

Special issue: Gender and Party Politics

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Regendering party politics: An introduction

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This special issue – *Re-gendering Party Politics* – pays tribute to the 1993 classic book *Gender and Party Politics (GPP)*, a collection of essays edited by Joni Lovenduski and Pippa Norris (Lovenduski and Norris, 1993). The aim of their volume was to explain how gender has affected party politics and how the imperatives of party politics influence the patterns of women's political representation (Lovenduski, 1995: 3). The book offered 'detailed and up-to-date accounts of developments in 11 countries' and demonstrated 'the complexity of the party systems through which feminists are pursuing political change (*Party Politics*)'.¹ *GPP* was rightly lauded in a review published in *Political Studies* for establishing 'a significant framework for future research in this underdeveloped area of political study'. Organized by country specific chapters, *GPP* delivered rich accounts of women's participation in the party political process (*Political Quarterly*). The introduction and conclusion augmented these, having already and comprehensively informed each chapter's approach, to provide substantial systematic comparison – in this, it was regarded as a model 'of what an edited collection of essays of this kind should be' (*Democratization*). It is no over-exaggeration to say that it influenced the subsequent generations of politics and gender scholars, a resource many of us picked up as the first port of call and an early key text for the teaching of comparative gender and politics.

Re-reading *GPP*, we are struck by just how much of the contemporary foci of gender and politics research – political recruitment and political careers, descriptive representation and gender quotas, substantive and symbolic representation, framing – were addressed back then in ways that revealed their interconnections rather than treating them as discrete areas of research. *GPP* has aged rather

well. Lovenduski's statement that (Lovenduski, 1995, cited in Krook and Childs, 2010: 83) 'an implicit goal of feminist infiltration of parties is to secure changes in attitudes about gender, mainly by increases in understanding and awareness of gender differences and their implications for power relations', made clear that women's engagement with political parties was never just about the simple inclusion of women – the first dimension of feminization (Lovenduski, 2005) – but also about feminizing parties' programmes and by implication governments, the second dimension of feminization. Diversity among women was acknowledged: Norris and Lovenduski write that 'feminists have disagreed sharply about the nature of women's interests', reminding us that the recognition of women's heterogeneity is not so very recent concern. Similarly, its reflections on the determinants of political change underpin the contemporary institutional turn (feminist and discursive) in gender and politics research. Women's agency – or more precisely feminists' agency – is centred (see Dahlerup and Leyenaar, 2013). As the review published in *Democratization* emphasized: 'You [women] won't get anything, if you don't go on demanding it'. Encouragingly, *GPP* offered a rosy future with its 'generally encouraging message, in highlighting women's continuous, if uneven, political advance'.

This special issue, coming some 20 years on, explores how gender continues to fundamentally shape the formal

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and informal institutions, norms and practices of contemporary political parties. It reaches across country borders to explore common themes and issues. Adopting a thematic rather than country case study approach, the collection picks up on some of the key concerns of GPP, with the aim to provide comparative research in a single place.

The authors in this special issue were tasked to address some of the key concerns first identified in GPP that remain salient today in order to analyse how gender shapes parties' form, function and activities in respect of the electorate, party ideologies, patterns of political recruitment and women's and men's political careers once elected. Collectively, the articles expose how parties are not gender neutral but based on a complex web of formal and informal norms and practices, the impact of which is differential for women and men and ethnic and sexual minorities (Krook and Nugent; Allen in this issue). Furthermore, the special issue foregrounds key feminist contributions to the study of party politics, with articles on gender-based political organizing (Childs and Kittilson in this issue), namely women's sections of political parties and on the relationship of parties and women's movements (Evans in this issue, for example). Importantly, it resists the temptation to study political parties as insular nation-state specific phenomena by studying them also in the context of European Union (EU) party politics (Kantola and Rolandsen Agustín in this issue).

In mapping and evaluating the analytic frameworks and approaches of feminist political science on political parties and party politics, this special issue offers comparative party scholars new – and we would argue – better ways to study party politics. Feminist re-conceptualizations of descriptive and substantive, constitutive and symbolic representation (Celis et al., 2008, 2014; Childs and Lovenduski, 2013; Lombardo and Meier, 2014; Saward, 2010; Squires, 2008), the notion of women's interests and issues (Schwindt-Bayer and Taylor-Robinson, 2011), of 'feminist' and 'feminized' parties (Childs, 2008; Young, 2000) and feminist institutionalism (Bjarnegård, 2013; Kenny, 2013; Krook and Mackay, 2011) will help to capture the characteristics and features of particular parties. They should also ensure that the determinants of party and party system change are fully explicated.

Theoretically, this special issue draws upon one of the key debate that dominates the study of gender and party politics today, namely, that of descriptive and substantive representation. Women's entry in to electoral politics as elected representatives over the last two decades – and the changing patterns in the number of women MPs across the globe – has probably been the most significant interest by gender and politics scholars. It is in the study of descriptive representation that feminist scholars have made particular progress in documenting and understanding feminized change and resistance. Single case studies abound, updated after each election, although there are some regions and

countries where research is more limited. Large N studies are becoming more frequent, not least as the benefits of quantitative studies to feminist political science become acknowledged (Paxton and Hughes, 2016). In relation to descriptive representation, research variously investigates: the processes of political recruitment and candidate selection (Bjarnegård, 2013; Kenny, 2013; Norris and Lovenduski, 1995), measures to enhance and or guarantee balanced representation, especially sex quotas (Celis et al., 2011; Dahlerup, 2006; Franceschet et al., 2012; Kittilson and Schwindt-Bayer, 2012; Krook, 2009; Murray, 2010), gender gaps in voting as dynamics for greater women's political presence (Campbell, 2006; Dahlerup and Leyenaar, 2013) and the relationship between descriptive representatives and party modernization (Childs, 2008; Lovenduski, 2005). That said, gendered inequalities in descriptive representation remain, and hence its study will continue to be a subject of gender and politics scholarship.

Substantive representation – 'acting for women' – is the second key strand of gender and party politics research (Celis et al., 2014). The study of the substantive representation of women frequently focuses on acts within legislative institutions. But it also takes place within parties and often leads into questions about the deeper interaction between gender and party politics and the ways in which gender affects parties as organizations and political actors, just as *GPP* highlighted some time ago. Women's issues and interests (Celis et al., 2014) are shown to be addressed – frequently explicitly as well as implicitly – in party manifestos and governmental programmes and discussed in relation to internal party rules and practices. Such a feminization of parties increasingly pertains to parties across the political spectrum rather than being the reserve of parties of the left (Childs and Webb, 2012; Lovenduski, 2005; Wiliarty, 2010). Parties are found to be both gendered and gendering, as institutional sexism shapes party structures (Childs and Webb, 2012; Kittilson, 2006, 2013); their formal and informal rules and norms frequently reinforce the power of dominant players in politics, traditionally men (Lovenduski, 2005) but are nonetheless capable of being regendered (Beckwith, 2005). Newer feminist party research speaks explicitly to current comparative party scholarship, such as intra-party democracy (IPD) and party regulation (Childs, 2013a, 2013b; Cross and Katz, 2013). If anything, the substantial literature on political parties coming out of the politics and gender literature stands rather starkly opposed to the rather limited attention comparative party politics scholars have given to gender in the same time period.

At the same time, we are acutely aware of how the recent developments in gender and politics and feminist theory further expand this field of study and its methodological and theoretical approaches (Dahlerup and Leyenaar, 2013; Galligan, 2015; Randall, 2015). This indeed illustrates both the growth and the strength of the field of gender

and politics. The special issue does not, most notably, address the specific issues of the decline of parties, presidentialization, parties and the media, and the rise of anti-women parties (Spierings et al., 2015). Political science remains a male-dominated and masculinized discipline, even as gender and politics scholarship has burgeoned in the last decade or so. Still, there are not enough of us to study all that we want and need to study. The study of masculinity and party politics and symbolic representation is only just, belatedly, emerging, being instigated by feminist researchers. Feminist research into party politics has the tendency to mirror more mainstream debates and often draws upon positivist and realist theories and methods to study women and gender in party politics. This has signified a paucity of studies that would approach political parties through deconstructionist or even post-deconstructionist perspectives popular in feminist theory (Kantola and Lombardo, 2017; Maignashca et al., 2016). Such approaches would draw attention broader discursive contexts and sifts, and the material, emotional and affective conditions that shape gender and party politics and could help to understand, for example, the rise of the populist left and right parties in Europe.

Against the backdrop of right-wing parties increasingly making efforts to integrate women's concerns, Erzeel and Celis ask whether ideology still counts as a reliable indicator for women's substantive representation. Ideology remains a key explanation for women's substantive representation, they conclude, but within the 'left-wing' and the 'right-wing' blocks there is a great deal of variety. The latter can be understood when it is acknowledged that parties from the same family can position themselves differently along various ideological dimensions. Furthermore, ideology is especially key in explaining feminist interests, but less so in the case of women's interests.

Campbell zooms in on the linkage between parties and voters. She shows that parties' conception of women voters and the way in which they respond to that conception is key in whether the linkage is long-lasting with the women voter seen as part of their core constituency of voters or ad hoc with women voters perceived as a 'special' interest group that pop on and off the political agenda. Campbell conducts two cases studies on the influence of gendered news frames on party policy and inter-party competition in the United States and Great Britain and from there builds an analytic framework to assess how parties' respond to portrayals of women voters and why in that particular way.

Krook and Nugent analyse the selection of female and minority candidates in the British case thereby focusing in on the labour party. In the labour party, the debates about female and ethnic minority candidates have been the most extensive resulting also in the election of the most female and ethnic minority MPs compared to other parties. Gender and race interactively shape citizens' opportunities to stand for and win election and confirm that only 'tandem quotas'

result in positive outcomes for minority women. They hence show that enhancing group representation requires 'multiple-axis' thinking. Doing otherwise allows White male dominance to persist, leaving marginalized groups to fight among each other for the crumbs falling from the table.

Allen's article continues the focus on the UK labour party in order to examine women's participation at the executive level. Utilizing original data which track the careers of men and women from the same political generation he establishes that sex was not a driver of promotion across the period studied. In so doing, Allen challenges the discourse of the glass ceiling and points instead to the particular mix of critical actors and a political environment conducive to the appointment of more women to executive roles.

Childs and Kittilson turn their attention to party women's organizations, little studied in the last two decades. Two competing scenarios are suggested in the extant literature: (1) that contemporary party member women's organizations have become sites for the substantive representation of women and (2) that in an era of greater IPD and party professionalization party women's organizations are in decline. Based on new European data, Childs and Kittilson find that almost half of the parties – notably, the traditional parties – has a party member women's organization, refuting claims of their demise. They also find little evidence of marginalization, suggesting that party women's organization are indeed potential sites for the substantive representation of women.

Evans focuses on the relationship between the women's movement and political parties in the United Kingdom and the United States. In both contexts, the feminist movement has traditionally positioned themselves at some distance from political parties and electoral politics and opted for more autonomous forms of organizing. Evans draws on a qualitative interview material, showing that although some of these suspicious attitudes remain, women's organizations also recognize the importance of working with political parties and especially with individual politicians. These engagements are strongly shaped by party ideology and the form of feminism the organization adopts.

Kantola and Rolandsen Agustin explore under researched terrain: gender and party politics in the EU. They explore the political dynamics of the European Parliament's seven party groups in relation to two contemporary policy issues, the economic crisis and the sexual and reproductive health and rights. Their findings show that shared constructions about gender equality are issue specific and change over time. Consensus breaks down along the left right axis and, at the same time, internal divisions within party groups impact upon policy output. This helps to explain the ups and downs of EU gender policy.

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1. <http://www.amazon.co.uk/Gender-Party-Politics-Joni-Lovenduski/dp/0803986602>

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Sarah Childs is professor of Politics and Gender at the University of Bristol, UK. She has published widely on women's political representation over the last decade or so. Her research expertise centres on descriptive and substantive representation, the concept of critical mass, political parties and parliaments, and conservatism, gender and representation. Prof Childs is currently researching feminized institutions with the UK Parliament and political parties. Key articles have been published in *Political Studies*, *Politics and Gender*, *Parliamentary Affairs* and *Party Politics*. In 2015 she published two co-edited books *Gender, Conservatism and Representation* and *Deeds and Words* with ECPR press, with Celis and Campbell respectively. Her most recent monograph is *Sex, Gender and the Conservative Party: From Iron Lady to Kitten Heels*, 2012, with Paul Webb, Palgrave. In 2009-10 Prof Childs was the gender Special Adviser to the UK Parliament's 'Speaker' Conference' on representation and in 2014 the Special

Adviser to the All Party Parliamentary Group, Women in Parliament Inquiry. In 2015 she received the Political Studies Association 'Special Recognition Award' for her work on women's representation. Having been 'embedded' in the UK House of Commons, she has just published a report, 'The Good Parliament' outlining necessary reforms to deliver a diversity sensitive UK Parliament.

Johanna Kantola is academy research fellow in Gender Studies at the University of Helsinki where she also holds a permanent position as Senior Lecturer. Her research focuses on political parties and institutions, gender equality policies, the European Union, and theoretical questions of representation and intersectionality. Her books include *Gender and Political Analysis* (with Emanuela Lombardo, Palgrave, 2016), *Gender and the European Union* (Palgrave, 2010) and *Feminists Theorize the State* (Palgrave, 2006). As an editor she has published *The Oxford Handbook on Gender and Politics* (Oxford University Press, 2013, with Georgina Waylen, Karen Celis and Laurel Weldon) and *Changing State Feminism* (Palgrave, 2007, with Joyce Outshoorn). She is the Editor of Palgrave Macmillan's *Gender and Politics Book Series* with Sarah Childs.

Political parties, ideology and the substantive representation of women

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Abstract

The recent finding that right-wing parties increasingly make efforts to integrate women's concerns raises questions as to whether ideology still counts as a reliable indicator for women's substantive representation and how different party contexts shape opportunities for the articulation of women's interests. This article therefore critically reassesses how ideology defines the opportunities for women's substantive representation, based on a comparative study of legislators' acting on behalf of women in 14 European countries. We argue that ideology still offers an important explanation for women's substantive representation, but that the link between the two should be conceptualized as complex rather than straightforward. The role of ideology is best understood if scholars (1) adopt an understanding of 'ideology' that allows for more variation and is conceptually different from 'party', (2) differentiate between gendered interests and feminist interests and (3) understand the impact of ideology as both direct and mediated.

Keywords

comparative research, gender, ideology, substantive representation, women's political representation

Introduction

This article critically reassesses a general assumption present in many studies of gender and party politics, notably that left-right ideology is an important explanation for women's political representation and that left-wing parties are more successful than right-wing parties in 'feminizing' the party. Left-wing ideologies traditionally attach more importance to guaranteeing social justice, which has encouraged left-wing parties to be the first to recruit female candidates, to connect with (progressive) women's movements and to support women-friendly policies (Ewig and Ferree, 2013; Kittilson, 2006; Lovenduski and Norris, 1993). However, studies suggest that right-wing parties are now also 'catching up' (Celis and Erzeel, 2015; Childs and Webb, 2012; Wiliarty, 2010). Already in 1993, Lovenduski and Norris found indications that various parties across the ideological spectrum made efforts to integrate women and their concerns, and their findings have only been corroborated ever since. Recent studies show that right-wing feminization efforts have at least in some parties reached beyond the symbolic level and have facilitated right-wing

women's access to elected assemblies and the articulation of (conservative) women's interests (Childs and Webb, 2012; Hien, 2014; Piccio, 2014; Piscopo, 2014; Rashkova and Zankina, 2014; Schreiber, 2008; Wiliarty, 2010). Because these studies are often case studies of one particular right-wing party at a time (Childs and Webb, 2012; Evans, 2011; Piccio, 2014; Wiliarty, 2010), we do not know yet how widespread right-wing feminization efforts really are. The few existing comparative studies reveal considerable variation between parties that traditionally fall under the banner of 'right-wing' parties, such as Christian democratic, liberal, conservative and radical right parties (Bashevkin, 1994; Celis and Childs, 2014; Celis and

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Erzeel, 2015), both in terms of how often they raise women's concerns and the type of claims they make.

The increased activity of right-wing parties nonetheless raises questions as to the validity of the original claim that the left offers a more favourable ideological venue for the articulation of women's interests and on the continuing impact of ideology on women's substantive representation. Studying the impact of ideology clearly becomes more complicated in such a context. When parties' efforts to represent women's interests spread across the ideological spectrum, it is important to scrutinize existing notions of ideology and to rethink the mechanisms through which ideology impacts upon women's substantive representation. At the same time, it also raises the need to identify additional factors that might in the end encourage (or discourage) left-wing *as well as* right-wing parties to articulate women's concerns, such as the presence of active women in the party and electoral considerations (Childs and Webb, 2012; Wiliarty, 2010).

This article therefore proposes a new explanatory model for assessing the role of ideology in women's substantive representation. This model starts from the premise that ideology still functions as an important indicator for women's substantive representation, but that both the notion of ideology and its expected impact should be conceptualized as complex rather than straightforward. This can be done by (1) adopting a more refined measurement of 'ideology' distinguishing between economic and post-materialist divisions, which allows for more variation between parties and which is conceptually different from party labels, (2) making a distinction within the broad category of women's substantive representation between the representation of feminist and gendered interests and (3) understanding the impact of ideology as both direct and mediated. We test this model by analysing new and original data from the comparative PARTIREP survey among legislators in 14 European countries. The comparative design of the survey allows us to examine the consistency and contingency of left-right differences in women's substantive representation across a variety of institutional settings.

In what follows, we first present the theoretical underpinnings of the proposed model. Then, we describe the methodology and the PARTIREP survey. Next, we present the results of our cross-national empirical study in 14 European countries, which confirm the new model. Finally, we discuss our findings in the conclusion.

Ideology and women's substantive representation: Towards a new model

If differences between left-wing and right-wing parties are disappearing, one might be tempted to conclude that the role of ideology as an indicator for women's substantive representation is in decline. Such conclusions, however, should not be drawn too hastily. At the heart of many

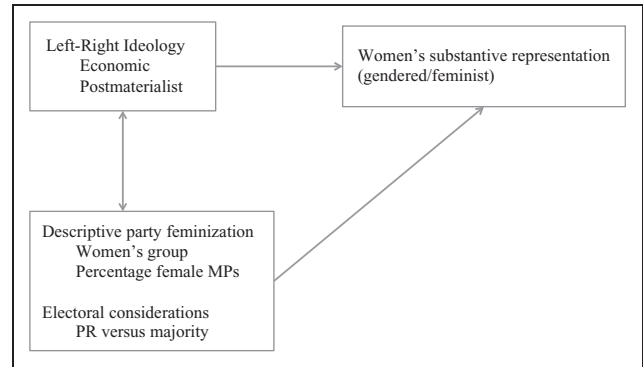


Figure 1. Impact of ideology on women's substantive representation: theoretical model.

findings lies a complex relationship between political parties, ideology and women's interests. This complexity relates to how scholars conceptualize the notion of ideology, the concept of women's substantive representation and the relationship between the two. We argue that (left-right) ideology might still offer an important explanation for women's substantive representation, but that a new theoretical model for assessing the role of ideology in women's substantive representation is needed (see Figure 1). This model is based on three premises, which we explain more in detail below.

The first premise is that any understanding of ideology should be conceptually differentiated from 'party' and should take different dimensions of ideology into account. Empirical studies of women's substantive representation often use party families as proxies for ideology (e.g. Celis and Erzeel, 2015; Kantola and Saari, 2014). This elision between ideology and party, however, is potentially tenuous. Ideologies are belief systems that are shared by members of a particular group (Van Dijk, 2006: 116). Although parties are often based on ideologies, ideologies as such do not include the societal structures that accommodate them (Van Dijk, 2006: 116). Whereas party labels can sometimes function as proxies for ideology in case-study research, they are often too crude indicators in comparative (either cross-national or longitudinal) studies. Party labels obscure a lot of ideological variation between parties and ignore the varying stance that parties might take on different ideological left-right scales.

Furthermore, a unidimensional account of ideology measured on a left-right continuum might not be enough to understand how ideology really influences women's political representation (Kittilson, 2006). More useful is a distinction between parties' positions on two ideological left-right dimensions. The first dimension relates to parties' stance on socio-economic issues and on the role of the government in these issues; the second scale relates to the post-materialist dimension and positions parties on ethical issues (abortion, euthanasia) and law and order issues. Both dimensions have a 'left' end and a 'right' end, and from

here onwards, we differentiate in that respect between 'economic left/right' and 'post-materialist left/right' ideologies. Parties towards the 'economic left' support an active role for the government in the economy, whereas parties towards the 'economic right' argue in favour of a reduced economic role for government. Parties towards the 'post-materialist' left in addition promote the expansion of individual freedoms on post-materialist issues, whereas parties on the 'post-materialist right' value order and tradition. We can expect that, in general, left-wing ideologies offer a more favourable context for the expression of women's interests than right-wing ideologies, but especially the post-materialist left-right dimension might steer parties' engagement with women's substantive representation. The reason for this is that gender issues appeared on the agenda as part of the post-materialist agenda in the 1970s (Hayes et al., 2000; Inglehart and Norris, 2003). The shift from materialist to post-materialist values led to a decline in class politics and brought new social movements concerned with egalitarianism, women's rights and feminism to the political arena. Left-wing parties that developed as part of this post-materialist agenda, such as green parties, have traditionally also devoted more attention to women's concerns than economic ('old') left parties, such as socialist parties (Kittilson, 2006). We therefore hypothesize that:

H1: A positioning more towards the left on the economic and post-materialist scale will lead to higher levels of women's substantive representation (H1a), but the effect of a left positioning on the post-materialist scale will be more outspoken than the effect of a left positioning on the economic scale (H1b).

The impact of ideology might furthermore not only depend on how scholars understand ideology but also on their understanding of 'women's substantive representation'. In that regard, Celis and Childs (2014) make an important distinction between the substantive representation of *feminist* interests and of *gendered* interests. The first category consists of claims that aim to transform existing gender roles in support of gender equality and social justice. It includes liberal/progressive feminist as well as conservative feminist viewpoints, which is relevant in a European context where women's movements have historically included both narratives (Offen, 1988). The second category includes claims that are about and for women, but are however not feminist in intent, and concern, for instance, material interests and non-feminist traditional women's interests and gender roles.¹ Feminist and gendered interests are thus the two subsets of women's interests and are both part of the substantive representation of women. This conception of women's substantive representation as including both feminist and gendered women's interests allows for a better understanding of the impact of ideology, and this is the second premise of the

theoretical model in Figure 1. Parties after all often differ in how they frame their representative claims. The egalitarian character of left-wing ideologies seems to offer a better fit with feminist ideologies, meaning that left-wing parties more often support feminist reforms, develop feminist legislation and endorse government intervention as a means for guaranteeing (gender) equality in social and welfare issues (Ewig and Ferree, 2013). Right-wing claims for women are less likely to be feminist in nature (Bashevkin, 1994), but can be gendered nonetheless (Celis and Childs, 2012; Childs and Webb, 2012; Curtin, 2014; Kantola and Saari, 2014; Murray and Sénac, 2014; Piscopo, 2014; Swers, 2002). In that sense, left-wing parties, and especially those adopting post-materialist leftist positions, might contribute to a *feminist* substantive representation of women, because of the closer ideological link between post-materialism and feminism (Hayes et al., 2000; Inglehart and Norris, 2003). We hypothesize that:

H2: A positioning more to the left on the two ideological scales will lead to higher levels of the substantive representation of *feminist* interests (H2a). The effect of a left positioning on the post-materialist scale will be more outspoken than the effect of a left positioning on the economic scale (H2b).

The third premise has to do with the (causal) link between ideology and women's substantive representation. Studies often assume that a direct link exists between ideology and women's substantive representation, but, as mentioned, ideology is not the only factor that encourages parties and legislators to represent women's interest. Other factors that play a role are the level of descriptive party feminization and parties' electoral considerations. These additional factors might themselves exert a direct impact on women's substantive representation, thereby mediating the effect of ideology.

First, we assume that women's substantive representation depends on the level of descriptive party feminization (Childs and Webb, 2012), that is, the organizational presence of a women's group and the percentage of female MPs in the parliamentary party group (PPG). Intra-party women's organizations have feminist/gender expertise and offer useful, accurate and 'first-hand' policy information on women's issues in their respective parties. When they are strong, they put pressure on parties to adopt women's interests (Kittilson, 2006; Lovenduski and Norris, 1993; Wiliarty, 2010). The numerical presence of elected women in addition sometimes gives leverage to women's case. Higher levels of left-wing activity on behalf of women found in many studies are at least partially related to the fact that left-wing parties were the first to witness an increase in the number of female MPs who are generally considered to be the most active defenders of women's case (Phillips, 1995). Efforts to increase the number of women

MPs have been made by right-wing parties as well (Kittilson, 2006; Lovenduski and Norris, 1993) and the increased presence of women can also create a favourable condition for the expression of women's interests in right-wing contexts (see for instance Bashevkin's (1994) study of Canada). We hypothesize that:

H3: The level of women's substantive representation (either feminist or gendered interests) will reach higher levels when the party has a women's organization.

H4: The level of women's substantive representation will reach higher levels when the percentage of women in the parliamentary party increases.

Finally, electoral competition might explain why parties represent women's interests. The electoral system determines how parties and individual MPs understand representation and define their constituencies (Norris, 2004), and holds cues on which electoral and legislative strategies representatives have to use. Electoral concerns can create possibilities or constraints for both left-wing parties and right-wing parties to represent women's interests. Relevant here is the distinction between majority/plurality systems and proportional systems. Representatives in the first group tend to be elected in small single-member districts, which encourage them to define constituents' interests primarily in geographical terms and not in social terms (Norris, 2004). In proportional systems, electoral districts are usually larger and more heterogeneous, leaving representatives with more room to promote (non-territorial) social groups' interests (Tremblay, 2006). We hypothesize that the following:

H5: The level of women's substantive representation will be higher under proportional rules than under majority/plurality rules.

Methodology

The analyses are based on new and original data from the 2008–2012 PARTIREP comparative MP survey (Deschouwer and Depauw, 2014). The survey was conducted among legislators in 14 national/federal parliaments (and 90 political parties) in Europe: Austria, Belgium, Germany, France, Hungary, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Spain, Switzerland and the United Kingdom. A team of international scholars from the 14 countries organized the survey. The questionnaire was kept constant across the different languages. Legislators typically received an introduction letter and email inviting them to fill in the questionnaire online. They were re-contacted at least twice, except for those who had explicitly stated that they refused to participate in the project. In the cases where response rates were disappointing, additional strategies were adopted, such as the use of telephone reminders or

face-to-face interviews, to increase the general response rates (Online Appendix 1). The use of a variety of methods depended on the international partners' estimation of 'best practices' in the past. There are no significant differences as to the percentage of male and female legislators responding to the survey. Because some left-wing parties are slightly over-represented in the data set, we apply a weighting to correct for party differences. We furthermore removed outliers (very small PPGs with less than three members) from the analyses.

The parliaments and parties in the survey were selected to represent a wide institutional variation in terms of electoral systems (proportional list systems, majority/plurality systems and mixed-member systems), party systems (parliaments with strong and weak left-wing parties) and variation in gender regimes (countries with varying levels of descriptive representation of women). The legislators in the survey also belong to a variety of party families, including socialist/social democratic, Christian democratic, liberal, conservative, green, populist, communist, agrarian, religious and single-issue parties. Several multilevel countries also include regionalist parties. The international experts who were involved in the organization of the survey were in charge of the categorization of parties according to party family.

Measuring women's substantive representation

Our operationalization of women's substantive representation makes a distinction between the substantive representation of gendered interests and the substantive representation of feminist interests as described above. In order to account for these issues, we use two different survey questions. The first question asks legislators how often they speak during meetings with your PPG "in order to signal/resolve a situation that they consider disadvantageous for women." Legislators could indicate on a 4-point ordinal scale whether they do this 'at least once every month' (score = 1), 'at least once every 3 months', 'at least once a year' or '(almost) never' (score = 4). The wording of the question does not favour a feminist orientation of women's interests, and is therefore appropriate to measure the substantive representation of gendered interests.

A second survey question consists of a number of attitudinal items measuring legislators' views on statements regarding gender equality. Two items ask about whether women are equal to men: 'On the whole, women and men enjoy real equality today' and 'Women's organizations are no longer necessary today'. Two items ask about whether the government should promote gender equality: 'Government should ensure that women and men have equal opportunities' and 'Affirmative action is a legitimate measure to address the under-representation of women in politics'. The respondents' positions with regard to these items, indicating whether they think gender equality *is* and *should be* realized, are used as an indication of whether legislators

have the *propensity* to represent women's interests in a *feminist way*. The underlying rationale is that establishing gender equality is key and common to all kinds of feminisms. Using this minimal criterion to identify feminist attitudes, they are open to various kinds of feminisms. Legislators were asked to indicate on a 5-point scale to what extent they agree with these items. The items were recoded so that high scores indicate a more feminist stance. Because the four items load on a single dimension, we bring them together in an additive 5-point 'feminist scale' (see Online Appendix 2).

Independent variables

In order to measure the left-right ideological stance of parties, we use a direct measurement of ideology based on data from the 2010 Chapel Hill expert survey (CHES) (Bakker et al., 2015). The CHES includes questions on parties' ideological positioning on two different left/right scales: parties' stance on economic issues and parties' stance on post-materialist issues ('democratic freedoms and rights' or 'GAL-TAN'). The first classifies parties based on whether 'parties want government to play an active role in the economy' (left) or 'parties emphasize a reduced economic role for government: privatization, lower taxes, less regulation, less government spending and a leaner welfare state' (right). The second classifies parties based on whether they 'favour expanded personal freedoms, for example, access to abortion, active euthanasia, same-sex marriage or greater democratic participation' (left) or whether they 'reject these ideas, they value order, tradition, and stability, and believe that the government should be a firm moral authority on social and cultural issues' (right) (Bakker et al., 2015: 144). For each question, country experts were asked to position each party in their country on a 11-point left-right scale with '0' implying an extreme left position, '5' a centre position and '10' an extreme right position. The correlation between the two ideological scales is only moderately strong (Pearson's $r = 0.564$, $p < 0.001$). Online Appendix 3 shows the descriptives for the two scales.

The operationalization of other variables included in the analyses is relatively straightforward. In order to measure descriptive party feminization, we use the percentage of women in the PPG and we dummy-coded whether or not a party has a women's section.² For the variable electoral competition, we make a distinction between 'proportional' electoral systems (score '1') and 'majority/plurality' systems (score '0'). The descriptives of the variables are also shown in Online Appendix 3.

Substantive representation of women, party families and left-right blocks

We now take a closer look at the empirical findings. Before testing our hypotheses, we first investigate whether our

Table 1. Legislators' speaking at PPG meetings, by party family (mean scores on 4-point item) ($N = 844$).

	Speaking on behalf of women in PPG Mean score (SD)
Parties in 'left' block	
Green/ecologist parties ($N = 33$)	2.52 (1.18)
Socialist/social democratic parties ($N = 310$)	2 (1.08)
Parties in 'right' block	
Christian democratic parties ($N = 143$)	1.64 (0.96)
Liberal parties ($N = 115$)	1.91 (0.99)
Conservative parties ($N = 185$)	1.62 (0.93)
Far right/anti-immigrant parties ($N = 33$)	1.94 (1)
Other ($N = 25$)	2 (1.06)
'Left' block ($N = 345$)	2.05 (1.2)
'Right' block ($N = 499$)	1.73 (0.98)

Note: SD: standard deviation. Only the largest party families are displayed as separate party families; the other parties are included in the category 'other'.

claim that the traditional groupings of parties in left or right blocks and in party families are too broad categories to fully understand the relationship between ideology and the substantive representation of women. Put differently, we first test whether we indeed need a more sophisticated operationalization of ideology to explain its relation to women's representation.

The PARTIREP survey first asked respondents to indicate how often they speak at meetings of their PPGs to signal a situation in society that they consider disadvantageous for women (see Table 1). A second question focused on legislators' position on four feminist items (combined in a feminist scale; see Table 2).

When asked about their speaking at PPG meetings on behalf of women, half of the group of legislators in our survey (52.3%) state that they (almost) never speak on behalf of women. In addition, 18.8% of the legislators indicate to speak at least once a year, 19.5% to speak at least once every 3 months and 9.4% to speak at least once a month. Respondents score on average 1.86 on this 4-point scale. Table 1 presents the mean scores and standard deviations by party family. At the bottom of the table, party families are used as proxies to group parties together in a 'left block' (i.e. green, socialist, communist and smaller leftist parties) and a 'right block' (i.e. Christian democratic, liberal, conservative, far right and smaller rightist parties). It is clear that the left block offers a more favourable platform for the articulation of gendered interests than the right holds. On average, legislators from parties in the left block speak more frequently on behalf of women in the PPG ($M = 2.05$) than legislators from parties in the right block

Table 2. Legislators' mean scores on gender equality items, by party family (5-point items).

	Feminist scale Mean (SD)	Women and men real equality (inverse) Mean	Government should ensure equal opportunities Mean	Affirmative action legitimate measure Mean	Women's group no longer necessary (inverse) Mean
Parties in 'left' block					
Green/ecologist	4.24 (0.52)	3.76	4.49	4.19	4.49
Socialist/social democratic	3.99 (0.63)	3.64	4.28	3.92	4.13
Parties in 'right' block					
Christian democratic	3.18 (0.73)	2.61	3.64	3	3.47
Liberal	3.24 (0.68)	2.84	3.90	2.89	3.35
Conservative	3.27 (0.7)	2.95	3.79	2.88	3.47
Far right/anti-immigrant	2.86 (0.83)	2.51	3.82	2.19	2.92
Other	3.55 (0.7)	3.22	4.11	3.25	3.61
Left block	4.02 (0.62)	3.66	4.29	3.94	4.15
Right block	3.21 (0.72)	2.79	3.79	2.88	3.4
N	844	856	853	857	858

Note: SD: standard deviation. Differences between the left block and the right block are significant after *t*-test. Feminist scale $t(836) = -16.891, p < 0.001$. Item 'Men and women enjoy real equality' $t(848) = -12.286, p < 0.001$. Item 'Government equal opportunities' $t(845) = -8.188, p < 0.001$. Item 'Affirmative action legitimate' $t(849) = -14.778, p < 0.001$. Item 'Women's groups no longer necessary' $t(850) = -11.256, p < 0.001$.

($M = 1.73$). These differences are significant after *t* test ($t[836] = -4.496, p < 0.001$).

However, considerable variation also exists within the left block and within the right block. A one-way analysis of variance revealed significant differences between party families ($F[6, 836] = 6.38, p < 0.001$). Legislators in green parties are distinctly more likely to speak for women than legislators of any other party family. Important variation exists between party families traditionally positioned in the right block: respondents from liberal and far right parties are reportedly more active than those in Christian democratic and conservative parties. Moreover, post hoc comparisons using the Tukey honest significant difference (HSD)³ revealed no significant differences between socialist parties and liberal and far right parties. Although we have to be careful not to overestimate the results, the results show that important variation exists between and within parties traditionally positioned in the left block and parties traditionally positioned in the right block.⁴

Turning to the second survey question measuring legislators' attitudes on feminist items, Table 2 shows very strong and significant differences between party families (after one-way analysis of variance, $F[6, 837] = 49.97, p < 0.001$). The green parties again show the highest mean scores, closely followed by the socialist parties. Post hoc comparisons using the Tukey HSD showed that, for each of the items in Table 2, green and socialist legislators present significantly higher mean scores than the other parties: they are less convinced that men and women enjoy real equality and that women's organizations are no longer necessary, and they are more convinced that government should ensure that women and men experience equal opportunities and that affirmative action is a legitimate measure to address the under-representation of women. Legislators in

parties traditionally positioned in the left block are thus clearly more attitudinally predisposed to represent *feminist* concerns than those in the right block.

Contrary to the findings in Table 1, differences between the left block and the right block are far more clear-cut in Table 2. Green and socialist parties differ most from other parties in their opinion on the affirmative action item. This is in line with findings that affirmative action is an issue that is deeply entrenched in the left-right divide in Europe (Erzeel and Caluwaerts, 2013): right-wing parties favour slow track solutions and individual efforts to end gender inequalities in politics, whereas left-wing parties support fast track and collective solutions improving the status of women as a group. Intra-block differences clearly also exist (far right parties are for instance less feminist than other parties on the right), but contrary to the results in Table 1, these are less important than differences between ideological blocks.

Based on this first analysis, we conclude that if we want to understand how ideology influences women's representation, the traditional grouping of parties in families and left-right blocks is not entirely satisfying. The inter-family and intra-block variation illustrated by the two tables above indicates that in order to fully understand the relationship between ideology and women's substantive representation, we need a more sophisticated measurement of ideology. To that end, the next section tests the hypotheses formulated in the theoretical framework.

Testing the model

In the theoretical framework, we hypothesized that legislators' engagement with women's substantive representation might be related to a number of factors, including parties'

Table 3. Bivariate correlations between the dependent variables and the hypothesized explanatory factors.

	Speaking on behalf of women in PPG	Feminist scale
Left-Right stance on economic issues	−0.136**	−0.418**
Left-Right stance on post-materialist issues	−0.147**	−0.441**
Presence of a women's group (yes = 1)	0.067	0.106*
% of women in PPG	0.145**	0.364**
Electoral system (Proportional = 1)	0.125**	0.040

Note: Correlations for 'speaking on behalf of women in the PPG' are Spearman's rho; correlations for 'Feminist scale' are Pearson's *r*.

***p* < 0.001; **p* < 0.01; *p* < 0.05.

ideological environment, levels of party feminization and electoral incentives. As a first test of the hypotheses, Table 3 presents the bivariate relationships between the (explanatory) factors on the one hand and legislators' speaking on behalf of women in the PPG and legislators' feminist attitudes (based on their attitudes concerning gender equality) on the other hand. The two ideological scales (the economic left-right scale and the post-materialist left-right scale) show significant correlations with legislators' speaking on behalf of women in the PPG and their feminist attitudes (H1a). The correlations are negative, indicating that when parties' scores move to the right, legislators are less encouraged to represent women's interests. Our related hypothesis (H1b) was that parties' stance on post-materialist issues would be more strongly linked to women's substantive representation than parties' stance on economic issues. This hypothesis is only weakly confirmed in this first bivariate analysis. The correlation coefficients for the post-materialist scale are only slightly higher than the correlation coefficients for the economic scale. Comparing the two dependent variables, we do see that the correlations are clearly stronger for the feminist scale, and this finding is in accordance with our second hypothesis (H2a), namely that left-wing ideologies especially contribute to a feminist substantive representation.

Regarding the influence of descriptive party feminization, we expected that the presence of a women's group and an increase in the percentage of women in the PPG would be associated with higher levels of women's substantive representation. Higher percentages of women in the PPG indeed go hand in hand with higher levels of speaking for women in the PPG and with feminist attitudes (H4). However, parties with a women's group do not overall appear to be more hospitable to women's substantive representation than parties without such women's groups (although there is a weak positive

correlation between the presence of a women's group and more feminist attitudes; H3). Finally, in terms of electoral considerations, we find that legislators' belonging to a proportional electoral system is associated with higher levels of speaking for women in the PPG, but not with a display of more feminist attitudes (H5).

Next, we test whether these bivariate correlations hold in a multivariate model. Tables 4 shows the results for the analysis with legislators speaking in the PPG as a dependent variable. We conduct a multinomial logistic regression analysis, for which we recoded the original variable with four categories into a new variable with three categories: 'frequent actors' (i.e. those who speak 'at least once every three months' or 'at least once every month' on behalf of women), 'occasional actors' (i.e. those who speak 'at least once a year') and 'non-actors' (those who speak 'almost never'). This was done because the category of respondents who 'speak at least once every month' was too small to keep it as a separate category and would produce unstable results in a logistic regression. Of all respondents (*N* = 844), 244 (28.9%) were identified as frequent actors, 159 (18.8%) as occasional actors and 441 (52.3%) as non-actors. The category of non-actors functions as a reference category.

The results in Table 4 are presented in a stepwise model. The first model tests the impact of ideology and includes only two independent variables – the economic left-right scale and the post-materialist left-right scale – and a number of control variables. The control variables are the following: legislators' sex (dummy), age⁵ (in years) and seniority⁶ (in years, log transformed), and a dummy variable distinguishing between majority and opposition parties. In the second model, we include the other three independent variables: the percentage of women in the PPG, a dummy for whether or not a party has a women's group and a dummy distinguishing between PR and majority/plurality electoral systems. This second model allows us on the one hand to test whether these three variables exert a direct and independent impact. On the other hand, it permits us to test whether the inclusion of the variables changes the regression coefficients for the two ideological scales. If the B-coefficients of the two ideological scales diminish or disappear, we can say that ideological differences between parties are partly or entirely the result of differences in feminization levels or electoral considerations of parties, and that the impact of ideology is mostly *indirect*. If the B-coefficients of the two ideological scales remain strong and significant, we can conclude that ideology has a *direct* influence on women's substantive representation.

Because individual MPs are nested in PPGs and in parliaments, the data are (potentially) hierarchically clustered, which is why we calculated the robust standard errors. Ideally, we would have performed a multilevel logistic

Table 4. Multinomial logistic regression explaining legislators' speaking on behalf of women, with clustered robust standard errors (Reference category = Non-actors; $N = 811$).

	Model 1 B (SE)		Model 2 B (SE)	
	Occasional actors B (SE)	Frequent actors B (SE)	Occasional actors B (SE)	Frequent actors B (SE)
Intercept	-1.707 (0.611)**	0.012 (0.519)	-0.733 (0.804)	0.188 (0.7)
Left-right economic	0.019 (0.059)	-0.004 (0.048)	-0.012 (0.064)	-0.026 (0.051)
Left-Right post-materialist	-0.077 (0.059)	-0.129 (0.046)**	-0.116 (0.062)	-0.12 (0.05)*
Presence women's group (Ref = yes)			0.051 (0.245)	-0.258 (0.202)
% women in PPG			-0.016 (0.008)*	-0.005 (0.008)
Electoral system (Ref = PR)			-0.469 (0.246)	-0.764 (0.237)**
MPs' sex (Ref = woman)	-0.872 (0.223)**	-1.19 (0.189)**	-0.96 (0.229)**	-1.124 (0.198)**
Seniority (log)	0.318 (0.454)	0.738 (0.415)	0.357 (0.459)	0.855 (0.425)
Age	0.024 (0.011)*	-0.002 (0.009)	0.023 (0.011)*	0.001 (0.01)
Government (Ref = government)	0.304 (0.197)	0.581 (0.179)**	0.304 (0.212)	0.680 (0.202)**
Nagelkerke R^2	0.113		0.135	

*** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$.

Table 5. Interaction effect between left-right economic scale and MPs' sex, with clustered robust standard errors (Reference category = Non-actors; $N = 811$).

	Model 3 B (SE)	
	Occasional actors B (SE)	Frequent actors B (SE)
Intercept	-0.004 (0.867)	0.886 (0.746)
Left-Right economic	-0.161 (0.099)	-0.173 (0.078)*
MPs' sex (Ref = woman)	-1.943 (0.546)**	-2.106 (0.462)**
Left-right*MPs sex	0.202 (0.108)	0.206 (0.088)*
Nagelkerke R^2	0.144	

Note: The following variables are also included in the model, but are not shown here: Left-Right post-materialism, Presence of women's group, % of women in PPG, Electoral system, Seniority (log), Age and Government. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$.

analysis to account for the (potential) hierarchical clustering of the data, but this was not possible because of the small number of cases at the highest level ($N = 14$).

The results in models 1 and 2 show that ideological differences exist in women's substantive representation, but that only the post-materialist left-right scale has a significant effect (and only for the category of frequent actors). The odds of speaking frequently on behalf of women decrease when parties hold more right-wing views on post-materialist issues. The economic left-right scale has no direct independent effect: legislators' odds of speaking for women do not increase in parties with economically leftist ideologies once we control for other variables. This finding confirms the hypothesis that it is especially the post-materialist left-right divide that informs parties' opportunities to represent women's interests (H1b).

The explanatory power of model 1 is not very high (R^2 of 0.113) and the two ideological scales alone account only for 2.8% of the variation in the dependent variable, which is not surprising given that only a small number of independent variables are included and given that the left-right gap was not that strong to begin with (see Table 3). The variable 'MPs sex', and not ideology, has the strongest effect in model 1. When we include the other three independent variables in model 2, we find that the R^2 increases only marginally (to 0.135). Party feminization and electoral system design account for a very small part of the variation in the dependent variable. The electoral system has the strongest direct effect, but only for frequent actors: legislators under PR rules are more likely than their colleagues under majority rules to frequently raise women's concerns in the PPG (H5).

The independent effect of the post-materialist left-right scale, furthermore, hardly decreases in model 2 when we include the other three independent variables. As mentioned above this means that post-materialist left-right ideology influences legislators' acting on behalf of women in a direct manner. The effect of economic left-right ideology is on the other hand mediated by legislators' gender, as the interaction effect in Table 5 points out. A move towards the right on the economic scale leads to a decrease in the odds of speaking for women, but *only* for female legislators. The behaviour of male legislators remains unaffected by the parties' positioning on the economic left-right scale. These findings thus only partially confirm the findings briefly discussed in the introduction that right-wing parties also substantively represent women. The inclusion of women and gendered concerns in rightist parties does not put them at the same level of more leftist parties when it comes to the substantive representation of women.

Table 6. OLS regression explaining legislators' position on the feminist scale, with clustered robust standard errors ($N = 813$).

	Model 1 B (SE)	Model 2 B (SE)
Intercept	4.232 (0.144)***	3.915 (0.174)***
Left-Right economic	-0.095 (0.016)***	-0.087 (0.016)***
Left-Right post-materialist	-0.103 (0.014)***	-0.094 (0.015)***
Presence women's group (yes = 1)		-0.082 (0.055)
% women in PPG		0.007 (0.002)***
Electoral system (PR = 1)		-0.047 (0.062)
MPs' sex (woman = 1)	0.415 (0.05)***	0.373 (0.052)***
Seniority (log)	0.194 (0.104)	0.203 (0.106)*
Age	0.001 (0.003)	0.002 (0.003)
Government (= 1)	-0.023 (0.049)	0.01 (0.05)
Adjusted R^2	0.315	0.325

Note: Multi-collinearity is not a problem: highest VIF score = 1.997, lowest tolerance score = 0.501 ('% women in PPG') in model 2.

*** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$.

Because several of the independent variables correlate (weakly) in model 2, we run a test for multi-collinearity by calculating the VIF scores and tolerance scores. In general, it is assumed that there is evidence of multi-collinearity when the lowest tolerance is less than 0.10 and the highest VIF score is more than 10 (Hair et al., 1995). In our analyses, we found that the highest VIF score is 1.994, and the lowest tolerance score is 0.502 ('% women in PPG'), so multi-collinearity does not pose a problem.

We now turn to the analysis with the feminist scale as a dependent variable. Table 6 shows the results of a stepwise Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression analysis. Model 1 is again the model of reference with the two left-right ideological scales as independent variables and legislators' sex, age, seniority and parties in government/opposition as control variables. In model 2, we add the independent variables measuring party feminization and electoral considerations. We again clustered the standard errors to account for the fact that individuals are nested in PPGs and in parliaments.

A couple of observations stand out. First, the R^2 of the first model in Table 6 is already quite high: 31.5% of the variation in legislators' feminist attitudes can be explained by the variables included in the first model, and 26.3% by the two ideological scales alone. This is in sharp contrast to the relatively low R^2 of the first model in Table 4, where the ideological scales accounted for less than 3% of the variation in legislators' speaking for women in the PPG. In line with our hypotheses, we find that a positioning towards the left on the two ideological scales leads legislators to adopt more feminist attitudes (H2a). This confirms that left-right ideology is a very good indicator for a *feminist* substantive representation of women. Contrary to the analysis in Table 4, we furthermore see that both ideological scales have an independent impact on the feminist scale, although the

effect of parties' positioning on the post-materialist left-right scale is again somewhat stronger than parties' positioning on the economic left-right scale (H2b). Female legislators present a higher score on the feminist scale than men and an increase in the numerical presence of women also encourages legislators to take a more feminist stance on gender issues. Compared to model 1 in Table 6, the R^2 in model 2 increases, but the independent effects of the two ideological scales do not disappear (although they diminish). Differences in ideology continue to exist, and these are only partially attributable to differences in party feminization and electoral competition.

Conclusion

Already in 1993, Joni Lovenduski and Pippa Norris noted in their seminal work on 'Gender and Party Politics' that various parties across the ideological spectrum had started to make efforts to integrate women's concerns. Now, 20 years later, this article studied whether ideology (still) offers an important and strong explanation for women's substantive representation across Europe and how different party contexts shape opportunities for the representation of women's interests. Based on a comparative study of legislators' acting on behalf of women in 14 European countries, we found that left-wing ideologies in general still offer more favourable venues for the representation of women's interests than right-wing ideologies, but not in every country. A lot of variation nevertheless exists within the 'left-wing' and 'right-wing' block. In order to understand this variation, we proposed a new theoretical model. We first of all maintained a clear distinction between party and ideology, and found that an ideological positioning towards the left led to higher levels of substantive representation of women only when we measured parties' positioning on post-materialist issues. Ideology thus still explains variation between parties in women's substantive representation, but the impact depends on which dimension of ideology is studied. In addition, we differentiated between the substantive representation of gendered and feminist interests and showed that ideology offers a strong explanation for a feminist substantive representation but loses importance when applied to broader conceptions of women's substantive representation. This is in line with previous results that left-wing and right-wing parties do not so much differ in how often they raise women's concerns, but *especially* in how they frame their representative claims (see Celis and Childs, 2012).

Ideology is thus still of great importance for women's substantive representation. Our study however shows that the picture is at the same time also more contingent and complex: ideology does not neatly map onto parties; whether ideology has an impact differs in terms of what kind of women's representation one has in mind; and only specific features of an ideology impacts on women's

representation. Our study furthermore shows that ideology is not the only thing that matters. Legislators' acting on behalf of women is also influenced by legislators' individual characteristics, electoral strategies and (to a lesser extent) political opportunities. Legislators in both left-wing and right-wing parties receive incentives under proportional electoral rules, and disincentives under majority/plurality rules, to represent women's interests. The level of feminist substantive representation increased when the percentage of women in the PPG increased (but the presence of an intra-party women's organization had no effect).

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Supplemental material

The online [appendices/data supplements/etc] are available at <http://ppq.sagepub.com/supplemental>.

Notes

1. This approach is distinct from other conceptualisations of feminism and of women's substantive representation in two respects. First, for Schreiber (2008), claims that explicitly support a traditional role for women as wives or mothers are 'gendered', but not 'feminist' (Schreiber, 2008). In our analysis, in contrast, claims on women's roles as wives or mothers can at least in theory be feminist provided that they support gender equality and social justice. Secondly, we include a category of gendered/non-feminist interests as part of the substantive representation of women. This interpretation is rejected by some scholars who argue that women's substantive representation is by definition feminist because it is about breaking male dominance (Dahlerup, 2014). We thank the anonymous reviewers for pointing this out.
2. This was based on a coding of the parties' official websites. As such, we measure whether or not parties recognize women's groups as being part of the party, but we do not measure the strength and influence of women's groups.
3. Tukey was chosen because we compare more than three groups (Roberts and Russo, 1999).
4. The contingent nature of party differences in women's substantive representation also manifests itself when we compared party families by country (not shown here).
5. We control for age because younger people might be more likely to support egalitarian attitudes towards gender roles in society (Inglehart and Norris, 2003).

6. We control for seniority because legislators' seniority or newcomer status might influence their overall agenda-setting power.

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Representing women voters: The role of the gender gap and the response of political parties

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Abstract

While analysis of the relationship between the descriptive and substantive representation of women has mainly focused on women politicians as critical actors in many contexts political parties provide *the* linkage between voters' preferences and policy programmes. The manner in which political parties respond to women voters is shaped by both the information they receive about women voters' preferences, from the news media, pollsters and other sources, and by gendered party type. Analysis of parties' attempts to target women voters can help us understand whether parties perceive women as typical or average voters. I conduct two case studies on the influence of gendered newsframes on party policy and inter-party competition in the United States and Great Britain to formulate a preliminary analytic framework designed to facilitate research to assess how parties' responses to portrayals of women voters vary according to institutional and contextual factors across time and space.

Keywords

gender gap, newsframes, voting behaviour

'When we're dealing with a gender-gap issue, there are two ways of looking at it – superficially through a public relations campaign or substantively through legislation' Congresswoman Schneider (cited in Abzug, 1984: 138)

Introduction

The core intention of this article is to provide a preliminary analytic framework capable of comparative application, to apply to the question, 'is the electoral linkage between political parties and women voters deep-rooted and central to electoral campaigns, or, on the contrary, superficial, ad hoc and volatile?' Two illustrative case studies are used to set out an innovative research agenda for extensive, in-depth, collaborative work to compare the response of parties – across time and space – to gendered representations of voters.

The majority of the extensive research undertaken by feminist political science on the link between the descriptive and substantive representation of women has focused on the role of women/feminist politicians as critical actors (Celis and Childs, 2011; Celis et al., 2008; Childs, 2007; Dovi, 2002, 2007; Mansbridge, 2003; Phillips, 1995;

Wängnerud, 2000). However, in many contexts, political parties provide *the* linkage between voters' preferences on the one hand and policy programmes on the other; critical actors serve as intermediaries who attempt to convince party elites to incorporate women's interests into their policy programmes. Critical actors make representative claims with regard to women (Celis et al., 2014; Saward, 2010) often by employing polling data to produce an account of women voters' preferences. The extent to which these interventions are successful may vary depending on the configuration of a number of factors: such as the mobilisation of feminist (usually) women in the legislature and the upper echelons of the party hierarchy; the ideological position of the party and the strength of women's/feminist organizations in civil society (Kittlison, 2006; Schwindt-Bayer and Mishler, 2005; Young, 2000). Another factor that is

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likely to have a significant impact on the ability of feminist actors to influence parties is the electoral context.

In an environment where women voters' behaviour is, or is perceived to be, distinct from men's parties may be more responsive to demands to represent women's interests if they anticipate gaining an electoral advantage. For example in the United States and Britain when women's suffrage was first granted political parties feared that women would vote as a block and they responded by developing policy programmes designed to be attractive to women (Burrell, 1993: 301; Carroll, 2010: 123). The stream of 'women friendly' policies however dried up when it became evident¹ that women differed little from men's (Abzug, 1984: 30, 109; Mueller, 1988: 20; Norris and Lovenduski, 1993).

In the early 1980s, evidence of partisan dealignment (Nie et al., 1979) demonstrated that many of the previously stable political identities (Lipset and Rokkan, 1967), that parties had targeted in order to secure an electoral mandate, had become less politically salient across advanced industrial democracies. The fracturing of these old political identities, and the rise of new politics in the 1960s and the 1970s, provided a window of opportunity for feminists to renew their claims that there was an electoral incentive for parties to take women seriously (Norris, 2001: 9–10); and many members of the women's movement switched tactics and began to participate in electoral politics. As a result, we see further evidence that male-dominated parties respond to women voters when they fear that they may vote as a block, in their reactions to the emergence of a 'modern gender gap' in the United States.

The gender gap is part of an enormous wave of demographic change sweeping the country that threatens to swamp the Republican Party. Edward J. Rollins, President Regan's chief political advisor (Cited in Abzug, 1984: 3).

The greatest political upheaval of the century [the gender gap] Patrick Cadell polling analyst for the Democrats (Cited in Abzug, 1984: 4).

Thus, where there are gender gaps in political attitudes and behaviour, there may be an opportunity for feminist actors to exploit these gender gaps to secure policy gains. It is well documented that feminist activists have used portrayals of women voters as leverage to pursue feminist goals (Norris, 2001). In the United States, the high-profile modern gender gap, evident since 1980, where more women than men support Democratic candidates, has been utilized by feminists to support their case for pursuing a feminist conception of women's interests. In the United Kingdom, the Labour Party's adoption of all women short-lists (1993) in the selection of parliamentary candidates has been, at least partially, accredited to a sustained campaign undertaken by women in the party to draw the leadership's attention to the historic advantage the Conservative party

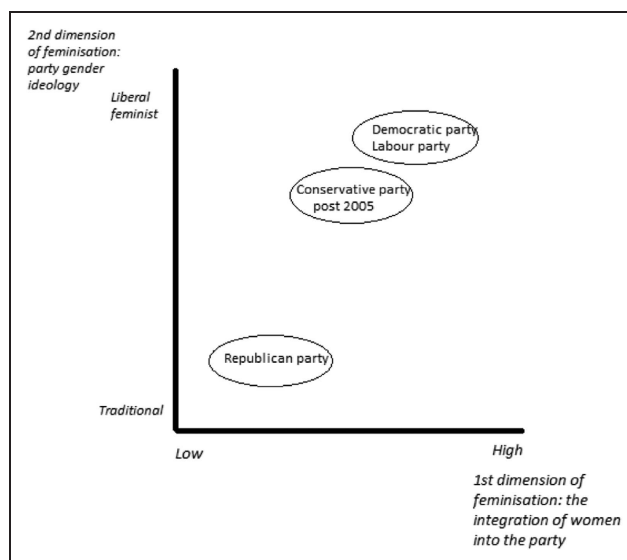


Figure 1. Gendered party types, United States and United Kingdom two largest parties.

had among women voters (Eagle and Lovenduski, 1998; Russell, 2005). If the supposition, that high-profile gender gaps in political attitudes and behaviour provide fertile ground for feminist policy initiatives, is correct then where gender gaps become salient features of media coverage of electoral contests we would expect to see the parties competing to capture gendered votes.² The extent to which the parties are themselves feminised is likely to influence whether any reaction to media portrayals of women voters is either fully integrated into a party's offer or superficially appended to it. Additionally exogenous shocks to the party system may open up windows of opportunity where feminist actors are able to direct the party's attention to the perceived interests of women voters (Childs, 2015: 9).

The feminisation of political parties can take place on two levels: deep-rooted and superficial. Deep-rooted feminization occurs when women's organizations, interests and perspectives are embedded within party structures and routinely incorporated into policy platforms and campaigns. Superficial feminization occurs when women's interests are accommodated in an ad hoc and piecemeal fashion in response to a perceived electoral case on an election by election basis. Figure 1 represents a schematic approach to classifying gendered party types along two dimensions: gender ideology (ideas) and the integration of women within the party (numbers; à la Lovenduski, 2005). A party with a liberal feminist ideology will include the substantive representation of women among its core beliefs and values. As such, a party with a liberal feminist ideology should be highly responsive to feminist portrayals of women voters. It is not necessarily inevitable that a party with a feminist ideology will also include large numbers of feminist (usually) women integrated within the party,³ but the two

dimensions are highly correlated because feminist activists working within the party over a long time period are likely to influence its core beliefs and values. Thus, a feminized party is most likely both feminist in its ideology and within its party structures. I hypothesize that feminist claims regarding women voters will provoke a more deep-rooted response from a feminized party than one with a traditional gender ideology and few feminists (usually) women mobilized within the party hierarchy.

Case studies

In order to highlight the need for an analytic framework to assess the relationship between feminist activism, media newsframes and party behaviour I employ two case studies (the United States and Great Britain). The criteria for case selection are that in both countries, the issue of gender became a salient feature of the election campaign coverage (from 1980 in the United States and 1997 in the United Kingdom). Focusing on these high-profile cases maximizes the likelihood that parties will be aware of, and therefore, possibly responsive to, gendered newsframes either at a surface or deep level. Future research should attempt to explain party response by capturing variation in media coverage and feminist activity to establish what factors determine party response across time and space (as set out in the preliminary analytic framework, Table 1).

The United States

The US gender gap literature is extensive, evolving and highly sophisticated. In this case, study I uses the gender gap literature to identify gendered newsframes employed during election campaigns. I trace the circumstances in which a newsframe gains purchase and identify causal factors that should be isolated in a systematic comparative analysis across space and time. The high-profile ‘modern’ gender gap in the United States has generated a massive body of research that has influenced analysis of gender and voting behaviour across the globe. The gender gap is not a chasm (Seltzer et al., 1997), but it has been relatively stable since 1980, remaining between 4 and 11 percentage points (Figure 2).

In the United States, little public attention was given to potential differences between men and women voters – after the bout of consternation at the time of women’s suffrage – until the *gender gap* was revealed in the aftermath of the 1980 presidential election, where 8% fewer women than men voted for Ronald Reagan (Frankovic, 1982; Sigel, 1999).⁴ In fact, there was a small gender gap in 1976, with more women supporting Carter, but this fact did not receive media attention and was dismissed by Carter’s own pollster as unimportant (Mueller, 1988: 17). It took feminist intervention for the modern or left-leaning gender gap in the United States to gain public attention.

Table 1. Proposed analytic framework.

Dependent variable/s	Party liberal feminist campaign scale comprising of analysis of: • Party manifestos; • Leaders’ speeches; • Election policy commitments and • Campaign materials. • (Gender gap in party of vote)
Independent variables	• Party feminization dimension 1: • Proportion of women representing the party in the: • Legislature; • Executive and • Mass membership. • Relative power of party women’s organizations • Party feminization dimension 2: • lite survey rating parties’ position on a liberal feminist scale over the previous legislative period. • Feminist campaign activity outside of the parties • Gendered voter newsframes: • Frequency of articles referring to women voters; • Frequency of use of gendered newsframes; • Feminist/traditional gender ideology driving the newsframe (Y/N) and • Newsframe created by feminist activists (Y/N). • Newsframe created by anti-feminist activists (Y/N). • Newsframe created by party (Y/N). • Additional information: • Newsframe supported by sound empirical evidence (Y/N). • Actual size of gender gap at last election

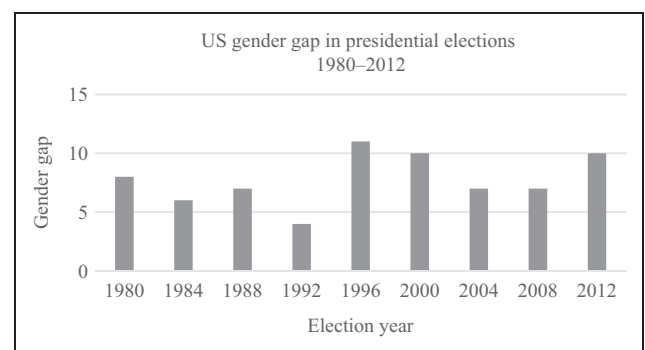


Figure 2. US gender gap in presidential elections 1980–2012.

Source: Center for American Women and Politics (CAWP; http://www.cawp.rutgers.edu/fast_facts/voters/documents/GGPresVote.pdf).

The first use of the term *gender gap* is attributed to Eleanor Smeal, then president of the National Organization for Women (NOW) in 1981 (Bonk, 1988: 89; Sigel, 1999: 5). Roberta Sigel (1999) argued that by naming the

phenomena – *gender gap* – and providing a coherent narrative about women voters the women's movement was able to draw politicians' attention to the issue of the representation of women (Sigel, 1999: 5).

The naming of the *gender gap* kept the issue of women's interests and concerns on the political agenda and encouraged the parties to consider women candidates; for example, it influenced the selection of Geraldine Fararro as the Democrat candidate for Vice President in 1984 (Norris and Carroll, 1997: 9). Carol Mueller argues that NOW effectively utilized the *gender gap* to convince the Democrats that including a woman as the vice presidential candidate would be electorally advantageous (Frankovic, 1988; Mueller, 1988). However, both CBS and the New York Times produced polls that showed that including a woman on the ticket would have no effect on the result but neither polls were published, as they did not fit with the prevailing newsframe (Mueller, 1988: 29). NOW's campaign to maintain a feminist newsframe was successful in the short term because of the resources they deployed and because their frame fulfilled the news media's demand for exciting news stories, with a coherent narrative, as a result the *gender gap* frame influenced the Democrat's decision to choose a woman to run for vice president (VP). Thus, feminist representations of women's interests can be demonstrated to have had a significant impact on the party's decision-making (directly improving the descriptive representation of women in the form of a woman vice presidential candidate), but in this case, success was not driven by the use of reliable evidence regarding the demands of women voters. Instead, the narrative that women would be more inclined to vote for a party with a woman running as VP was not supported by the opinion poll data, but evidence that ran counter to the newsframe was excluded from media portrayals of women voters. This example illustrates why a comprehensive account of how parties represent the interests of women voters requires the inclusion of an analysis of how information about women voters is conveyed to the parties rather than simply linking survey data to party policy without considering the intervening variables of feminist activism and media content.

The *gender gap* newsframe, although still in use, was accompanied by the *Year of the Woman* in 1992, focusing on the record numbers of women running for and elected to Congress (Dolan, 1998). Sue Carroll contends that although women's organizations, such as NOW, initially benefited from the surge in attention to women voters in the *Year of the Woman*, over the longer term interest may have waned as a result of media fatigue and interest in women candidates declined in 1994 and 1996 (Carroll, 1999). Attempts to estimate the influence of the women's movement on the parties' attitudes toward women voters should include a measure of the fluctuation in campaign intensity (in this case as a result of diminishing resources available to NOW (Bonk, 1988; Mueller, 1988) to assess whether, as

feminist activism drops off, other actors' framing of women's interests become dominant.

The *Year of the Woman* was followed by the *Year of the Angry White Male* in coverage of the 1994 House elections. The shift to a focus on men resulted from an opinion poll showing that men had transferred their support to the Republicans, as a result women were largely absent from media portrayals of voters and candidates during the 1994 election (Carroll, 1999: 8). The shift of emphasis from women to men was criticised on the grounds that it simply reflected the media's appetite for a new angle rather than a response to credible evidence of a shift in the behaviour of men.

Scholars with access to the National Election Studies have searched hard for evidence about the angry white male in the 1994 elections, but they have come up empty-handed (Norris and Carroll, 1997: 11).

Yet more evidence that media portrayals of voters should be included in models of parties' attempts to represent women voters.

The 1996 presidential election saw the arrival of the *Soccer Mom*. The term was cited by E. J. Dionne in *The Washington Post* on 21 July, 1996 when he quoted a senior media adviser to Bob Dole, Alex Castellanos, who said that Clinton was following the advice of his pollster, Dick Morris, and targeting a voter whom Castellanos called the 'Soccer Mom' (Norris and Carroll, 1997); 'the overburdened, middle income working mother who ferries her kids from soccer practice to scouts to school' (Dionne Jr, 1996). Clinton responded to the *Soccer Mom* frame by speaking on issues that his team believed would appeal to this specific group of target voters, such as school uniforms and curfews for teenagers (Carroll, 1999: 10). Dole's response was more explicit than Clinton's and he referred to *Soccer Moms* directly on several occasions and argued that his proposed tax cut would allow more women to stay at home with their children rather than seek paid employment (Carroll, 1999: 10). To some extent, neither candidates' responses to the *Soccer Mom* frame were liberally feminist as they focused almost exclusively on children rather than the core demands of the organized women's movement – such as the liberalization of access to abortion, access to healthcare or childcare or other feminist concerns, such as sexual harassment (ibid). The *Soccer Mom* frame resulted in an emphasis on policies that impact on children and women were used as a proxy for family concerns. In fact, in her analysis of the same election, Sue Carroll concluded that the widespread use of the gendered *Soccer Mom* newsframe may have been detrimental to the ability of women's organizations to translate the media and party interest in women voters into tangible gains for women (Carroll, 1999). This example again shows that models of party behaviour should include competing representative claims made about

women voters and should incorporate the dominant narrative evident in any given election cycle.

However, a small number of the Clinton ads did cover feminist concerns (Jamieson et al., 1999) and Clinton referred to women in his speeches and made use of them as examples more often than Dole did. Clinton's even suggested God might be a woman (Jamieson et al., 1999: 14). This analysis demonstrates that despite Carroll's critique that Clinton's attempts to target women voters were overly narrow they were considerably more liberally feminist than Dole's overtures. This is in keeping with a feminist analysis of Democrat and Republican gendered party types, which demonstrates that even in the context of a high-profile gender gap gendered party type plays a crucial role in the extent to which campaign messages and policy platforms are designed to meet the interests of feminist women.

The potential for dissonance between gendered newsframes and the empirical evidence is manifest in the post-election analysis of the 1996 presidential election.

Ultimately, ... the soccer mom did not play a particularly important role in Clinton's victory. Like the "angry white male" before her, on further analysis, systematic evidence establishing the importance of the soccer mom proved elusive. (Kaufmann and Petrocik, 1997 cited in Norris and Carroll, 1997: 12)

It would seem that although the *Soccer Mom* newsframe did direct some attention to women voters, it shifted the media and parties' attention from the feminist framing of the gender gap and the need to address a wide range of 'women's issues' to a much narrower conception of women's interests which elided women with the family. Hence, it is important that any analysis of the influence of gendered newsframes on parties' attempts to represent feminist women voters includes an assessment of the extent to which the newsframe is liberally feminist.

The *Soccer Mom* reappeared, although to a lesser extent, in the 2000 presidential election campaign and she was followed by the *Security Mom* in 2004 (Carroll, 2006, 2008: 77). The *Security Mom* had much in common with the *Soccer Mom*: she was perceived to be white, married with young children, but in the wake of the 2001 terrorist attacks, she was extremely anxious to protect her family (Carroll, 2006: 93). And, much like the *Soccer Mom*, 'empirical data collected from voters offer little support for the characterization of security moms as portrayed in media accounts' (Carroll, 2008: 76). Kerry and Bush both addressed the *Security Mom* by stressing that they would be tough on terrorism, but Kerry also focused on healthcare and the gender pay gap in an attempt to gain support among poorer women who were over-represented in the undecided category. Both candidates made symbolic attempts to appeal to women voters by making public appearances with

prominent women and in addition, Kerry made some targeted issue-based appeals. Sue Carroll concludes that the *Security Mom* frame benefited the Bush campaign because it allowed him to appear to address women's concerns without making any tangible policy commitments (Carroll, 2008: 87). Again the *Security Mom* frame deflected attention away from other subgroups of women, from the women's movement and from a feminist reading of the gender gap (Carroll, 2006). Although the use of the frames meant that women voters received some attention during the campaign, it would seem that neither the *Soccer Mom* nor the *Security Mom* were likely to encourage the parties to attempt to represent liberally feminist women.

In the 2008 and 2012, presidential elections women voters received more media attention than ever before (Carroll, 2010, 2014). In 2008, Hillary Clinton's candidacy in the Democratic primaries and the high levels of support she received among women ensured that women voters were a central part of the media's coverage of the election (Carroll, 2010). Again the candidates made symbolic appeals to women voters by being seen with high-profile women and the Republicans sought to push back against the Democrats' advantage among women by selecting a woman, Sarah Palin, to run as VP (Carroll, 2014). The selection of a woman to run as VP was McCain's most serious attempt to target women voters in 2008. Obama made more issue-based attempts to attract women voters, stressing economic initiatives to help working women (Carroll, 2014: 120). In 2008, there was not a dominant gender newsframe and instead women voters were portrayed in a variety of different ways and they were central to the election coverage. In 2012, the most prominent gender newsframe was generated by the Obama campaign itself; they developed a narrative of the *Republican War on Women*. The narrative had purchase because of the extreme and shocking statements made by a number of Republicans during the primaries and the campaign: including Republican Senator Rick Santorum saying that contraception is 'not okay' and Republican Congressman Todd Akin stating that women's bodies prevent them from getting pregnant as a result of rape (Carroll, 2014: 121–122). In addition, Obama repeatedly stressed his support for equal pay for men and women, while Romney publicly dodged the question. Romney's campaign made little reference to women's issues and in contrast, Obama frequently raised issues of women's health and pay equality. It is clear that gendered newsframes often originate from within political campaigns/organizations (both feminist and non-feminist) and critically the extent to which they are liberally feminist in content is likely to both reflect and shape the parties' attempts to represent women voters.

It would seem that 32 years after NOW publicized the *gender gap*, the story of how women voters are portrayed by the media and represented by the parties in the United States is one of considerable variation and change over

time. The extent to which parties respond to women voters in an ad hoc or more systematic and holistic manner does seem to be influenced by the way women voters are portrayed in the campaign and which actors are most successful in shaping that narrative.

Great Britain

Historically women in Britain voted for the Conservative party in greater numbers than men (see figure 3) (Norris and Lovenduski, 1993: 38). In the United Kingdom, feminist activists within the Labour Party in the 1980s and early 1990s were successful in linking this gender gap in voting behaviour to the under-representation of women in Parliament and this narrative played a critical role in the party's decision to adopt a gender quota, in the form of all women shortlists, in the selection of parliamentary candidates in the run up to the 1997 General Election. The use of women voters to argue for the better representation of women in politics was set out in two pamphlets published by prominent Labour women (Brooks et al., 1990; Eagle and Lovenduski, 1998; Hewitt and Mattinson, 1987). The attempt to secure the better representation of women voters was largely an internal party campaign and not driven by media-generated gendered newsframes. However, the party's attempts to target women voters did lead the media to identify newsframes to pitch the story.⁵

Feminist advocacy groups were particularly active in the 1997 election campaign, producing reports and polls and generally attempting to push the issue of women voters onto the media agenda and gaining considerable coverage (Lovenduski, 1997). The press coverage did not include one single-dominant gendered newsframe and both feminist and anti-feminist portrayals of women voters were in evidence (Lovenduski, 1997: 714). However, in 1997, *Worcester Woman* was identified by Conservative pollsters and adopted by the media as a newsframe to describe working-class women in marginal constituencies with children who might have previously voted Conservative but who had switched to Labour. To some extent, *Worcester Woman* was borne out of the Labour feminists' campaign for the party to take women seriously by drawing attention to the traditional gender gap, but it also narrowed the focus to women with children. In addition, women MPs were subject to a gendered newsframe after the election in the form of *Blair's Babes*, which was prevalent in coverage of the increase in the number of Labour women MPs from 37 to 101. Again there was not a dominant gendered newsframe during the 2001 election campaign, although *Worcester Woman* returned, and women journalists took up feminist criticisms of the absence of women politicians from key campaigning roles (Lovenduski, 2001). There was evidence that the parties were seeking to target women's votes, most prominent was the Labour Party, which produced a manifesto for women, but the Conservatives also

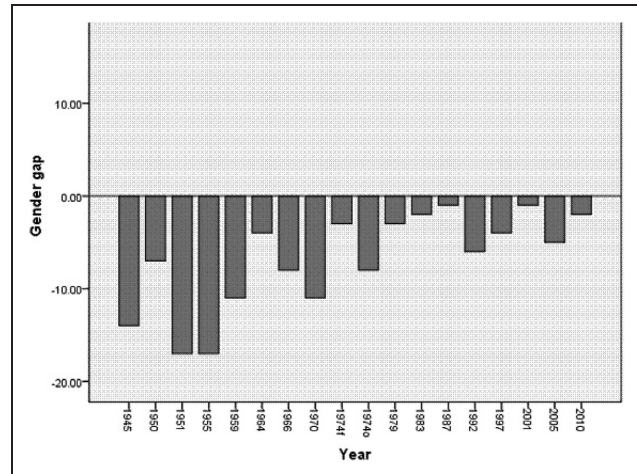


Figure 3. The British gender gap 1945–2010 (adapted from Norris, 1999).

produced some policies targeted at liberally feminist women (Lovenduski, 2001: 748).

In the run up to the 2005 General Election, the parties and the media were unusually interested in women voters. The media attempted to define women voters by applying gendered newsframes, *Worcester Woman* returned again, accompanied by *Let-down Woman* and *Do-it-all woman*. *Let-down Woman* reflected a belief that women were especially unhappy about Britain's involvement in the Iraq war and that they were disaffected with Tony Blair, supported by a poll commissioned by the liberally feminist advocacy group the Fawcett Society. However, women's supposed disillusionment with Blair was probably an artefact of poor research methods; reports of polling evidence that women were unhappy with Blair frequently did not offer a comparison with men and implied a gender difference that was not in evidence. The *Let-down Woman* frame created the impression that women were moving away from Labour when in fact there is no evidence to support this interpretation. The focus on women's alleged hostility to Blair also suggested that women respond to party leaders in a more personalized and emotional way than men – headlines asked questions, such as whether 'women had fallen out of love with Blair' and discussed attempts to 'woo' women voters – again a stereotype without empirical support. All three parties used the media to engage in direct appeals to women voters. Labour and the Liberal Democrats produced manifestos for women and Labour women filled a bus with women MPs and visited marginal constituencies to speak to women voters, although the bus received little media attention (Campbell and Lovenduski, 2005: 847; Childs, 2005). The Conservative Party's third consecutive defeat in 2005 led them to elect a new party leader, David Cameron. Cameron sought to detoxify the party's brand by portraying the party as being in touch with modern Britain: A key part of the strategy was party feminization (Childs and Webb,

2012). Cameron chose to make his first speech as party leader at the Equal Opportunities Commission and he focused on women's issues from a liberally feminist conception of women's interests. As a result, from 2005 onwards, the difference between the main parties on feminist ideology diminished considerably.

In the British news media, 2010 was going to be the 'Mumsnet Election'. The term was coined by Rachel Sylvester in the *Times* (17/11/09) and by 5th May, 43 further articles in British national newspapers used the term. Sylvester claimed that the election 'would be decided at the school gate' and she depicted the party leaders as lining up to participate in live web-chats with women voters through the Mumsnet site. The focus on mothers was confirmed by Douglas Alexander, the Labour Party's 2010 election coordinator, when he said that 'Labour needs to win back middle-income female voters with children in marginal seats' (*Guardian*, 19.2.10). The Mumsnet Election was a significant feature of the election newsframe that set up a narrative that women voters, and policies that affect women more than men, would be at the centre of the campaign. The three main parties did set out policies specifically targeted at women and mothers in particular, work/life balance issues were addressed in all three election manifestos with promises to make maternity and paternity leave more flexible. All three parties were also committed, rhetorically at least, to improving the representation of women in Parliament. All three main parties offered a liberally feminist set of policy propositions and although the Labour Party provided the most comprehensive offer for liberally feminist women, the Liberal Democrats and the Conservatives actively competed to secure their votes.

During the 2015 British General Election, women voters became a salient feature of the election coverage when the Labour Party launched its pink battle bus intended to reach out to women voters. The bus generated a great deal of publicity, not because the party was targeting women voters per se but due to its colour; generating many column inches that at least touched on the issue of women voters. The Labour Party were accused of patronizing women and of succumbing to the 'pinkification' of womanhood; although – as previously noted – the Labour Party had employed campaign buses (of other hues) seeking out women voters in previous elections which had been largely ignored by the media. Admirable as the attempt to draw attention to women's issues may have been, the bus's deployment was largely publicly justified on the basis of dubious statistics. The Labour Party claimed that there were 9.1 million missing women voters in the 2010 British election whereas in fact there was not a statistically significant gender gap (Campbell et al., 2015). The 'missing' women voters became a recurrent news story and thus a good deal of the media coverage and public debate about women voters that took place was based on the erroneous belief that women had been less likely to vote in 2010 than

men. This is another example of a representative claim made about women voters that became part of the news agenda but was not supported by sound evidence. As a result in order to understand the parties' attempts to target women voters during the 2015 election, we need to understand how they responded to this portrayal of women as disproportionately non-voters as well as including observational data about 'real' gender differences in analytic models. Future research should assess whether the other parties responded to the frame and offered feminist policies in order to attempt to compete for women's votes as a result.

Although there wasn't a single coherent gendered newsframe in play during the 2015 election, a Nexis search of UK national newspapers shows that considerable newspaper copy was devoted to the subject. In fact during the final 3 months prior to the election in 2015, there were 142 references to women voters in national newspapers compared with 45 references in the same period in 2010. There was not an easily digestible simple newsframe such as the Mumsnet Election or 'Worcester Women' to provide a journalistic hook for articles discussing women voters, but women voters and women's issues were raised frequently. It is possible that the issue of women voters was more fully integrated into the coverage of the 2015 campaign as a whole. Analysis of the parties' manifestos shows that all of the parties offered liberally feminist policy positions on issues ranging from childcare to domestic violence and even UKIP, the least feminist party, put forward a set of policies designed to attract liberally feminist women voters (Campbell et al., 2015). The 2015 British General Election was highly gendered in other regards, the prominence of the small parties in the leaders' debates in the election coverage (three of the seven party leaders were women), meant that women politicians were more visible in the campaign than in previous years. Further research should assess whether an electoral context where women voters and women politicians, framed from a liberally feminist perspective, are highly visible results in inter-party competition for women's votes.

To sum up, there is no longer a statistically significant aggregate level gender gap in voting behaviour in the United Kingdom. Women voters are a recurrent feature of election coverage and there appears to have been an upsurge in the attention the media pays to them. Crucially all of the main political parties have adopted liberally feminist policy platforms, particularly since the election of David Cameron as Conservative party leader; the main parties are explicitly competing for the votes of liberally feminist women. In this context, it is perhaps not surprising that a modern gender gap (Inglehart and Norris, 2000) has not emerged in Britain. There is less variation in gendered party types in the United Kingdom than in the United States, which may help explain the variation in the gender gap across the two countries. Returning to our central research question, there has been a significant movement

in the attempts of the main parties in the United Kingdom to incorporate liberally feminist policies into their election commitments. The application of the analytic framework, set out later, would help us to unpick whether this change has been driven by observable shifts in women's preferences, feminist activism, gendered newsframes or all three.

The analytic framework

In this section, I use the insights gained from the United States and United Kingdom case studies to elucidate a preliminary analytic framework to guide future comparative research. In order to provide a convincing answer to the research question, 'is the electoral linkage between political parties and women voters deep-rooted and central to electoral campaigns, or, on the contrary, superficial, ad hoc and volatile?' researchers must operationalize a series of concepts.⁶ These concepts include gendered party types (measured using the two dimensions of party feminization), feminist and anti-feminist campaigning from inside and outside of the parties and gendered newsframes. The extent to which election campaigns address liberally feminist concerns can be assessed through the use of content and discourse analysis of party campaign materials, manifestos and speeches. In order to generate comparable data, country researchers should develop a common coding frame and create a cumulative party liberal feminist campaign scale generating a score for each major party seeking election. The first dimension of feminism could be operationalized by collating information about women/feminists representation throughout the hierarchy of the political parties. The second dimension of feminism could be operationalized by conducting a survey of gender and politics scholars to place the parties on a liberal feminist scale over the previous legislative period.

The extent to which gendered newsframe/s are evident in election coverage could be captured with a simple frequency score for the number of references to women voters subdivided by the keywords employed in the gendered newsframe/s in coverage of the campaign. For the purposes of this analysis, gendered newsframes refer to media portrayals of women voters that have a single coherent narrative and a frequently employed phraseology, such as *gender gap*, *Soccer Mom* or *Security Mom* (Jamieson and Waldman, 2004). The gendered newsframe may be coded as liberal feminist or anti-liberal feminist and may originate within feminist organizations (inside and/or outside the parties) or from outside of the women's movement. Undertaking this data collection exercise would require the creation of a network of country researchers and the deployment of substantial research resources, but the potential for significant advances in our understanding of how/when the substantive representation of women occurs and, potentially, the sources of the gender gap itself are

sizeable. Collating detailed and systematic comparative data, as set out in Table 1, would enable a comparative analysis of how political parties respond to liberally feminist representations of women voters over time and place that would incorporate variations in election context and political activism.

Conclusion

A historical reading of how parties have been persuaded to address women's issues reveals that a case that women's votes depend on it is very commonly made. Critical actors are important but they are most successful when they are able to claim that they can bring women voters with them. The study of gender and voting behaviour and gender and party politics form two distinct strands of gendered political research but they should be more fully integrated. This is a real challenge because it requires extensive collaborative research across time and space, but such an approach would provide more complete accounts of how the representation of women occurs.

It is time to bring politics back into models of the gender gap. The US case study demonstrated that the 1980 US presidential election was a critical election in gendered terms as it was the first where a modern gender gap was apparent. The year 1980 also possibly represents a critical moment in terms of the polarization of the two main parties on gender ideology (Freeman, 1987; Gillion et al., 2014; Rymph, 2005). The successful Republican presidential candidate, Ronald Reagan, was the most traditional in his view of gender roles among his Republican rivals; stating that a wife in the workforce 'threatens the very structure of family life itself' (Abzug, 1984: 81–87) and arguably this was the moment where the two parties' gender ideology clearly diverged or arguable reversed (Freeman, 1987). Early studies of the gender gap incorporated the behaviour of the parties into their analysis of the gender gap; for example, Sue Carroll described Ronald Reagan as a 'catalyst for the gender gap' (Carroll, 2010: 125), but most recent studies focus on sociological explanations for differences in men and women's voting behaviour. Most current analysis of the gender gap in voting behaviour treats the party positions as relatively stable, but if 1980 was a critical moment then there is reason to measure the parties' gender ideology and mobilization of women within the party hierarchy over time to assess the impact this has on women's support for the parties themselves. In these circumstances, we would expect the Democrats to be more responsive to feminist portrayals of women's policy interests and to prove more attractive to liberally feminist women voters than the Republicans, arguably a significant source of the US gender gap. In the United Kingdom, however, the main parties are much closer together in terms of gender ideology, particularly since 2005 (Campbell et al., 2015). In this context, we may not expect to see

a gender gap in voting behaviour as the main parties are competing to capture ‘feminist’⁷ women’s votes. Thus, understanding gender and voting behaviour in global perspective requires an account of both the sociological factors shifting gendered attitudes and the reactions of political actors.

Throughout the case studies, it was clear that political parties create and react to gendered newsframes and that the extent to which they respond by incorporating feminist demands depends on gendered party type and the feminist (or not) nature of the newsframe itself. It is important, therefore, that any academic analysis of the relationship between gender gaps and the descriptive and substantive representation of women, as facilitated through political parties, includes measurements of both actual gender differences in political attitudes and behaviour and media portrayals of these differences.

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Notes

1. Although the evidence that women did not vote as a block in the aftermath of women’s suffrage may be faulty due to the lack of opinion polls at the time (Mueller, 1988).
2. In the main, when women’s organizations in Western democracies advocate for the inclusion of women’s interests in party policy, they do so from a liberal feminist position. It is possible to imagine a position where an anti-feminist women’s movement would make claims about how the parties should best represent the interests of women using gender gaps to support their case, but we do not see these to any great extent in media coverage of national elections. In this article, I therefore focus on feminist conceptions of the representation of women, but the framework could equally be applied to anti-feminist campaigns to represent women who support traditional gender roles.
3. There are two components to the first dimension of feminization; women can be integrated within parliamentary elites and as party members through party women’s organizations (Childs 2008).
4. However, there were some notable academic exceptions. For example, see Tingsten (1937) and Duverger (1955).
5. The gender gap is calculated as the difference between the ConLab lead for women and men. *Gallup Polls* 1945–59; BES 1964–2010. 2015. Data was not available at the time of writing.
6. In this article, I elucidate a framework for analysing the link between liberally feminist claims about the representation of

women and political parties but it could equally be applied to studies exploring radical feminist or conservative feminist campaigns to attempt to represent women.

7. In this article, I refer to ‘feminist’ women as women who are not necessarily self-conscious feminists, but whose policy preferences are liberally feminist.

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Feminizing political parties: Women's party member organizations within European parliamentary parties

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Abstract

Party member women's organizations were early features of party development. While some contemporary studies maintain these are important sites for the substantive representation of women, there is also a claim that they are in decline. Our primary purpose here is to establish the existence of party member women's organizations – as one test of the first dimension of party feminization: the inclusion of women. We draw on new survey data of 17 European countries provided by Scarrow, Poguntke and Webb. We establish that almost half have a party member women's organization. The new data also permits analysis of relationships between party member women's organization and gender quotas for the top party leadership body (National Executive Committee (NEC)), women's presence among the party leadership and candidate quota rules. Together we see these (i) as a means to establish whether women are marginalized within the party, thereby limiting descriptive representation and (ii) as surrogate measures for women's substantive representation. We importantly find that the presence of a party member women's organization does not come at the cost of women's presence on the NEC. In the final section, we turn our attention to building a new comparative research agenda that more fully addresses substantive representation.

Keywords

European parties, feminization, gender, gender quotas, party women's organizations

In established democracies, the history of women's participation in political parties frequently dates from the time of mass enfranchisement in the late 19th or early to mid 20th centuries. Women were often key mobilizers of the newly enfranchised, and of course, would ultimately constitute half of the universal vote. An early form of women's party participation was the 'ladies auxiliaries'. These were party organizations of women who undertook political house-keeping and supported the party in its everyday activities (Childs and Webb, 2012; Young, 2000: 134). Later, some second wave feminist engagement with political parties took place, but this was uneven across different polities and parties, not least because some feminists questioned the desirability of engagement with electoral politics (see Lovenduski and Norris, 1993). Today, as Evans' contribution in this special issue suggests, contemporary feminist activists may eschew more systematic or collective

engagement with electoral politics and parties in favour of more individualized relationships with women party politicians.

Contemporary research on party women's organizations is unfortunately rather limited. Comparative party research too rarely adopts a gendered approach, and the politics and gender literature has focused much of its attention on party recruitment practices, and women in legislatures over the last 20 years or so. What literature that does exist posits two competing scenarios for party women's organizations in the contemporary era. The first, derived from the gender

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and politics literature, and largely based on a small number of single case studies, contends that contemporary party member women's organizations remain organizations *of* women, but that they are now also acting *for* women, even as they might still fulfil their traditional function (Allen and Childs, 2014; Childs and Webb, 2012; Willliarty, 2010). In these accounts, party women's organizations are found to constitute an important site from which women are making gendered political demands of their party. These demands are underpinned by an explicit group identity engendered by the women's participation in their party women's organization. A second scenario, deriving more from contemporary comparative party literature, points not to a new function but to their abolition. Wider developments in the form of political parties have seen moves towards greater intra-party democracy (IPD) and professionalization. Maintaining structures for particular groups of members is said not to be a feature of such modern political parties (see, e.g. Cross and Katz, 2013; Young and Cross, 2002). In the context of such limited and seemingly contradictory analysis, this article seeks (1) to provide a more systematic, large *N* study of the existence of party women's organizations and (2) to contribute to the debate about the form and function of women's party organizations. Our primary focus is to map their prevalence across a range of European industrialized countries. Based on new data of 17 European countries, generously provided by Susan Scarrow, Thomas Poguntke, and Paul Webb, we are able to confirm the extent to which party women's organizations exist in the political parties of today, and, moreover what kinds of political parties are associated with them.¹ We find that almost half of the parties – notably, the traditional parties – have a party member women's organization, refuting claims, implicit or explicit, in the contemporary IPD literature of their demise. But what role do party member women's organizations play in respect of the descriptive and substantive representation of women within parties? If women's presence is restricted to their participation in a party women's organization, we would suggest that their descriptive representation is limited. Accordingly, and again making use of the new comparative data, we examine the relationship between party women's organization and internal gender quotas for a party's executive body (which frequently take the form of reserved seats on a party's National Executive Committee (NEC)), women's presence in party leadership positions and the presence of gender quota rules for parliamentary candidates.

The new survey data also importantly permits us to begin to address the claim made in recent years by a number of gender and politics scholars, namely that party women's organizations constitute at least a *potential* site for the substantive representation of women.² Substantive representation is usually studied by looking at the actions of political actors, parties or governments frequently in terms of legislative interventions and outputs, policy pledges and

public statements (see Childs and Lovenduski, 2014). Here we are interested in the role played by party women's organizations as actors of substantive representation, and, more precisely, whether the party women's organization is included in (at least some of) the sites where party policy is determined. We accordingly reflect further on the relationship between the presence of party member women's organization, gender quotas for the top party leadership body (NEC), women's presence among the party leadership and candidate quota rules, taking these as surrogate measures of women's substantive representation. In other words, if the presence of women's party member organizations is associated with women's marginalization within the party, then the potential for women's substantive representation would be – all other things being equal – reduced. Our data shows little evidence that women are so marginalized, even if it does not find evidence for higher numbers of women's presence in the party leadership either.

In the final section of the article, we sketch out a new comparative research agenda. We do this cognizant of having established the ongoing prevalence of party member women's organization across a large number of European cases, in acknowledgement of the limitations of current survey data, noting the lacuna in extant research, and with regard to the burgeoning gender and politics scholarship on gender and political institutions. We also take note of the wide array of party women's organizations and look to provide for a more precise consideration of the relationship between the substantive representation of women and women's party organizations. To better evaluate party women's organization, three criteria – institutionalization, powers and accountability – are presented, along with associated empirical measures. Ultimately, we contend that this research framework should enable determination of the 'good' women's party organization; it certainly begs subsequent empirical research.

Women's party organizations

As key representative actors in democratic politics, political parties constitute an important, albeit not sole, site for the political representation of women – descriptive, substantive and symbolic (Childs, 2008; Lovenduski and Norris, 1993; Young, 2000). The comparative literature on political parties has, regrettably, too often ignored gendered analysis, at least until very recently (Cross and Katz, 2013; Rahat 2013; Representation, 2013). Feminist research on political parties *qua* parties is more limited than one might have expected given the foundational edited collection dates from the early 1990s (Lovenduski and Norris, 1993). The nexus of gender and party can be examined at multiple sites within party politics (Kittilson, 2013). Women may be party supporters, voters, members, activists, participants, workers as well as elected representatives. The gender

Table 1. Feminization and party types.

	First dimension		Second Dimension
	Integration of women parliamentary elites	Integration of women party members	Integration of women's concerns
Responsive party I (feminist both dimensions)	High/moderate representation; Well designed and fully implemented quotas; or absence of obstacles to women's representation.	Parity of members; women's organizations are fully integrated into party policy making	Positive and in feminist direction
Responsive party II (feminist second dimension)	Low representation; absent or poorly designed/implemented quotas	Fewer women members; integrated women's organizations	Positive and feminist
Co-optive party (feminist on first dimension, neutral on second)	High/moderate representation; may have quotas	Parity of members; auxiliary women's organizations	Neutral or where positive, in a neutral direction
Anti-feminist co-optive party (feminist on first dimension, anti-feminist on second)	High/moderate representation; may have quotas	Parity of members; either anti-feminist women's organizations fully integrated into party policy making or 'auxiliaries'	Positive but in anti feminist direction
Non-responsive	Low representation; absent quotas	Indifferent to representation of women; auxiliary women's organizations rather than integrated ones	Negative
Anti-feminist party	Low representation; rejects principle and practice of quotas	Indifferent to representation of women; either anti-feminist women's organizations fully integrated into party policy making or auxiliary women's organization	Positive in an anti-feminist direction

Source: Amended from L. Young 2000; Childs 2008.

and politics literature which has specifically focused on parties has frequently been characterized by single or small N case studies (e.g. Childs and Webb, 2012; Willarty, 2010; Young, 2000) or discussed parties as part of a wider national account of women and politics (Childs, 2008). The latter provides a broad overview of women's interventions and participation in parliaments and politics, often as representatives of political parties, with extensive study of the actions of women representatives 'for women'. The former provides in many instances very rich description, documenting the ways in which women have entered parties, become active therein, and effected (or sought to effect) gendered change (Childs and Webb, 2012; Willarty, 2010; Young, 2000). This scholarship establishes that political parties are highly gendered institutions, structured by, and constitutive of gender relations. Whether in their formal rules, norms and, or wider relations,³ gender is manifested throughout party processes, structures, norms and ideologies; there is a complex web of shared practices that differentially impact women and men.⁴

We can conceive of a *feminized* political party as one that both (i) includes and integrates women as political actors and (ii) addresses women's concerns (following Lovenduski, 2005). The first dimension of feminization has

two components: the integration of women as parliamentary elites and the integration of women party members via party women's organizations (Childs, 2008). The second dimension refers to the integration of women's issues and perspectives. Parties can make one of six responses, as Table 1 shows. Crucially here, feminized parties are not the same as feminist political parties, as parties do not have to respond in a feminist fashion on either dimension of feminization.

Party member women's organizations often called women's sections or federations (Kittilson, 2011, 76) are internal to the party structure and may operate at the party's branch and/or central levels. Party women's organizations can take a number of forms. The following is illustrative:

- A formal members' women's organization(s);
- Women's post(s) in the party's voluntary organization;
- Women's posts on particular party structures, for example, at leadership level, reserved seats on a national executive committee or party board; or as in a few parties' in respect of the party leader post (e.g. male and female co-leaders) or in the leader and deputy leader positions;

- Women's posts in the professional/secretariat of the party;
- At the elected level there may well be a 'Women's Minister' or Opposition spokesperson, perhaps with associated staff and
- At the legislative level, a women's formal parliamentary caucus or more informal cross-party caucus.

The extant literature (see Kittilson, 2013) suggests a number of hypotheses coming out of more recent case study research regarding first, the existence of party member women's organizations, and secondly, their nature and impact.

Women's organization existence

Taken together, the first set of expectations focus on the existence and form of party women's organizations in contemporary party politics (see Childs and Webb, 2012; Kittilson, 2006, 2011). Comparative parties scholarship suggest, as noted earlier, (i) that the era of women's party organizations is over in established democracies (Cross and Katz, 2013; Young and Cross, 2002). These expectations are often based on the claim that party leaders dominate party politics, and group identity has given way to individual representation. Different versions of this expectations point out that (ii) party women's organizations have often shifted form, moving away from formal member organizations to looser 'networks' of women members, often more professionalized and oriented towards party policy change and/or towards promoting women in parliament. At the same time, other gender and party scholars suggest that (iii) party women's organizations have resurged, renewing claims for women's representation within the party organization (see Leyenaar, 2004: 199 cited in Childs and Webb, 2012; Kittilson, 2011; Willarty, 2010).

Remit and impact

Rival hypotheses suggest that women's organizations (iv) limit women's descriptive and substantive representation by marginalizing women within the party. Specifically, they keep women from the true centres of power and decision-making within parties; women's issues may here be perceived as special or separate from the party platform. (v) Party women's organization may facilitate women's descriptive and substantive representation by collectively representing and lobbying. The women's organization may additionally (vi) provide resources to women seeking selection as parliamentary representative and, or encourage a collective sense of gendered consciousness, strengthening the women's issue agenda demands of the political party.

Our empirical focus in this article is primarily on the *existence/form* hypotheses; our data speaks less

comprehensively to the second set of hypotheses, although we are able to say something in respect of hypotheses four and five. We return however to questions of how scholars might empirically study the totality of the remit and affect hypotheses in the final part of this article as we develop a new comparative research framework.

In sum, we seek in this article to establish the presence of a party women's organization across a range of European political parties, making use of new survey data. Moreover, we relate this presence/absence to the balance or otherwise of women in the party leadership. We do this because of wider debates about the changing nature of political parties. Plebiscitary parties, as noted above, are said to reject group organization and group representation (Cross and Katz, 2013). In professional/electoral and cartel parties, policy is regarded as having become increasingly the preserve of the party leadership (Katz and Mair, 1995). If this is the case, women's party organizations – even where they continue to exist – will likely be effectively emasculated by a disproportionately male party leadership.

There is, however, an alternative possibility linking women's party organizations and party leaderships that women's enhanced presence in party leaderships has the potential to rebalance gender power within parties and engender the descriptive and substantive representation of women (Childs, 2013; Kittilson, 2011). In other words, by studying the relationship between the absence and or presence of a women's party organization and the number of women in the party leadership, we are able to begin to consider whether these are working in tandem. In other words, to what extent do women's organizations divorce party women from the 'real' centres of decision-making and power within party organizations? Or do they constitute a potential site of substantive representation, alone or in conjunction with women in the party leadership.

Research design and method

A new political party database (www.politicalpartydb.org) helpfully permits us to identify which of the individual parties from across Europe do and do not have a formal party member women's organization. The definition used by researchers gathering the data for this survey is as follows:

Which of the following types of non-territorial sub-organizations are mentioned in the party statutes (examples include women's organizations, youth organizations)? These are organizations with individual memberships.

The Political Party Database Project (PPDP) team undertook their first data collection in 2012–2013 with 2011 as the initial year for which data has been gathered (Scarrow and Webb, 2013, 7). The project 'limited' its attention to parties 'official stories'. This enabled the systematic gathering of comparable data, even as the research

Table 2. Party women's organizations, by country.

Country	# Parties with women's organizations/total # parties
Australia	3/4
Austria	2/5
Belgium	6/12
Canada	3/5
Czech Republic	1/5
Denmark	0/8
Germany	3/7
Hungary	2/4
Ireland	2/5
Israel	4/9
Italy	5/5
Norway	3/7
Poland	2/6
Portugal	2/6
Spain	0/5
Sweden	6/8
United Kingdom	4/4

design authors recognized that 'formal structures maybe a poor guide to actual power relations, and that official resource data may be far from accurate' (Scarrow and Webb, 2013). It would also prevent more subjective analyses.⁵ Three non-European parliamentary democracies – Australia, Canada and Israel – augment European countries in the PPDP project, although we do not include all of these cases in our analysis (see Table 2).

Given the more expansive conceptualization of party women's organizations highlighted above, we recognize that PPDP definition – in particular its emphasis on them being mentioned in 'party statutes' – may not capture all forms.⁶ Nevertheless, and crucially, if anything, the Webb et al. survey is likely to *under-count* rather than over-count parties with women's member organizations. The new data further enables us to determine whether the presence and absence of a women's party organization so defined differs by party type, country type and, or region. We can also compare the absence/presence of a women's party organization with other indicators of feminization based on additional secondary data: (i) women's descriptive representation (the percentage of women in the national legislature), (ii) levels of party parliamentary representation (the numbers of women MPs that particular party returns to the legislature) and (iii) the presence of an internal party women's organization within the party leadership body, and the balance or otherwise of women and men in the party's internal leadership body.

Findings: The prevalence of party member women's organizations

Of the 106 parties from 17 industrialized democratic countries for which Scarrow, Poguntke and Webb collected

data, 48 parties currently have party women's organizations.⁷ Almost half of the studied European political parties have, then, a party women's organization. Moreover, most countries have at least one party with a party member women's organization. Indeed, among the 17 countries, there are only two that have no parties with women's organizations: Denmark and Spain. Overall, and based on this new data, it is clear that the era of the party women's organization cannot said to be over. Instead, party women's organizations persist across a host of different party landscapes in contemporary European party politics.

If the ongoing presence of women's party member organizations in political parties is our first clear finding, our second observation – and a striking one – is that there is a great deal of variation within most national party systems. Only in two countries, Italy and the United Kingdom, do all of the major parties have women's organizations. Or take, for example, Ireland where Fine Gael and Labour Party have party women's organizations, but Fianna Fail, Sinn Fein and Green parties do not. In Norway, the Labour and Conservative parties do not have party member women's organizations, but the Centre and Liberal parties do. In Canada, the Liberal, National Democratic and Green parties have women's organizations, while the Bloc Quebecois and Conservative Party do not.

Are certain types of parties more likely to have internal women's organizations? We examine this proposition by grouping our parties by 'party family'.⁸ We might assume that parties of the left are more accommodating: for reasons of ideological closeness, with concepts of women's equality better 'fitting' leftist parties, or because these parties may be more comfortable with notions of 'identity politics'. Similarly, we might expect post-materialist parties to be more at ease with concepts of women's interests. In contrast, and given antipathy between feminism and conservatism and more especially radical rightist parties, we might be surprised to see an association with party women's organization. Of course, and in a counter argument, we know that conservative parties have frequently been very comfortable with concepts of 'women's interests' albeit defined in a non- or anti-feminist fashion (Celis and Childs, 2012). Accordingly, we might expect to see rightist party women's organizations – the ladies auxiliaries of previous note, for example.

Figure 1 presents the percentage of parties with women's organizations, for each party family type. The total number of parties in each category is given in parentheses. As the figure makes clear, Social Democratic/Socialist, Liberal, Agrarian and Conservative/Christian parties are similarly likely to house party women's organizations. In contrast, Communist parties appear to reject them, with none of the 11 Communist parties across our dataset including a women's organization. Similarly, the newer niche parties such as Ecology, Right Wing, Regional and Special Issue parties are also less likely to contain

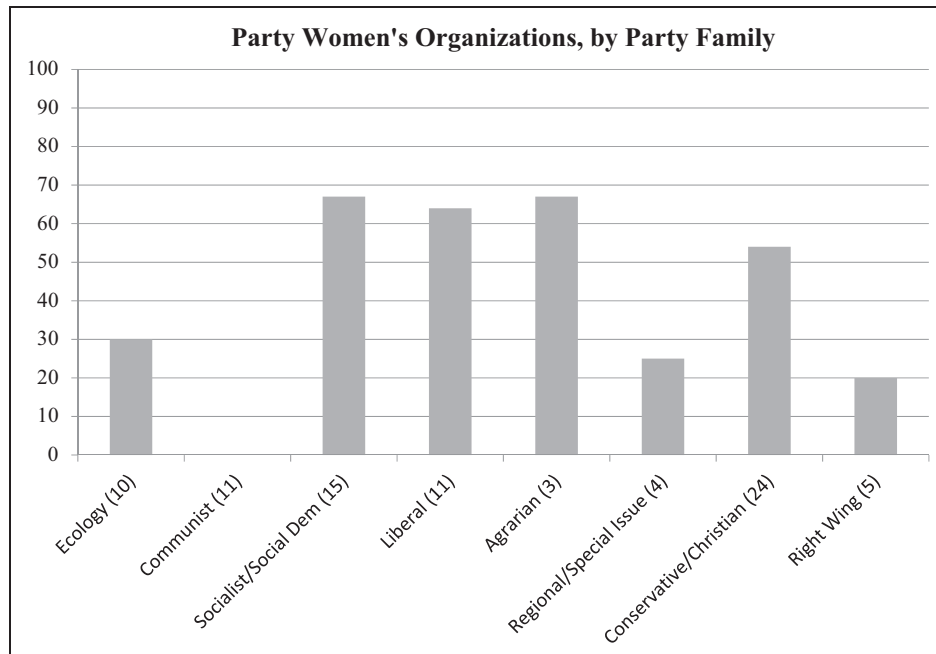


Figure 1. The presence of party women's organizations by party family.

women's organizations. The pattern we have found here is one that draws a distinction between what we might call 'mainstream parties' of post-war European democracies and both parties at the extreme of the left/right spectrum and political parties newer in formation as well as those underpinned by particular political concerns/interests.

Party member women's organization and women in the party leadership

Past research suggests that party women's organizations may limit women's substantive representation of women by keeping women out of the centres of power within the party – the ghettoization thesis (see for the UK case, Childs and Webb, 2012; Kittilson, 2011). To test this claim, we examine the relationship between the presence or absence of party women's organizations and the percentage of women on the party's top leadership body. The top leadership body is often referred to as the NEC or some variant of this term. In a different fashion, party women's organizations may advocate for rule changes within the party to promote women in the party leadership or as party candidates. Note the aforementioned claim that party women's organizations may constitute a site from which women party women can mobilize for the enhanced descriptive representation of women, within the party and as elected representatives of the party. Party rules for the leadership (NEC) range from reserved seats for women, a quota or target for a certain percentage of women on the NEC. Party rules for candidates include both quotas and set targets for percentages of women candidates and, or MPs.

Table 3. Party women's organizations and party centres of power, bivariate correlations.

	Party women's organization
% Women on party NEC	0.006 (N = 79)
Party gender quotas for NEC	0.161 (N = 104)
Party gender quotas for candidates	-0.058 (N = 105)

* $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.005$.

First, we examine some simple correlations among party women's organizations and the outcomes of interest. Table 3 presents these bivariate relationships. Party women's organizations share little relation with women on the party's NEC, nor the presence of rules regarding women's presence on the NEC or quota rules for *parliamentary* candidates.

Given the findings of past research, we move on to control for the presence of internal quota rules for the NEC and Left-Right party ideology in predicting the percentage of women sitting on the NEC. Our measure of Left-Right party ideology is taken from the Parliament and Government Composition Database (see Online Appendix 1) and it is a 0–10 scale, where higher numbers indicate a more rightist party ideology.

Table 4 presents the results of an OLS linear regression model explaining the percentage of women on the party leadership body (NEC). Even after controlling for these influences, we find that *party women's organizations are not associated with lower percentages of women on the NEC*. Thus, we do not find any evidence that women's organizations marginalize women from the power centres

Table 4. The influence of party women's organizations on the NEC.

	% Women on party NEC	Variance inflation factor
Party women's organization	0.37	1.04
Party gender quotas for NEC	2.29	1.08
Left-Right ideology	-1.77	1.08
Constant	40.33***	
Adjusted R ²	0.031	
Durbin-Watson	1.186	
Number of cases	65	

Note: Table entries represent coefficients from linear regression.
* $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.005$.

within parties. At the same time, *party women's organizations are not associated with more women on the NEC, and so do not seem to serve as a springboard for women to ascend to party leadership either*. Our results also suggest that leftist parties are no more likely to have women on the NEC than rightist ones. Crucially, rules regarding party gender quotas or reserved seats for the NEC are not related to higher percentages of women on the NEC. We also present some diagnostics for this model in Table 4, to be sure that our model does not violate assumptions of OLS regression. To test for multi-collinearity, the variance inflation factor (VIF) is presented beside each coefficient. Collinearity among our predictors does not appear to present problems for our model. The VIF hovers around 1 in each case, which is well within the boundaries for this diagnostic. In addition, we employed the Durbin-Watson to test for autocorrelation, and this figure (1.18) indicates there may be some positive autocorrelation, but not enough to present problems for our model.

Table 5 presents the covariates from logistic regression models that predict the presence of two types of gender quota rules: *parliamentary* candidate gender quotas and party gender quotas for the NEC. Both models control for party ideology. For *parliamentary* candidate quotas, *the presence of a party women's organization does not dampen (nor heighten) the likelihood that a party will adopt gender quotas for candidates*. The relationship is not statistically significant. However, *the presence of a party women's organization does increase the propensity for parties to adopt gender quotas for the NEC*. For both models, a leftist ideology is a statistically significant predictor of candidate and NEC quota policies.

On the basis of analysis of a 17 country study of political parties, our findings establish (1) that almost half of all the parties studied across these European democracies have a party women's organization – so party member women's organizations remain a significant feature of political party organization in contemporary party politics, even working

Table 5. The influence of party women's organizations on quota rules.

	Candidate quotas	Party gender quotas NEC
Party women's organization	-0.19	0.96*
Left-Right ideology	-0.24*	-0.24*
Constant	1.4*	0.30
Nagelkerke R ²	0.09	0.12
Number of cases	79	79

Note: Table entries represent coefficients from logistic regression.
* $p < 0.05$, *** $p < .005$.

with the 'official' definition demanded by the PPDP research schedule; (2) women's party organizations are mostly a feature of traditional political parties – those that may well now be considered electoral-professional, but are the contemporary versions of the mass and catch all parties of the mid 20th century. In contrast, newer parties and parties of the extreme right and left are less likely to have women's party organizations. These findings may well take on additional significance, if greater party proliferation occurs (as arguably observable in austerity Europe), and, or with the electoral success of populist or radical parties to the detriment of long-established mainstream parties. Some of the party positional gains made by our traditional parties *vis-à-vis* women's representation might, then, be threatened by these parties that have little desire for, or organizational space for party women's organizations. Indeed, when we turn to the consequences of the presence of party women's organizations, we were able to examine whether these give rise to greater descriptive representation of women, both internal to the party and in terms of a party's elected representatives. Here we found that (3) parties with women's organizations are not more likely to have women among their party leadership, nor more likely to have party gender quota rules for *parliamentary* candidates. However, parties with women's organizations are (4) more likely to have gender quota rules for the top party leadership body (NEC). In this way, women's organizations within the party are only *indirectly* related to women's presence among the party leadership; these organizations are associated with the sorts of rules that promote gender equality among the party leadership.⁹

Notwithstanding the clear value of our findings relating to the prevalence of women party member organizations – of being able to present an overview pan-European picture – such large N study leaves room for additional research. We noted earlier how the official definition of what constituted a women's party member organization used in the PPDP study may exclude other party women's bodies that did not quite fit the PPDP definition¹⁰ – recall our list of illustrative typology of party women organizations. Quantitative analysis will be unlikely to capture such multiple

types and variation unless it is designed precisely to do this. To be sure, scholars do need to establish what number and type of party women's organization(s) any individual party might have. Again whether these vary by party family type, and how these relate, if they do, to women's presence in the parliamentary and internal party leaderships. A recent study of the UK Conservative party (Childs and Webb, 2012), for example, identified: the Conservative Women's Organization (CWO), a party member organization, the infamous 'blue-rinsed' backbone of the party, more recently organized around policy issues; Women2win, a 'ginger group' of party members and supporters directed towards women's candidacy for elected office; the CWO Muslim Women's Group (rather short-lived, ending in 2010); Women's Summits and Forums that brought together party members, interested third sectors organizations, MPs and interested outsiders on particular policy issues; a party Vice-Chairman for Women; a shadow Minister for Women; and Women's Policy Group of MPs and party professionals. In such a context, noting the presence of a party member women's organization, as the PPDP survey data documents, cannot fully account for the number and variety of forms of women's party bodies in play at any one time, and limits in turn a full understanding of what such women's organizations do, and to what effect vis-à-vis descriptive and substantive representation.

Subsequent studies might also want to consider the relationship between women's party bodies and the prevalence of other group representations, for example, youth or minority ethnic institutions within parties. Often women's organizations mirror the structure and functions of the party's youth section. These additional institutions would help examine to a greater extent the prevalence of the plebiscitary party characteristics said to be indicative of contemporary political parties, speaking directly to the comparative parties literature. It is also the case that other factors might facilitate the presence of a party member women's organization, or any other party women's body, for that matter. Critically, these may not always be internal to the party. Pressure from feminist women might be a contextual factor in contemporary times as it was, of some parties in the 1970s and 1980s (see Evans in this issue). As noted elsewhere (Childs, 2014), gender and politics scholars have taken very little notice of party regulation (including party funding) as part of the context within which women's descriptive and substantive representation takes place, but this might well facilitate their presence.¹¹

Developing a comparative research framework for the study of party women's organizations

A key proposition answered only indirectly by the PPDP data is the possible relationship between the presence of a

Table 6. Parties' women's organization status and remit.

Dimension	Operationalization/components
Institutionalization	Officially constituted; resourced; autonomous; status; marginalized-integrated continuum
Powers	Policy development-policy veto continuum; Descriptive representation guarantees
Accountability	To whom? The party leadership (and when in office, to the Government)? Women elected representatives? Women party members? Women voters?

party women's organization and the substantive representation of women. The argument is intuitively attractive: a party member women's organization might constitute a 'safe space' from which to articulate not just demands for women's descriptive representation within the party, but to make demands of the party in terms of policy (Allen and Childs, 2014; Celis et al., 2014) and might constitute a resource for individual critical actors in Parliament or Government. The opposing contention is that a party women's organization may keep women's issues and interests away from the party leadership – the aforementioned ghettoization thesis. While our analysis of the PPDP data cannot fully address questions of substantive representation, it is importantly able to show that in the European case, a women's party organization is not a zero-sum game with women's presence on the party NEC.

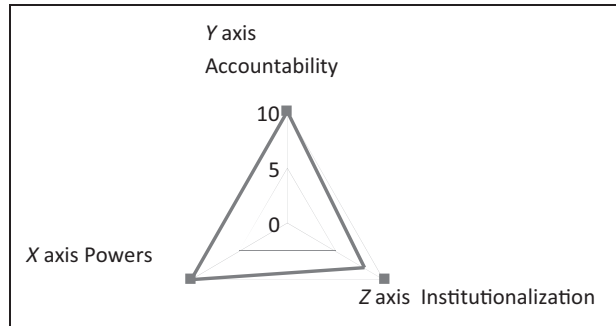
Given the rather limited ways in which existing data speaks to the question of substantive representation we now turn to map out a new research agenda for the study of women's party organization. Once a careful mapping of the range of a party's women's bodies has been undertaken, it is necessary to grasp the extent to which these different party women's organizations are institutionalized within the party proper and what kind of activities they undertake. Ultimately, we are interested in establishing what re-gendering (following Beckwith, 2005) effect party women's organization(s) have. In light of recent conceptual refinements of feminist institutionalism,¹² a focus on the formal and informal will be needed. Research questions, include, to whom, and through what processes or structures, are different party women's organizations accountable? Are women constituted as subjects in their own right? Are they the centre of their own conversation? (Campbell, 1987: 283) Do they work together? Most importantly, does each or any of the party member women's organizations seek to substantively represent women *as women*?

Table 6 displays the operationalization of our approach. The three dimensions seek to capture capacity and likely influence. Institutionalization seeks to establish the permanency, autonomy and embeddedness of the women's organization. Regarding powers, one needs to establish whether and to what extent the women's organization formally

Table 7. Measures for the assessment of parties' women's organizations.

Component	Possible measures
Officially constituted	Established as part of the party's constitution/rules. Status change subject to formal requirements of the constitution/rules.
Resources	Funding protected in party constitution; secured as set percentage of party funds; women's organization(s) personnel paid out of the central funds of the party. Receives 'resources in kind' from the party proper, e.g. offices, admin support, meeting rooms, postage and other materials.
Policy-making powers	Laid out by party constitution/party rules. Has policy initiative rights regarding, and policy veto powers over, explicit women's issues. Women's organization(s) have a formal right to advise on draft election manifestos.
Autonomy	A representative from the women's organization(s) is an equal member of top party policy making forum. Women's organization(s) are a creature of (constituted via election by) women party members. Internal party quotas provide for the representation of women's organization(s) representatives on all internal party bodies. Parity of representation is required by party law/constitution throughout party structures, including parliamentary and executive.
Status	At least equal to other internal party identity groups, for example, youth, minority ethnic groups, LGBT groups (e.g. resources and powers). Fully integrated into party's policy and other decision making bodies, e.g. campaigning and strategy internal structures.
Accountability	How are women's organizations constituted? Are they elected by women party (parliamentary) members? Does the group have an Executive, and if so, are they elected? Are there Executive term limits? How frequently does the organization meet? And how do they decide on what foci and actions they undertake?

participates in policy development. Accountability refers to where the organization sits regarding the party leadership and women party members; whether it is a body 'of' the party leadership, of its women parliamentarians, and, or its party members, and whether it sees itself in a represented/representative relationship with women party members. In addition to these, and reflecting concerns in the wider gender and politics literature, we also ask about ideology: whether if and when these institutions seek explicitly to act for women whether they do so in light of defined feminism

**Figure 2.** The 'good' party member women's organization.

or some other gender or gendered ideology (Celis and Childs, 2012).

Building upon these three dimensions, Table 7 shows how we might operationalize status and remit for comparative empirical research. Many of the measures relate to 'formal' party rules or statutes. For example, it should be relatively easy to determine if a women's organization is officially equal to another similar group, say youth, for example. Ditto, the difficulty or ease it is to abolish such a group – whether this requires a special party rule change, thereby constituting an effective protection from abolition. However, such observation of the formal will also likely need supplementing by consideration of the informal. Formal equivalence between party organizations need not necessarily be real, for example. Similarly, official resources may not capture the effective capacity of a women's organization. Take, for example, the UK Labour party's parliamentary Women's Committee, which usually small in number in terms of attendance at its member meetings, arguably punches symbolically and substantively above this size (Allen and Childs, 2014). On the ground, case study research, both quantitative and qualitative is, then, required.

The outcome of such empirical research informed by our approach can be represented graphically via a spider or radar chart with three legs, as shown in Figure 2. In turn, this will generate ideal types of, and rankings for, women's organizations across these three dimensions.¹³

Conclusion

Documenting the prevalence of political party women's organizations is the first step in better understanding the role played by such bodies in the feminization of political parties, and in better capturing the contemporary form of political parties. This article, drawing on extensive new European quantitative data, should lay to rest the claim that women's party member organizations are old hat, replaced today by party forms that do not provide for group representational institutions. Indeed, given the range of possible party women's organizations, from the purely party member to those including party professionals and

parliamentarians and party leaders, the party politics community needs to undertake more nuanced accounting of the role of women and their institutions when considering the nature of parties and party change. To do otherwise, would be to miss a significant part of what has changed about (some) political parties as well as contemporary features of inter-party competition and party systems. Our findings are clear: many parties, especially traditional parties, retain party member women's organizations. However, no direct relationship with higher levels of women at the MP level or in the NEC is found. Looking beyond simple accounts of descriptive representation, we are also interested in what the presence of women's party organizations means for women's integration within political parties. Importantly, there is little evidence in the European data to support the marginalization thesis. Women members are not restricted to only 'their' parts of the party. Turning to substantive representation, and in addition to some optimism that women are not excluded from the party leadership in parties with women member organizations, in the final section of the article we think through new research questions prompted by our analysis of the Webb et al. data, not least in terms of what kind of women's party bodies would best deliver good substantive representation. Comparative empirical research requires the development of measures that can travel; these have hitherto been absent in respect of women's organizations (Kittilson, 2011). It is for these reasons that we have sought to develop both conceptual indicators and measures in the final part of this article; we hope to prompt subsequent engagement by both gender scholars and comparative party scholars. Despite it lacking from most studies of party politics, feminization – the inclusion and integration of women and women's concerns – should, we contend, be a significant dimension of party scholarship. An important part of this lies with documenting and examining the role played by women's organizations therein.

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Supplemental material

The online appendices are available at <http://ppq.sagepub.com/supplemental>.

Notes

1. www.politicalpartydb.com/.
2. This is another way of talking about the gendered political demands made by party women.

3. Chappell, 2011; Crawford and Pini, 2011; Franceschet, 2010; Hawkesworth, 2003; Kenney, 1996; Krook and Mackay, 2011; Lovenduski, 2005, 1998; Puwar, 2004;
4. Grace, 2010; Kenny and Lowndes, 2011; Lovenduski, 1988; Lovenduski, 2011.
5. There is also, rightly, recognition by Webb et al. that alternative research designs suffer from limitations.
6. We'd like to thank one of the data collectors for this survey for pointing this out to us.
7. Israel is dropped from the analyses below because it is not included in the datasets for party family, party ideology and percentage of women on the National Executive Committee.
8. Data on party family collected from Doring et al. (2011). Parliament and Government Composition Database. Data not published for Israel and a few parties in other countries.
9. Of course, and as Kittilson (2006) has noted previously, the higher presence of women on party National Executive Committees is in turn related to higher numbers of women MPs and the adoption of candidate gender quotas. Take the UK Labour party, for example, qualitative study has shown how the process of quota adoption for parliamentary quotas followed the adoption of internal gender quotas, which in turn and among other factors, provided the women's bodies at party conference who were able to vote in order to pass the necessary rule change introducing parliamentary gender quotas (Childs, 2004; Russell, 2005).
10. We'd like to thank one of the data collectors for the Scarrow and Webb survey for pointing this out to us.
11. In Finland, for example, party regulation laws designate a specific percentage of party funding for women's party activities. When there is a new government after the elections, there are governmental negotiations which include the level of party funding that goes to political party's women's organizations (between 8% and 12% of general funding goes to 'women specific activities') (Kantola and Saari, 2014).
12. See Notes 1 and 2.
13. These findings have the potential, in turn, to affect gender party activists' strategies.

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Author biographies

Sarah L Childs is professor of Politics and Gender at the University of Bristol, UK. She has published widely on women's political representation, party politics and the UK parliament. She is published in *Political Studies*, *Party Politics*, *Representation* and *Politics and Gender*. Her latest books include two 2014 volumes, *Deeds and Words* and *Gender Conservatism and Political Representation*, with Campbell and Celis, respectively, both ECPR, and *Sex, Gender and the Conservative Party*, with Webb, published in 2012 by Palgrave.

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Achieving sex equality in executive appointments

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Abstract

In a political context, the ‘glass ceiling’ is shorthand for the barriers faced by women politicians, resulting in them being less likely to reach executive roles at the same rate as their male colleagues. This article outlines a case where there was sex equality in executive appointments; a cohort study of British Labour Party MPs elected at the 1997 parliamentary election. Examining executive appointments at the cabinet and sub-cabinet level, descriptive analysis shows no statistically significant differences in the proportion of men and women reaching executive positions, or the prestige and gender type of these positions. Regression modelling confirms this, and sex is not found to be a significant driver of these patterns. Three factors are identified that combined to achieve this – critical actors, favourable context and a left-wing party in government. The article concludes with a call for further comparative research using the cohort study method.

Keywords

cabinet appointments, executive appointments, gender and politics

The idea of a ‘glass ceiling’ has gained currency in recent decades as shorthand for the invisible obstacles faced by women on the basis of their sex when attempting to break into the upper echelons of occupational life that leave them less likely to make it into executive and other leadership positions than male colleagues (Arulampalam et al., 2007; Cotter et al., 2001; McDowell et al., 1999; Murray, 2010; Ragins et al., 1998; Reynolds, 1999). Political science has paid increasing attention to the number of women holding executive appointments worldwide, with feminist activists and scholars alike arguing the case for more women to make it into such posts in addition to studying the conditions under which this occurs. Methodologically, many accounts in this field are based on data collected at a specific point in time, providing a ‘snapshot’ of how many men and women hold cabinet or government positions, rather than looking at how the careers of comparable groups of male and female politicians develop over time. Thus, while much is known about the numbers of men and women in executive positions at a given time, little is known about the gendered dynamics of career progression for comparable individuals and how this might present a different picture to the snapshot method.

This article contributes to this literature by adopting a unique cohort study methodology to examine the career trajectories of a group of legislators who all entered the national legislature of the United Kingdom, the House of

Commons, at the time of the 1997 general election. This election saw the numbers of women in the national legislature of the UK double overnight in advance of a long period of single-party government, offering an unprecedented opportunity to assess the longitudinal progress of those women elected at this time. Based on this methodological approach, the article makes an empirical contribution to the literature by demonstrating a case where men and women achieve equality in executive appointments.

Three research questions are addressed – do women reach executive office at the same rate, of the same gender type and of the same prestige, as their male colleagues? The analysis proceeds in two parts. First, descriptive statistics demonstrate that men and women from the cohort make it into cabinet and sub-cabinet positions in roughly equal numbers and that the gendered nature and overall prestige of the offices they hold are also broadly the same. Second, a series of penalized binomial logistic regression models support the descriptive analysis and show that sex is not a

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significant driver of patterns of executive promotion. The situation is one of broad sex equality in appointments. I argue that three factors combine to result in this outcome: the presence of critical actors in gatekeeper roles, a context of pressure for more women in executive positions, and the presence of a party of the left in government that was ideologically amenable to arguments supporting sex equality. Combined, these factors resulted in the shaping of norms around executive appointments that somewhat normalized the presence of women in the executive arena (Annesley et al., 2014). I conclude by highlighting the limitations of the study and call for further comparative research that utilizes the method employed here.

Glass ceilings in a comparative context

According to the US Federal Glass Ceiling Commission the term glass ceiling was first popularized in a journalistic account as the 'invisible barriers that women confront as they approach the top of the corporate hierarchy' (1995: 3). Since then, the term has been widely used in studies of women's progress in the corporate, judicial, academic and political worlds in addition to being utilized in studies of racial inequality (Cotter et al., 2001). In political terms, the underlying logic of the term stipulates that as women move closer to political power held in executive positions, they encounter barriers to entry that are not a result of any 'job-relevant characteristics' that they may or may not hold but rather based solely on their sex. Additionally, the negative impact of these barriers will be 'greater at higher levels of an outcome than at lower' (Cotter et al., 2001: 657–661). This has developed some expectation that higher the office that women achieve in political life, the harder they will find it to reach an even higher one – the so-called 'vertical segregation' (Yule, 2000).¹

Much existing work in this field considers the position of women in cabinet positions across countries, broadly asking three wide-ranging questions. First, how many women are appointed? Second, to what positions? and Third, what are the causes of variation in both numbers and types of appointments?²

In terms of the number of women in cabinet positions worldwide, the data are mixed, but in recent years the overall trend has been one of growth compared to previously low numbers (Bauer and Tremblay, 2011a; Krook and O'Brien, 2012: 841). A number of European countries have had parity or even a majority of women in cabinets. These include Finland, Spain, France and Norway. Conversely, at the time of writing, Italy, Greece and Portugal have been noted as performing especially badly at getting women into cabinet-level roles.³ Women are increasingly seen in prime ministerial or presidential roles, for example, Angela Merkel became the chancellor of Germany in 2005, Jóhanna Sigurðardóttir the prime minister of Iceland in 2009 and

Julia Gillard the prime minister of Australia in 2010. So although the picture is not universally positive, there appears to be a general trend towards more women making it to the top of political life (Bauer and Tremblay, 2011b).⁴

Although such statistics might seem *prima facie* positive, many women are appointed to positions that reinforce traditional gender roles or to roles that hold lower levels of prestige than those more commonly held by men (Krook and O'Brien, 2012: 841–842). For example, rather than holding portfolios that relate to the financial management of government or to military defence, women are more likely to find themselves dealing with issues such as health, education and other issues which are sometimes referred to as 'soft' or 'feminine' areas (Karam and Lovenduski, 2005: 197). However, the extent to which this is necessarily a negative thing is contested: there is a counter-argument that women perhaps choose to pursue such areas ahead of others holding some merit, as well as the fact that many of these areas 'tend to have the largest budgets and the greatest impact on people's daily lives' and therefore, these should not be dismissed out of hand (Murray, 2010: 456). There is also the problem of assessment – how should the femininity or prestige of the policy area of a ministry be judged? Mona Lena Krook and Diana Z. O'Brien utilize a historical approach, taking into account the ways in which policy areas have developed as the domain of either men or women or both (2012: 844). It should be noted, however, that the gender type of policy areas can develop and change over time. For example, education portfolios, once seen as soft, are now perceived quite differently, with ministers in this area holding significant spending power in addition to a portfolio considered to be of great importance by the electorate.⁵ Turning to prestige, they build on the consequentialist approach adopted by Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor Robinson (2005, 2009), which uses notions of visibility and policy control to rank different ministries in addition to the upward mobility that these policy areas provide in terms of future promotional prospects.

Finally, existing research has considered the circumstances under which women tend to increase their presence in cabinet positions. Krook and O'Brien offer three broad factors that will affect the number of women in executive positions – institutional factors, the broader state of gender equality within a country and finally wider political recruitment issues including the number of women already present in a political elite (2012: 846–848), and these factors are reflected in the broader literature (Bauer and Tremblay, 2011a; Siaroff, 2000). Institutional effects include the electoral system, the system of government, the partisan alignment of the governing party(ies), and the proximity of party competition (Krook and O'Brien, 2012: 846–847), in addition to electoral system and the process of cabinet selection. Rebecca Howard Davis distinguishes between generalist models of cabinet recruitment, whereby cabinet members are mostly selected from an eligibility pool comprising a

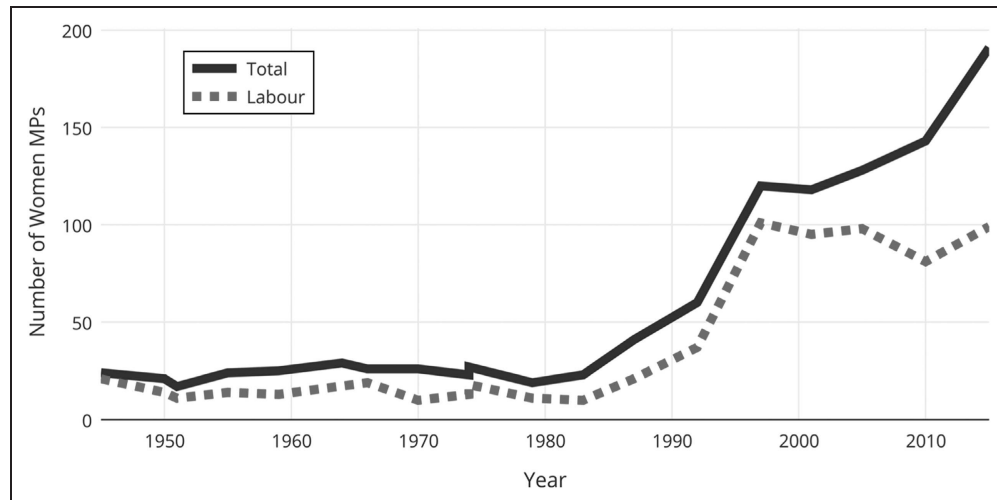


Figure 1. Total women MPs and women MPs from Labour Party 1945–2015.

parliament and specialist models where ministers are selected for their specialist knowledge and are commonly selected from extra-parliamentary locations (1997). The literature largely argues that a generalist model, if combined with an increasing number of women in parliament, should yield a greater number of women in executive positions (Bauer and Tremblay, 2011a; Siaroff, 2000). Bauer and Tremblay write that ‘one may deduce that a situation combining voting systems yielding generous proportions of female legislators with a generalist model for selecting cabinet ministers should have a positive impact on the proportion of women cabinet ministers’ (2011a: 183). However, in many ways, the dynamics of cabinet appointments remain a black box of sorts. As Claire Annesley and her colleagues note, ‘there is much that we do not know about the “... hidden life” of institutions within the executive branch’ (2014: 2).

In terms of understanding broader attitudes to gender equality within a given country, measures include women’s labour force participation, women’s historical role in political leadership and the extent to which this is institutionalized, and how developed the country is overall – modernization often leads to shifting attitudes towards traditional gender roles. The political recruitment traditions of a country, as well as the number of women already present in its political elite, will impact the number of women in cabinet. Whether a woman has ever held a senior institutional role within the national legislature, whether a woman is currently the prime minister or president, what is the percentage of women parliamentarians and whether or not there exists a ministry specifically devoted to women’s affairs, or other state women’s policy agencies, will all have an effect (Krook and O’Brien, 2012: 847–848; Lovenduski, 2008: 174–175). The role of extra-institutional women’s movements is also noted in the literature (Bauer and Tremblay, 2011a).

The British case

Britain is an old parliamentary democracy with a bicameral legislature, the upper House of Parliament being the (mostly) appointed House of Lords, and the lower one, the fully elected House of Commons. The Commons is elected on a single-member constituency basis using a simple majoritarian electoral system commonly dubbed ‘first past the post’. Those candidates who successfully contest elections are subsequently referred to as MPs. The electoral system arguably throws up barriers to the success of women at the candidate selection stage, offering limited turnover due to an abundance of safe seats that are almost always secured by one party as well as removing the opportunity to instil the tenets of gender equality through equal presence on a proportional representation (PR) list system ballot (Norris, 1997: 309–310). The leader of the party with a majority of legislative seats forms a government following an election and draws their cabinet, for the most part, from the House of Commons.⁶ The cabinet is the most senior level of the UK government and contains a mostly consistent number of around 25 ministers, though this fluctuates between administrations and on those occasions when the prime minister, the head of government, chooses to ‘reshuffle’ their cabinet. Utilizing the classification of Davis, the United Kingdom has a generalist model of cabinet selection (1997) and this power of patronage is one of the prime ministers’ single greatest sources of executive authority, ‘the locus of prime ministerial primacy’ within the cabinet (Hennessy, 2001: 68). However, there are active constraints on the prime minister’s use of this power, most notably the requirement to maintain party unity under their leadership, and it cannot be used unfettered.

The House of Commons has seen a slow and steady rise in the number of women MPs over the past 34 years. As shown in Figure 1, the one uncharacteristic leap in the

number of women elected was at the 1997 general election which saw the number of women double overnight on 1 May 1997 from 60 to 120, or from 9.2% to 18.2%. This was in large part due to the all-women shortlists (AWS) imposed by Labour at the candidate selection stage in half of its marginal target constituency seats prior to the 1997 election (Norris, 1997: 306). The party lies to the left of centre of the ideological spectrum and had been out of governmental office for 18 years prior to its 1997 victory. Pursued in the face of significant dissent, the quota had the desired effect, with 64 Labour Party women being elected to parliament for the very first time. This provided new Prime Minister Tony Blair and his successor in 2007, Gordon Brown, with a larger pool of eligible women than any previous prime minister from which to pick their cabinets throughout the next 13 years of Labour government. Figure 1 also highlights the extent to which the overall number of women MPs was essentially equivalent to the number of Labour Party women MPs until the 2010 general election, underlining the importance of studying the internal dynamics of executive appointments within the Labour government between 1997 and 2010.

The institutional structures in place at Westminster (generally) offer stable single-party governments, thanks primarily to the majoritarian electoral system, something considered conducive to the promotion of women to cabinet roles by reducing the trade-offs, which characterize the formation of coalition governments (Krook and O'Brien, 2012: 846).⁷

Societally, in terms of gender equality in a broader sense, the United Kingdom is a relatively equal country, highly economically and socially developed overall and scoring 0.863 in the 2011 United Nations Human Development Index.⁸ That said, this score places the United Kingdom below France, Germany and Spain among others, even if it compares well globally. The employment rate for women aged 16–65 is 66.5% (compared to 76.6% for men), although this is partly a result of women's greater presence in higher education than men.⁹ Women are now more likely to be educated at degree level than men in the United Kingdom, with this gap widening in the university intake of 2012.¹⁰ In global terms, women in the United Kingdom hold a strong economic and social position and as such, the impact of levels of gender equality in the country overall, as identified by Krook and O'Brien, is unlikely to have a notable impact on the presence of women in cabinet positions in contemporary Britain (2012).

Existing work also assesses the impact of whether countries have a tradition of including women in political executives (Krook and O'Brien, 2012). The United Kingdom had its first woman cabinet minister in 1929, with the appointment of Margaret Bondfield as minister of labour, but between then and 1997, only nine other women made it into the cabinet, this despite the fact that a woman, Margaret Thatcher, served as the prime minister from 1979 for

11 years. Since 1997, there have been over 25 further women cabinet ministers, as well as a full-time Minister for Women, although there has been controversy with some office holders combining this with other, perhaps more time-consuming, roles at other ministries (Annesley and Gains, 2010: 918–919). It is clear that the United Kingdom is not in possession of a tradition of sex parity in politics but has rather had middling success at including women in an intermittent fashion.

Data and method

Existing research in this field generally adopts one of two methods. The first is to compare the numbers of men and women in a cabinet; the insinuation being that anything short of sex parity is evidence of sex inequality – a glass ceiling. A second method is to, in addition to the first method, compare the proportion of men and women in executive positions with their respective proportion in the legislature from which the executive is drawn. This method is only applicable in situations where there is a clear selection pool in existence (see, e.g., Bauer and Tremblay, 2011a: 173). The issue with this approach is that it does not always compare like with like. That is, it does not account for intervening factors, namely, the amount of time an individual has spent in a legislature as well as the ways in which political contexts may change over time. For example, counting the respective numbers of men and women in a cabinet alongside their numbers in the legislature following an election which saw an increased number of women elected is a flawed method of assessing sex equality – it takes time for individuals to gain promotions to junior government posts, let alone reach the cabinet. To address this, rather than looking top-down at the number of women and men in executive appointments at a single point in time, the article instead adopts a longitudinal cohort study method to track the progress of women and men elected to the British House of Commons at the same time.

The original individual-level data, collected by the author from official parliamentary data sources, details the political career trajectories of the 178 Labour Party MPs elected for the first time in 1997 – only those MPs who had never sat in the Commons prior to this election. The 1997 cohort provides two main benefits that are unparalleled in the British case. Firstly, it offers a uniquely large group of newly elected women MPs who can be compared directly to their male colleagues elected simultaneously. Secondly, the longevity of the Labour government first brought to power in 1997 provides a significant time period which can be analysed. The party went on to win the 2001 and 2005 general elections, giving them an uninterrupted tenure of 13 years in government.¹¹ Looking at data which cover the entire life of a party in government for a bounded time period allows for the identification of how high men and women MPs rose within the executive hierarchy over the

Table 1. Highest office achievement by sex.

	Backbencher (<i>n</i> = 82)	PPS (<i>n</i> = 31)	Undersecretary of state (<i>n</i> = 23)	Minister of state (<i>n</i> = 32)	Cabinet (<i>n</i> = 10)	Total
Men, % (<i>n</i> = 114)	47.4	18.4	13.2	16.7	4.4	100
Women, % (<i>n</i> = 64)	43.8	15.6	12.5	20.3	7.8	100
Total	45.5	17.4	13.5	18.0	5.6	100

Note: *n* = 178; χ^2 test found no significant differences, *p* = 0.831 (all of the tables in the article report percentages for ease of reader comprehension, although for the statistical analysis raw numbers were used to facilitate accurate significance tests). PPS: private parliamentary secretary.

13 years that their party was in government. There currently exists no comparable UK cohort in terms of either the time span of government or the number of women elected together for the first time and as such this cohort in particular provides a unique opportunity to interrogate any glass ceiling in British political life.

As a dependent variable, I focus on the roles MPs were appointed to within government, specifically looking at which of the offices they reached was the highest.¹² Highest office is coded as either the highest office reached hierarchically in government, or, if multiple posts were reached at the same hierarchical stage, which was more prestigious, between the 1997 and 2010 general elections or when the MP left parliament for electoral or other reasons, whichever came first. There is a naturalized hierarchy of governmental positions, beginning with cabinet roles at the top, minister of state positions beneath these, undersecretary of state roles underneath these and then, finally, private parliamentary secretary (PPS) positions at the bottom, the latter unpaid (Allen, 2013). Although the final category of PPS is technically approved by the prime minister, they are likely to have had little to do with their appointment, this instead being decided by the minister whom the PPS will directly support.¹³ As such, these offices are not directly comparable to the others listed above and will not be included in the analysis. I use Krook and O'Brien's framework for assessing the presence and status of women in governmental roles, by looking at 'numbers, gender, and prestige' (2012: 842). The *number of women* is a self-explanatory way of measuring the progress of women. The *gendered nature* of the positions they are appointed to as well as their *prestige* will be coded for using the guidelines laid out by Krook and O'Brien, with only minor alterations being necessary (2012: 846).¹⁴

Descriptive analysis of the effect of sex on executive appointments

Numbers

There is a clear hierarchy of governmental positions in the United Kingdom, and therefore the numeric distribution of women across this parliamentary hierarchy matters. The rationale for comparing cabinet roles with wider governmental positions is based on the glass ceiling expectation of fewer women in the higher positions. This is assumed in the

Table 2. Gender-type of highest government role by sex.

	Masculine (<i>n</i> = 27)	Feminine (<i>n</i> = 11)	Neutral (<i>n</i> = 27)	Total
Men, % (<i>n</i> = 39)	46.2	10.3	43.6	100
Women, % (<i>n</i> = 26)	34.6	26.9	38.5	100
Total	41.5	41.5	16.9	100

n = 65. Fisher's exact test found no significant differences, *p* = 0.208.

existing literature – where power is, women are not (Davis, 1997).¹⁵

As shown in Table 1, there are no statistically significant differences between the highest office achievements of men and women. At the lower end of the hierarchy, 3% more women than men left the backbench altogether. At the higher end, 7% more women had reached either the cabinet or the minister of state levels than men did. Thus, a slightly higher proportion of women reached cabinet and minister of state roles than men did, while a lower proportion of women than men saw their careers peak at the PPS or undersecretary of the state level.

Even when looking at the percentage of posts at each hierarchical level held by MPs of each sex (as opposed to looking at the proportion of men versus the proportion of women reaching each level), of the 10 cabinet positions taken by those MPs first elected in 1997, women took 50%. Of the 32 minister of state roles occupied as a highest office by that same group of MPs, women took 41%, this despite their raw numeric disadvantage relative to men.

Gender type

Existing research notes that although women may be present in relatively high numbers in cabinet positions, they are often placed in roles that augment existing norms and stereotypes of gendered socialization (Lawless, 2012). The dominant coding schema across previous comparative work classifies ministries by their gender type, delineating between those which are masculine, feminine or neutral (Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005: 838; Krook and O'Brien, 2012: 846). As noted above, I have adapted this for use in the British case. The findings for cabinet positions only are shown in Table 2.

Table 3. Gender-type of highest cabinet role by sex.

	Masculine (<i>n</i> = 6)	Feminine (<i>n</i> = 2)	Neutral (<i>n</i> = 2)	Total
Men, % (<i>n</i> = 5)	60	20	20	100
Women, % (<i>n</i> = 5)	60	20	20	100
Total	100	100	100	100

Note: *n* = 10. Fisher's exact test found no significant differences, *p* = 1.000.

Table 4. Highest cabinet role prestige by sex.

	Low prestige (<i>n</i> = 3)	Medium prestige (<i>n</i> = 3)	High prestige (<i>n</i> = 4)	Total
Men (%) (<i>n</i> = 5)	40	0	60	100
Women (%) (<i>n</i> = 5)	20	60	20	100
Total	100	100	100	100

Note: *n* = 10. Fisher's exact test found no significant differences, *p* = 0.286.

As seen in Table 3, the gender type of those cabinet roles achieved by men and women are identical. The three women appointed to masculine-type positions were Ruth Kelly as secretary of state for transport, Jacqui Smith as home secretary and Yvette Cooper as secretary of state for work and pensions. Based on this measure, as with the previous measure of numeric presence, women and men are equal in terms of cabinet appointments by gender-type portfolio. Increasing the number of cases by additionally including sub-cabinet positions tells a similar story shown in Table 2.

Table 2, showing the highest office appointments of those MPs who reached at least the level of undersecretary of State, finds no sexed division of role type and no statistically significant differences across portfolio assignment; 65.4% of women hold positions coded as either neutral or feminine in comparison to 53.9% of men), and almost 50% of men hold masculine-type portfolios compared to 36.4% of women.

Prestige

The third measure of women's executive presence is the relative prestige of the offices they are appointed to. Existing research has laid out the criteria and benefits of higher prestige offices to women ministers, which include greater visibility and increased policy control in addition to greater springboard capability into other offices (Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005, 2009).

Despite the small *n*, the pattern of cabinet-level sex equality is also clear in Table 4, with exact tests finding no statistically significant differences in the prestige of portfolio areas held by male and female cabinet ministers, a finding different to those seen elsewhere in the literature

Table 5. Highest government role prestige by sex.

	Low prestige (<i>n</i> = 14)	Medium prestige (<i>n</i> = 40)	High prestige (<i>n</i> = 11)	Total
Men, % (<i>n</i> = 39)	17.9	59.0	23.1	100
Women, % (<i>n</i> = 26)	26.9	65.4	7.7	100
Total	100	100	100	100

Note: *n* = 65. χ^2 test found no significant differences, *p* = 0.238.

(Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005: 838–839). The sole woman appointed to a high-prestige role from the 1997 intake was Jacqui Smith who became home secretary.¹⁶ This reflects the findings of other studies and highlights that women do gain appointment to such high-prestige posts (Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005). This pattern is interrogated further in the multivariate analysis below.

Expanding the sample to sub-cabinet positions, shown in Table 5, sees the majority of both sexes holding medium-prestige posts, and no statistically significant differences between men and women; 23.1% of men reach high-prestige posts compared to 7.7% of women, but over half of both held medium-prestige offices as their highest government office reflecting the scarcity of high-prestige offices.

Modelling the effect of sex on executive appointments

Building on the descriptive statistics above, multivariate analysis allows for the establishment of the relative effect size of sex alongside other predictors of front bench and executive appointments drawn from the existing literature (Berlinski et al. 2012). The multivariate analysis proceeds in two parts – first, a binomial logistic regression model fitted by Firth's Penalized Maximum Likelihood Method establishes that sex does not appear to affect progression to the front bench relative to other variables such as political experience or level of education. Second, two further binomial models, also fitted using Firth's method, suggest that this is also true of the gender type of such appointments as well as their prestige. The Firth Penalized Maximum Likelihood Method is used in this case to avoid the small sample bias that can be found when using traditional maximum likelihood estimates in logistic regression models, in particular when the number of 'events' in the dependent variable is small relative to the number of non-events (Firth 1993; Heinze and Schemper, 2002). These models are estimated using the 'logistf' package in R (Heinze, 2013).

In addition to a binary sex variable, all three models shown in Table 6 include the same additional independent variables that together represent those characteristics that might be expected to affect various dimensions of front

Table 6. Penalized binary logistic regression models of the impact of MP characteristics on promotion to front bench office, high-prestige portfolios and masculine portfolios.

	Model 1 – Promoted to front bench position	Model 2 – Promoted to high-prestige portfolio	Model 3 – Promoted to masculine portfolio
Variables	β (SE)	β (SE)	β (SE)
Constant	2.567*** (0.800)	0.348 (1.247)	1.150 (0.974)
Sex (woman)	−0.014 (0.345)	−0.822 (0.713)	−0.249 (0.464)
Instrumental occupational experience	0.372 (0.348)	0.191 (0.611)	0.191 (0.447)
Degree educated	0.614 (0.394)	−0.762 (0.627)	0.172 (0.539)
Election age (by decade)	−1.018*** (0.240)	−0.804 (0.406)	−1.086*** (0.307)
Log likelihood	3.324	1.963	2.784
N	178	178	178

***Denotes statistical significance at the 0.001 level.

bench promotions. Measuring the ‘quality’ of politicians could be done in myriad ways, and is in many ways problematic, but existing work has utilized measures of candidate quality which include legislative experience, wider political experience and also occupational experience (Murray, 2010). In addition, to this could be added educational qualifications and age at time of first election, these all factors which might be measures of quality or preparedness for office in some way but also as a route into understanding the differences, if any, between men and women MPs in this cohort. Evidently, there will be no sex differences in legislative experience at the national level – all of these men and women were elected for the first time at the same election. Based on this, I include the following three covariates. First is a variable that denotes whether the MP holds pre-parliamentary political experience at the national level. Second, there is a dummy variable indicating whether the MP is educated to degree level. Third, I include a measure of the age at which the MP was first elected. This is grouped by decade. The models are necessarily parsimonious but allow for the impact of sex to be estimated.

Across all three models shown in Table 6, it is clear that sex is not the driving patterns of promotion into front bench positions or affecting the types of portfolios to which legislators are assigned. This supports the descriptive findings outlined above. In models 1 and 3, age has a significant effect on the outcome variable, indicating that being elected young improves the odds of gaining promotion not only to front bench office overall but also to front bench office of masculine portfolio type. Model 2 is less clear, with no variables having a statistically significant effect on the outcome in question. This might be reflective of the ‘black box’ nature of factors driving high-prestige ministerial appointments and additionally could be a product of the small number of high-prestige positions available to access. In other words, it is hard to know precisely what differentiates those MPs who do reach those kinds of portfolios from those who do not.

Discussion – explaining a case of sex equality in executive appointments

Descriptively, there were no significant differences between the proportions of men and women first elected to the British House of Commons at the 1997 general election making it into executive positions, no significant differences between the gender type of the portfolios they held, and no significant differences between the prestige of those portfolios. Additionally, logistic regression models support the descriptive findings, suggesting that sex was not a driver of any promotional patterns seen across the period covered by this study. How to explain this? I argue that the New Labour era saw a combination of factors come together to provide the recipe for sex equality in executive appointments. I claim that there are three main explanatory variables: the presence of critical actors in gatekeeper roles, a wider context of pressure for increased numbers of women leaders and a left-wing party in government that was supportive of principles of sex equality.

Critical actors in gatekeeper roles

There is ample evidence that the leadership of the Labour Party wanted women in prominent positions within both the party and government. Primarily, the adoption of AWS prior to the 1997 election resulted in the election of an unprecedented number of women MPs. In the face of legal challenges, Blair dropped the policy in 1996, but re-introduced it for the 2005 general election following its full legalization under the Sex Discrimination (Election Candidates) Act passed in 2001 (Campbell and Lovenduski, 2005; Squires, 1996). In his pursuit of the AWS policy despite opposition, Blair arguably fulfilled the role of ‘critical actor’, a term which refers to ‘those who act individually or collectively to bring about women-friendly policy change’ (Childs and Krook, 2009: 126–127). While the United Kingdom continues to use a majoritarian electoral system with single-member constituencies, any moves

to bolster women's presence through the use of quotas will remain politically costly for those who pursue them, regardless of outside support.¹⁷ However, Blair's persistence paid off, with the images of him surrounded by new women MPs becoming iconic. A proactive political elite, in the role of gatekeeper, is necessary to maintain momentum in terms not only of getting women elected but also of getting women promoted, and into governmental roles focused on various policy areas.

Context of pressure for more women leaders

The pressure to challenge these norms, and consistently act to further women in the party came from advocates inside and beyond Labour. Maria Eagle and Joni Lovenduski note that 'by the 1980s, a number of feminist voices in different parts of the Labour party were campaigning for power for women' (1998: 5). Clare Short describes this movement within the party as 'a quiet revolution' (1996: 17). Short notes how earlier Labour leaders, especially Neil Kinnock, instigated the feminization of the party, and points out that this was completely in line with an international movement among similar socialist parties (1996: 18). The late 1980s saw an increased sense 'that the party had to make itself more women-friendly' (Short, 1996: 19). Meg Russell, in a similar vein, notes that the presence of women in the parliamentary party following the 1997 general election kept the issue of women's representation within the party on the agenda. Overall, this movement within the party, almost a decade old by 1997, created a context of pressure for women to be appointed to top positions within the party. Combined with increased numbers of women rising to the top of politics in other European countries, it was simply no longer acceptable for the party leadership to not include large numbers of women.

Left-wing party of government

The Labour Party held an additional commitment to women and equality in a broader sense. As reflected in the comparative literature, parties of the left are generally better at getting women into national legislatures than parties of the right, both by using sex quotas of some kind and by promoting women once they are in the eligibility pool (Caul 2001; Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005: 840).¹⁸ The party's commitment to sex equality was evident in both the adoption of AWS in order to increase the number of women MPs, and thus the potential supply pool for cabinet positions, and in the broader promotion of women's equality through the establishment of the minister for women position as well as in a wider gender mainstreaming agenda (Cowley, 2007: 28–29; Squires and Wickham-Jones, 2004).

This article generally paints a positive, if qualified, story. Clearly, questions remain regarding the sexed

distribution of executive portfolios in government. The relative desire of women legislators to substantively represent other women may affect the portfolios they both desire and attain, something dependent in part on the enthusiasm of political parties to incorporate these desires into their political programmes, in addition to whether governments are comprised of parties of the left or are coalitions (Curtin, 2008). Sarah Childs, reporting evidence from women MPs elected in 1997, highlights the perception of a tension between substantively representing the interests of women and getting promotions to top governmental positions – a lone MP alerted Childs to 'a perceived tension between a feminized transformation of politics and a successful parliamentary career for individual women MPs' (2004: 131). Assessing the extent to which this is true is beyond the scope of this article, but it is possible to speculate that a government not amenable to 'women's' concerns might exacerbate such a tension, making it hard for women looking to further women's interests to make it into executive positions.

In sum, this section offers some explanation of the empirical patterns of sex equality in executive appointments, which focuses on three elements that aided the patterns discussed above. The Labour government elected in 1997 had demonstrated a clear and broad commitment to the principles of sex equality, most notably through the adoption of a party sex quota in the form of all-women shortlists. This policy led to an increased number of women in the House of Commons, with their overall number doubling overnight at the time of the 1997 general election. Concurrent with this was a desire to increase the numbers of women at the top of the Labour government. Utilizing the theory of critical actors, it has been argued that Blair and Brown, as well as other ministers of both sexes in their governments, were critical actors, taking action which resulted in women-friendly outcomes. Overall, these factors combined to contribute to the case of equality highlighted for the first time in this article.

Conclusion

This article has discussed the executive office attainments of the 64 women who entered the House of Commons as Labour MPs following the general election in May 1997. Utilizing original data which tracks the careers of men and women from the same political generation, it has been shown descriptively that women proportionally achieve high office in equal numbers to men. Additionally, there is no statistically significant difference between men and women in terms of either the gender type of any portfolio they hold or the prestige of their office. Logistic regression models also indicate that sex was not a driver of any patterns of executive promotion across the period studied. Although it is hard to say with any precision whether this constituted a sea change in gender attitudes among British

parliamentarians or was simply a one-off, it is clear that the men and women of the 1997 general election cohort achieved executive office unaffected by explicit sex discrimination, a finding that challenges the glass ceiling discourse.

This empirical contribution arises from a methodological approach not previously used in this literature, a cohort study approach. This looks simultaneously at the political career trajectories of men and women elected at the same time, under identical political circumstances. Given the findings of the article, which run contrary to much existing scholarship in the field, the findings suggest that scholars should in future look at the proportional appointment of men and women who were elected at the same time to executive positions. This provides more accurate estimation of the presence of discrimination than ‘top-down’ accounts that compare the numbers of each sex in an executive at a single point in time or that compare the overall numbers of men and women in executive positions to their number in the legislature from which they are drawn.

The article has highlighted factors, which resulted in sex equality across executive appointments in this case and has also raised questions about those factors, which could result in the opposite, using the United Kingdom as a case study example. These findings apply directly to the sole cohort analysed here – the situation will likely differ under a right-leaning government, for example, or over time, as women parliamentarians embed themselves further into the norms and culture of legislative life. In this case, the mix of critical actors and a political environment conducive to the appointment of more women to executive roles was pivotal, given the inherently informal nature of the rules that govern executive promotion (Annesley et al., 2014).

The article has also thought beyond the British case, utilizing comparative concepts as outlined by Krook and O’Brien among others (Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005, 2012), opening the door for further country-specific case studies to develop in a similar fashion. Such case studies allow for detailed examinations of how country- or region-specific political contexts, often at specific moments, can interact with broader factors, conceptualized comparatively, such as electoral systems and institutional structures. In particular, studies such as this one should nurture discussion of how women in cabinet can substantively represent women at the top of political life as well as consider how these frameworks would apply to ethnic minority legislators in addition to other minority groups (Childs and Krook, 2009). In terms of future comparative work, a similar study which includes more European cases should test for any contagion effects, something which has been found in studies of Latin American cabinets (Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson, 2005: 841). Additionally, this work adds to a growing selection of scholarship which utilizes the study of political careers to understand the similarities and differences in the

ways in which men and women politicians enter and progress in a given political system (Lawless, 2012; Lawless and Fox, 2005) and, cumulatively, will hopefully provoke mainstream studies to consider the effect of sex on cabinet appointments in a more detailed way.

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Notes

1. Although I will not explore this here, there is a well-rehearsed normative argument as to why it matters how many women are appointed to cabinet positions, an argument drawn from notions of democratic health, the representation of women’s interests in policy-making processes, and from justice. See, for example, Phillips (1995, 1998, 2012).
2. I acknowledge here that there are other approaches to the study of women in cabinet. For example, Berlinski et al. model the differing influence of various factors, including sex, on the likelihood of being promoted to a cabinet position (see Berlinski et al., 2012). Additionally, rather than focusing on highest office attainment, it would also be of interest to look at patterns of career trajectory by sex, looking at variables such as number of offices occupied overall in addition to the relative prestige of first office appointments. These are, however, different research questions to the one being examined in this article; suffice to say, there are multiple methodological approaches to the issue of women in executive roles.
3. http://guide2womenleaders.com/situation_in_2014.htm (last accessed 22 June 2015).
4. It is worth noting here that there is a tacit assumption when considering these figures that women want to be in cabinet, an assumption that equally is made of both sexes in much of the political ambition literature (see Schlesinger, 1966). In this article, I too will make this assumption as if almost without doubt that, to quote Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor Robinson, ‘some ambitious politicians of both genders want to be cabinet ministers because ministers influence policy and control extensive resources’ (2005: 830). Additionally, empirical evidences from Childs (2004) and Cowley (2007) suggest that there was no significant difference in the political ambitions of new MPs of either sex elected in 1997, with just over 60% of both men and women stating their ambition to be a minister in a decade’s time.
5. For example, at the US Presidential elections of 2008 and 2012, almost 70% of voters listed education as a ‘very important’ priority for them when casting their vote,

- <http://www.people-press.org/2012/09/24/for-voters-its-still-the-economy/> (last accessed 20 December 2014).
6. It is, however, common to see cabinet ministers being drawn from the Lords, though it is rare for them to hold the most prestigious roles. The government has numerous representatives in the Lords, but these are mostly sub-cabinet-level posts.
 7. Since the May 2010 general election, however, the United Kingdom has had a coalition government formed by the right-leaning Conservative Party and the centre-left Liberal Democrat Party. The implications of this for the topic in hand will be discussed in the concluding remarks of the article.
 8. This figure is used in other comparable studies, such as Krook and O'Brien (2012) and Escobar-Lemmon and Taylor-Robinson (2005). Data obtained from <http://hdr.undp.org/en/reports/global/hdr2011/> (last accessed 20 December 2014).
 9. Taken from the UK Office for National Statistics Labour Market Statistics, February 2013, http://www.ons.gov.uk/ons/dcp171778_297429.pdf (last accessed 20 December 2014).
 10. Data taken from <http://www.bbc.co.uk/news/education-21698522> (last accessed 20 December 2014).
 11. Evidently, there have been longer-serving governments in Britain in the post-war period, most notably the Conservative government which was in power from 1979 to 1997, but the low numbers of women elected for the party in that time preclude any in-depth statistical analysis.
 12. I collected individual-level, cross-sectional data on 178 Labour Party MPs first elected to the UK House of Commons at the May 1997 General Election, comprising 114 men and 64 women. The Labour Party, led by Tony Blair, who became the prime minister following the election, won a landslide victory and held a House of Commons majority of 179 seats. Data were sourced from the Dod's Parliamentary Companion volumes in addition to the House of Commons website, <http://www.parliament.uk/business/commons/> (last accessed 20 December 2014).
 13. A private parliamentary secretary (PPS) can be characterized as the eyes and ears of a minister on the floor of the House of Commons, bringing them news from the backbench as well as relaying the general mood of the parliamentary party. Cabinet ministers all have their own PPS, but ministers of state and undersecretary of state often share a single PPS.
 14. The main alterations and addition to Krook and O'Brien's coding schema are as follows. Government whips, whose role is to enforce roll call voting in the House of Commons, were coded as gender-type neutral and given medium prestige. Positions in the Department for International Development were coded as gender-type masculine but were given only medium prestige despite being related in some way to foreign affairs. This is because the position deals with issues similar to those of a welfare role that happen to be on an international scale, thus involving little in the way of diplomacy and other areas associated with foreign affairs portfolios.
 15. A Fisher's exact test was used in some cases where the data violate the assumptions of a χ^2 test. As Fisher's test is conservative in nature, p values have been reported throughout the article for readers' benefit and own interpretation. Although it could be said that the article presents a full population analysis, by looking to make a more substantial point about whether sex matters (or not) in executive appointments, running robust descriptives or analytical models that examine particular effects requires a way of gauging influence on the outcome. As such, it is necessary to generate β s, related standard errors and then the subsequent p values and the significance associated with these. Consequently, all of the above are reported throughout.
 16. It is also of note that Smith was selected from an all-woman shortlist at the candidate selection stage. Differences in the political careers of quota and non-quota women in this cohort were found to be non-existent by Allen et al (2014).
 17. Recent polling in the United Kingdom regarding quotas, albeit quotas for boardroom positions, puts support for quotas at 30% compared to 45% who oppose them. Data taken from <http://yougov.co.uk/news/2011/03/12/gender-quotas-britain/> (last accessed 20 December 2014).
 18. It should be noted, however, that many parties from the right of the political spectrum have placed increasing emphasis on getting more women elected. See Celis and Childs (2014) for discussion of this.

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Intersectional institutions: Representing women and ethnic minorities in the British Labour Party

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Abstract

The political representation of women and ethnic minorities has received growing attention among political parties around the world. Focusing on the British case, we map data and debates concerning the selection of female and minority candidates, highlighting the simultaneous and interactive role of gender and race in shaping citizens' opportunities to stand for and win election. Utilizing data from the Labour Party, our analysis illustrates the implications of distinct strategies to include members of politically marginalized groups—as well as provides evidence for the potential of “tandem quotas” to result in positive outcomes for minority women. Taken together, these findings suggest the need for stronger measures on the part of Labour to encourage the selection of minority candidates; a shift from “single-axis” to “multiple-axis” thinking when devising strategies to enhance group representation; and rejection of a “zero-sum” mentality regarding the nomination of female and minority candidates.

Keywords

British politics, candidate selection, gender and politics, gender quotas, race and politics

In recent elections, the political representation of women and black, Asian, and minority ethnic (BAME) communities has received growing attention among the three major British political parties. Both groups won a record number of seats in the House of Commons in 2010, resulting in 22.8% female members of parliament (MPs) and 4.2% BAME MPs. These numbers grew again in 2015 to 29.4% women and 6.3% BAME parliamentarians. However, these figures remain far from proportional to these groups' share of the population, standing at 50.9% and 12.9%, respectively.¹ Ethnic minority women have been even more underrepresented, at 1.5% of all MPs in 2010 and 3.1% of MPs in 2015. Such patterns are replicated elsewhere: a global study calculates that minority women comprise a mere 2.1% of national legislators, compared to their 11.2% share of the population (Hughes, 2013: 501).²

Experiences of minority women have inspired the concept of “intersectionality,” describing the ways in which oppressions are interrelated (Crenshaw, 1991; Hancock, 2007). Research and activism on diversity and political representation, however, often does not adopt an intersectional approach, instead addressing sex discrimination separately from racial discrimination, and vice versa. Such

“single-axis thinking” tends to privilege the interests of advantaged subgroups, namely white women and ethnic minority men (Holmsten et al., 2010). Improving the political representation of ethnic minority women thus suffers from what Spelman (1988) calls the “ampersand problem,” falling between efforts to promote members of these two categories separately. Single-axis thinking, moreover, can foster a sense of hierarchy or competition among marginalized groups—in turn diverting attention from the dynamics of advantage privileging dominant groups (McCall, 2005).

Advocating a shift to “multiple-axis thinking,” this article examines the British case, applying an intersectional perspective to compare patterns of election, debates for inclusion, and the impact of distinct measures to enhance

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Table 1. Percentage of women and ethnic minorities, parliamentary party delegations.

	Labour			Conservative			Liberal democrats		
	% Women	% BAME	% BAME women	% Women	% BAME	% BAME women	% Women	% BAME	% BAME women
1987	9.2	1.7	0.4	4.5	0	0	4.5	0	0
1992	13.7	1.8	0.4	6.0	0.3	0	10.0	0	0
1997	24.2	2.2	0.5	7.8	0	0	6.5	0	0
2001	23.1	2.9	0.5	8.5	0	0	9.6	0	0
2005	27.6	3.7	0.6	8.6	1.0	0	16.1	0	0
2010	31.4	6.2	3.1	16.0	3.6	0.6	12.3	0	0
2015	42.7	9.9	6.0	20.6	5.1	1.5	0	0	0

Note: BAME: black, Asian, and minority ethnic.

Source: House of Commons, own calculations.

the political representation of women and BAME groups. The first section presents data illustrating the gendered and raced dimensions of access to parliament, as well as the simultaneous and interactive role of gender and race in shaping citizens' opportunities to stand for and win election. Combining intersectionality with the insights of feminist institutionalism (Kenny, 2013; Krook, 2009), we argue that the formal and informal rules, practices, and norms of candidate selection are both gendered and raced (cf. Hawkesworth, 2003). We propose that attention to "intersectional institutions" is vital for forging new paths in research as well as for underscoring the need to devise party strategies tackling multiple axes of discrimination.

The second section turns to the current state of research and action taken to address the underrepresentation of women and BAME groups in British politics. Single-axis thinking predominates in both areas. A review of the academic literature reveals that gender scholars rarely engage with questions of race, while race scholars generally overlook issues of gender. A similar separation is reflected in political practice, in at least two respects. First, the legal status of positive action for these groups differs: parties may restrict candidacies in a constituency to women (a strategy known as "all-women shortlists" (AWS)) but may not do so in the case of ethnic minorities (a so-called "all-black shortlist" (ABS)). Second, the Labour Party—which has adopted stronger measures to promote the selection of more diverse candidates than the other parties—applies distinct provisions to these two groups. This separation not only renders invisible the specific challenges faced by BAME women but has also resulted in debates that frame women and ethnic minorities as competitors in the struggle for increased political representation.

The third section utilizes a unique dataset obtained from the Labour Party,³ tracking the sex and race of individuals participating in the four stages of the selection process for prospective parliamentary candidates in the run-up to the 2015 elections. We observe the implications of distinct strategies to include members of politically marginalized

groups, with the share of women and BAME aspirants at each stage revealing weaker results in terms of selecting and electing BAME candidates. The data also provide intriguing evidence regarding the potential of "tandem quotas"—attention to both sex and race in selection decisions—to result in positive outcomes for minority women. The article concludes by reflecting on implications for future initiatives to enhance political inclusiveness in Britain, highlighting the need for stronger measures to encourage the selection of BAME candidates and the importance of reframing the representation of women and minorities as a positive- rather than a negative-sum game.

Intersectional institutions

Recent elections in the United Kingdom have resulted in greater diversity among the members of the House of Commons. Between 2010 and 2015, the share of women increased from 22.8% to 29.4%, while the proportion of BAME members rose from 4.2% to 6.3%. The number of BAME women has also climbed over time, although their presence remains disproportionate. Prior to 2010, there had only been two Black and no Asian female MPs. The total increased to 10 in 2010 and to 20 in 2015, doubling from 1.5% to 3.1% of all MPs. Yet, this still reflects less than half of BAME women's share of the population. Nonetheless, recent increases do better capture intra-category diversity: minority women now constitute 10.5% of female MPs, slightly less than the BAME share of the population, and 48.7% of BAME MPs, compared to half of the population which is female.

These aggregate figures obscure important differences across parties, however. In comparison to the Conservatives and Liberal Democrats, Labour has long elected the largest proportion of women and ethnic minority MPs in both relative and absolute terms (see Table 1). Although the Conservatives elected more women in 2015 than ever before, rising from 47 to 68 female MPs, this amounted to only 20.6% of the party's total MPs—less than half of women's share of Labour MPs at 42.7%, as women's

numbers grew from 87 to 99 even as the party lost 24 seats. Similar patterns appear for BAME MPs. At first glance, this is surprising, given that in the run-up to the 2015 elections, the Conservatives led all parties in selecting 10% candidates from non-White backgrounds, compared to 8% by Labour and the Liberal Democrats, respectively. Yet, the three parties differed substantially in terms of where these candidates were selected. Labour placed its BAME candidates in more winnable and marginal seats, resulting in 9.9% minority MPs, versus 5.1% BAME MPs among the Conservatives and 0% among the Liberal Democrats.⁴ Labour similarly leads when it comes to the representation of BAME women, electing 14 of the 20 minority women MPs in 2015 and 8 of the 10 minority women MPs in 2010. Together, these patterns point to both gendered and raced dimensions of political exclusion.

The data also reveal that these dynamics work together, with BAME women being even more underrepresented than white women and minority men. Consequently, opportunities to stand for and win election are subject to simultaneous as well as interactive processes of gender and race.⁵ The concept of “intersectionality” highlights these interrelations (Hancock, 2007), illustrating that “the intersectional experience is greater than the sum of racism and sexism” (Crenshaw, 1989: 140). Single-axis analyses of sexism and racism may thus unwittingly incorporate racist and sexist assumptions, respectively, into their theoretical frames. An intersectional perspective is thus vital for analyzing patterns of candidate selection as well as for devising effective solutions to tackle multiple inequalities.

Over the years, research on intersectionality has moved increasingly toward more structural approaches, calling for greater attention to structures and institutions that give meaning to politicized identities (Smooth, 2013). This view, importantly, says nothing about the effects of these structures on particular individuals, who may have differing views and experiences even as they are socially positioned in similar ways (Weldon, 2006). A similar shift toward focusing on structures has also been seen in the literature on political recruitment. Traditional approaches propose that the share of women and ethnic minorities elected is the combined result of the qualifications of group members to run for political office (“supply”) and the desire or willingness of party elites to select these aspirants (“demand”) (Norris and Lovenduski, 1995). More recent contributions build on these frameworks using institutional theory, conceptualizing human behavior as being shaped by various types of “institutions,” namely “formal constraints—such as the rules that human beings devise—and informal constraints—such as conventions and codes of behavior” (North, 1990: 3–4).

Combining feminist theory with an institutionalist perspective, Krook (2009) theorizes candidate selection in terms of three types of gendered institutions: formal rules,

formal and informal practices, and formal and informal norms, which together shape the likelihood that women will be selected (cf. Bjarnegård, 2013; Kenny, 2013). Feminist institutionalism attends to the ways that institutions not only endure (informed by traditional institutionalism) but can also be changed through deliberate political strategies (taken from feminist political science) (Krook and Mackay, 2011). Despite its focus on gender, we argue that feminist institutionalism can be accommodated with an intersectional perspective, and moreover, that the core intuitions behind feminist institutionalism can and should be applied to the study of other groups. We thus propose focusing on *intersectional institutions* of candidate selection. Data from the British case provides initial validation of this approach. First, variations in the election of women and ethnic minorities indicate differences in rules, practices, and norms of candidate selection across political parties. Second, changes witnessed over time, as parties have come to rethink how they select candidates, suggest that rules, practices, and norms can be re-gendered and/or re-raced.

Focusing on intersectional institutions builds upon recent efforts to expand the theoretical and empirical remit of prior work on diversity and political representation. Although most research analyzes the experiences of a single group, emerging studies have begun to address different groups together. New studies, for example, map the ways in which multiple groups make claims for—or are identified by party elites as requiring—measures to ensure their representation (Bjarnegård and Zetterberg, 2014; Celis and Erzeel, 2013; Krook and O’Brien, 2010; Reiser, 2014). Yet analyses exploring inequalities within these categories remain rare, especially in cases outside the United States. One exception is the work of Hughes (2011), finding that quotas for women tend to favor women from dominant ethnicities, while provisions for minorities tend to benefit minority men. Compellingly, however, her data also show that where quotas for women and minorities—or “tandem quotas”—are applied, minority women are more proportionately represented.

Based on evidence from more than 80 countries, Hughes (2011) thus points to the dynamics of exclusion at work within single-group strategies to enhance political representation—as well as lends support to the intuition that a multigroup lens may achieve greater diversity among those elected. The latter approach may appear in both formal and informal guises. An example of an explicit intersectional approach is the policy in Uganda requiring that women be included within the other groups guaranteed representation: women must occupy 2 of the 10 seats reserved for the military, 1 of the 5 seats set aside for youth, 1 of the 5 seats for people with disabilities, and 1 of the 5 seats reserved for workers. A more informal tactic is the pragmatic “intersectional puzzling” that occurs in Belgium and the Netherlands as parties seek to increase the diversity of their

electoral slates. In these processes, minority women may enjoy a “complementarity advantage” because their identity features maximally complement those of incumbents (Celis and Erzeel, 2015; Celis et al., 2014).

Attention to multiple facets of identity, moreover, is consistent with the lived experiences of minority women. Submissions to the 2009 Speaker’s Conference on Parliamentary Representation⁶ indicate a clear awareness regarding multiple forms of discrimination on the part of BAME women. The National Muslim Women’s Advisory Group referred to the barriers that Muslim women face in terms of sexual discrimination and cultural prejudice, affecting their ability to develop the networks and skills necessary to be successful in politics.⁷ FATIMA Women’s Network described the need for “a very high level of courage almost bordering on the masochistic” for ethnic minority women to come forward as candidates, due to experiences with “multiple disadvantage and discrimination.”⁸ A shift from single-axis to multiple-axis thinking is thus required in order to combat potential exclusions within efforts to enhance the political representation of different groups.

Gender, race, and British politics

Apart from a few exceptional cases, women and ethnic minorities are underrepresented in electoral politics around the world (Hughes, 2011). Many commentators thus offer parallel arguments for these groups, arguing that their enhanced political presence is necessary for the sake of justice, the promotion of group interests, and the broader legitimacy of the polity (Mansbridge, 1999; Phillips, 1995). Despite awareness that both women and ethnic minorities face barriers to election, academic studies and political practices have tended to focus on one of these groups to the exclusion of the other (Krook, 2014). These global trends are evident in the United Kingdom, where single-axis thinking characterizes both research and action taken to address the underrepresentation of women and BAME groups. This “logic of separation,” in the words of Bassel and Emejulu (2010), has the effect of placing demands for these groups on distinct trajectories and framing these groups as competitors for increased representation, in turn rendering invisible the specific challenges faced by minority women.

The academic literature on women and ethnic minorities in British politics is impressively large, expanding rapidly over the last 15 years. Yet research on these two topics has proceeded more or less independently from one another. Studies on women in politics in the United Kingdom make little or no mention of race (among others, see Childs, 2004; Lovenduski, 2012; Mackay, 2004). At the same time, key texts on race and ethnicity in British politics offer few or no references to gender (among others, see Garbaye, 2005; Heath et al., 2013; Sagar, 1998; Sobolewska,

2013). When gender is mentioned by race scholars, the focus is not on their interaction but on how policies for women might serve as an example for ethnic minorities (Hampshire, 2012). Across both literatures, challenges faced by BAME women are rarely discussed, apart from observing the paucity of non-white women elected (Childs, 2010).

A rare exception is Norris and Lovenduski’s (1995) study of political recruitment, examining the role of gender, race, and class in shaping paths to a parliamentary career. Yet their analysis treats these identities as largely independent: In the quantitative work, the variables for gender and race are never interacted, and in the discussion, gender and race appear in separate subsections.⁹ Their conclusions include statements like “black applicants seem to suffer greater disadvantage than women” (1995: 142), with no reference to diversity within either group. Although never explicitly expressed, however, their work is “protointersectional” in the sense of deeming gender, race, and class to be essential elements for understanding the processes and outcomes of candidate selection.¹⁰ Some parts of the analysis also hint at the simultaneous nature of axes of oppression. For example, Norris and Lovenduski identify the “insider strategy” as the most common path to the House of Commons, with the ability of candidates to tap into existing elite networks and present themselves as “one of us” as the key to success. While the authors do not discuss the gender and racial dimensions of these networks, white male dominance of these networks opens the way—implicitly—to a more intersectional approach.

In a parallel fashion, campaigns to enhance the political inclusion of these groups have taken different paths. In contrast to group-based quotas elsewhere, reserving seats or mandating a certain proportion of group members on candidate lists (Krook and O’Brien, 2010), the British electoral system—organized around single-member districts—has led parties to focus on the composition of the aspirant shortlists considered before a single candidate is chosen. A strong version of this strategy is to require that final shortlists include only members of a certain group, thereby ensuring that someone from that group is selected. A milder form is to require that shortlists include some members of the group, with no further restrictions, thereby permitting members of any group to be the party’s nominee. During the 1990s, the Labour Party was sued by male and minority members on grounds that it had violated the Sex Discrimination Act (SDA, passed in 1975) and Race Relations Act (RRA, approved in 1965 and revised in 1968 and 1976). Following these court challenges, the SDA was reformed to allow parties to use AWS, while the RRA has remained intact, introducing ambiguities regarding the legality of ABS as a measure to enhance BAME representation.¹¹

The origins of AWS can be traced back to the compulsory shortlisting rules introduced by the Social Democratic

Party (later the Liberal Democrats) and the Labour Party in the 1980s. These policies mandated that at least one woman (later two women) be included on every shortlist (Love-nduski and Randall, 1993). After Labour lost the 1992 elections, Labour women argued that enhancing women's representation might help close gender gaps in voter support (Perrigo, 1996). They proposed that AWS be used in half of vacant seats the party was likely to win, a policy that was approved at the 1993 party conference. As the AWS policy was put into motion, the party was sued in 1995 by two male members, Peter Jepson and Roger Dyas-Elliott. Bringing the case to an industrial tribunal, they argued that their exclusion from candidate selection in AWS districts violated the SDA, which in section 13 prohibited sex discrimination in judging qualifications for employment.¹² The party's lawyer responded that candidates were office holders, not employees. Rather, candidate regulations fell under section 33, which allowed parties to make special provisions for one sex.

In giving its judgment, the tribunal agreed that MPs did not have employment contracts, but argued that candidate selection did constitute a qualification for becoming an MP. For that reason, it found that the AWS policy violated the employment provisions of the SDA, as it did not allow men to be considered as candidates in certain districts (*Jepson and Dyas-Elliott v. The Labour Party and Others*). Although supporters of the policy urged the party to appeal the decision, and there were good legal grounds for doing so,¹³ leaders decided that an appeal was not worth the risk, as the judgment did not affect the 35 women who had already been selected via AWS in other districts, but an appeal might cast all of these selections into doubt (Russell, 2000). Keeping these women on as candidates contributed to a doubling in the proportion of women in parliament from 9% in 1992 to 18% in 1997.¹⁴

After the number of female MPs fell in 2001, the Labour government proposed a bill to reform the SDA to exclude from its purview acts taken by parties to reduce inequalities in the numbers of men and women elected. Opposition parties did not object to the bill, enabling it to pass all stages without a vote in 2002. A key reason was the bill's permissive nature: it did not compel but simply allowed positive action (Childs, 2003). It also contained a "sunset clause" stating that the reform would expire in 2015 unless otherwise extended. Labour responded by reinstituting its AWS policy. The Liberal Democrats considered but rejected AWS at the 2001 party conference. They retained the compulsory shortlisting policy and established a Gender Balance Taskforce.¹⁵ In 2009, party leader Nick Clegg stated that while he "did not see [AWS] as a panacea," he would consider them if the party's number of female MPs did not improve in the next election.¹⁶ The party did not subsequently change its politics (Evans, 2011) but did launch a leadership program to identify and train female candidates.¹⁷

The Conservatives were slower to take up the issue, but this changed in 2005 with the election of David Cameron as the party leader. In his first speeches, he pledged to "end the scandal of women's underrepresentation," declaring that "the sound of modern Britain is a complex harmony, not a male voice choir."¹⁸ One week later, he proposed a "priority list" consisting of at least 50% women from which Conservative-held and target constituencies would be required to select their candidates (Campbell et al., 2006). He dropped this policy several months later in favor of requiring local parties to consider gender-balanced shortlists at every stage. In 2009, he committed to AWS in districts where candidates had not yet been selected for the 2010 elections, but this was never implemented.¹⁹ Conservative voters, party officials, and MPs remain hostile to "quotas" (Childs and Webb, 2011),²⁰ and when some female MPs expressed support for AWS in 2014, their statements were rebuked by party members and senior officials. The party has instead relied on the Women2Win campaign to encourage women to stand as candidates.²¹

Over the last 20 years, the issue of women's representation has thus reached the agenda of all three major parties. While only Labour has adopted AWS, Liberal Democrat and Conservative leaders have both acknowledged to some degree their validity as a strategy to secure the nomination of female candidates. The idea of applying ABS, in contrast, has found relatively little traction, including within the Labour Party—despite the fact that the party has elected the vast majority of BAME MPs (Ali and O'Connneide, 2002). Although the first South Asian MP was elected in 1892, most MPs with BAME backgrounds arrived more recently: the first four Black MPs were elected in 1987 (including the first Black female MP) and the first Muslim MP was elected in 1997 (followed in 2010 by the first two female Muslim MPs). ABS were briefly debated in 1993, but party leaders decided to take more time to consider this proposal (Norris, 1997). After the 1997 elections, Labour changed its selection procedures to require that shortlists in each district be gender balanced and include at least one ethnic minority candidate. Introducing this rule, however, did not lead to a major increase in the number of minority candidates selected and elected in 2001 (Ali and O'Connneide, 2002).

Further, despite Labour's record on minority representation, problems with discrimination were rife in a number of constituencies (Shukra, 1998; Solomos and Back, 1995). Events in the Sparkhill Ward of Birmingham, a district with a large Pakistani population, led party member Raghieb Ahsan to file a case with the industrial tribunal, claiming that the party had discriminated against him on racial grounds, contrary to section 12 of the RRA. Between 1991 and 1998, he was the ward's representative on the local council and hoped to be re-selected. The Sparkhill branch had been suspended for nearly 3 years by the central leadership, however, along with three other constituency

parties with the highest concentration of ethnic minority groups, stemming from accusations of corruption. An inquiry found no evidence to this effect, but the candidate chosen for Sparkhill without involvement of the local branch was a white man. Despite the fact that the white man did not qualify as a candidate under party rules related to time as a party member, the panel argued that he was “best placed to counter some of the problems which had arisen in the ward . . . closely associated with the Pakistani community.”

Like Jepson, Ahsan argued that being a councilor was a profession and that party authorization to stand as a candidate was necessary for him to be elected.²² The Labour Party responded that section 12 did not apply because a political career was not the same as employment. As the question was pending, a list of approved candidates was circulated from which Ahsan’s name was removed on the grounds that he had brought proceedings against the party. This incident was the subject of his second complaint to the tribunal in September 1998, this time alleging victimization contrary to section 2 (1) of the RRA. When the tribunal found against the party on the question of employment, the party appealed the decision but had the appeal dismissed (*Sawyer v. Ahsan*). In 2000, Ahsan made yet a third complaint of racial discrimination, again under section 12, in connection with the selection of candidates that year and his candidature for the local party executive committee.

Meanwhile, in an unrelated case (*Ali v. McDonagh*), the Court of Appeals found that Labour was not the type of body to which section 12 applied. Yet the Employment Appeals Tribunal decided it was bound by the unappealed decision in Ahsan’s first case, finding in his favor on all three counts. The Court of Appeals then decided that Ahsan had not been discriminated against on racial grounds, deeming the party’s wish not to have a Pakistani candidate to be a “legitimate objective” if acts of corruption were in fact associated with this community. Ahsan next turned to the House of Lords, which allowed the appeal because racial makeup was what enabled it to be described as a “Pakistani community.” In 2007, the Lords restored the initial decision that the party had engaged in racial discrimination but argued that the grounds for this decision lay in section 25, dealing with discrimination by associations against their members or prospective members (*Watt [Carter] v. Ahsan*). In other words, proper jurisdiction for claims of discrimination was the county court, not the industrial tribunal—returning to the pre-Jepson status quo (Morris, 2012).

These legal ambiguities led to brief discussions at the 2001 party conference of including race when reforming the SDA, but this was later dropped. At the time, the reigning interpretation from *Sawyer v. Ahsan* was that section 12 did apply to candidate selection and forbid discrimination, positive or negative (Russell, 2001). Following the 2001 elections, the Labour National Executive Committee

(NEC) suggested openly that some local parties might be asked to use ABS, especially in areas with high BAME populations. If that failed, they stated, they would consider proposing a bill to reform the RRA in a similar way to the SDA.²³ Party leaders issued calls 5 years later for districts with high BAME populations to use ABS,²⁴ while also holding meetings with a leading Black pressure group, Operation Black Vote. Several prominent Labour politicians came out in favor of ABS, but a private member’s bill introduced in 2008 by Keith Vaz, an Asian Labour MP, to reform the RRA did not garner widespread support.²⁵

The result of these debates has been a continued distinction between the legality of measures to promote the political representation of women and BAME groups. Notably, the 2010 Equality Act, consolidating more than 100 pieces of antidiscrimination legislation, extends the use of AWS until 2030. In contrast, it does not permit shortlists comprised solely of people selected on grounds of race or disability, although it does allow parties to reserve places on shortlists for such groups (Kelly and White, 2009). While the final report of the Speakers’ Conference urged reform of the RRA to allow parties to use strategies to promote the representation of BAME candidates similar to those in effect for women, legal reform to permit ABS has not been forthcoming—even as top party leaders recognized it was “wrong” not to have more ethnic minority MPs.²⁶

Although the Conservatives and Liberal Democrats have joined Labour in instituting measures and programs to stimulate minority representation, all three approaches fall short of the guarantees offered by AWS in winnable districts. When Cameron became party leader in 2005, he promised to increase diversity by selecting a “significant” proportion of BAME candidates in Conservative held and target constituencies (Campbell et al., 2006). Due to this “A-list” strategy, a record share of BAME candidates were nominated for the 2010 elections, with the result that the number of minority Conservative MPs grew from 2 to 11, although this represented only 3.6% of Conservative MPs overall (Wood and Cracknell, 2013: 4). The Liberal Democrats—with no BAME MPs—considered, but rejected, a motion at their 2010 conference to require at least one BAME person on candidate shortlists. Instead, a weaker provision was approved, establishing targets for BAME representation and training opportunities for BAME aspirants.

Frustration at the lack of BAME candidates for the 2015 elections generated new calls among some Labour activists and MPs to institute ABS, with the Labour Black Network launching a “manifesto for change” at the 2014 party conference to “right the wrong of poor representation of Black members.” Data in December 2014 revealed that Labour had selected the fewest BAME candidates for the seats of retiring MPs, generally the parties’ safest seats: only 2.9%, compared to 15.6% for the Conservatives and 10% for the Liberal Democrats.²⁷ BAME groups have been critical of

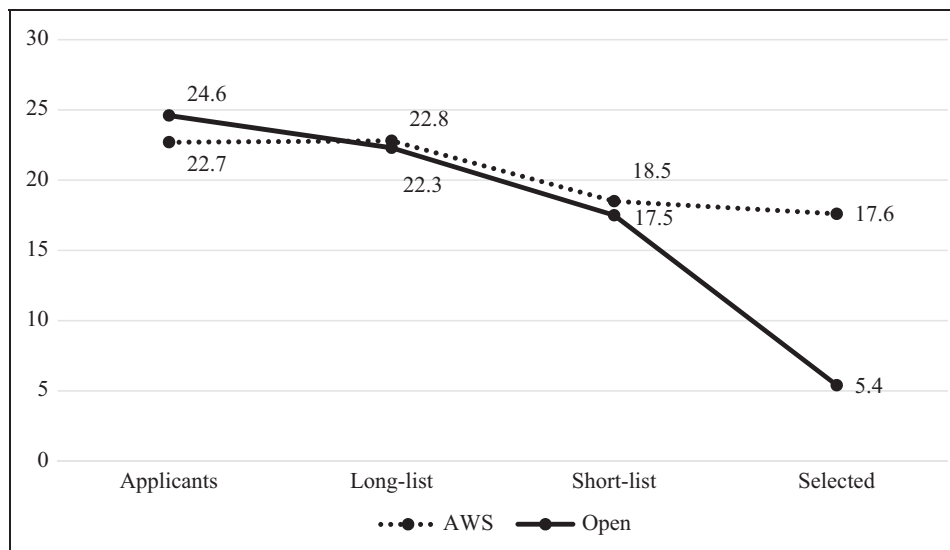


Figure 1. Proportion of BAME aspirants in Labour Party selections, open and AWS seats. BAME: Black, Asian, and minority ethnic. Source: Labour Party, own calculations.

AWS, framing the representation of women and ethnic minorities in zero-sum terms.²⁸ One approach is to condemn AWS on intersectional grounds, noting that AWS have been “all-white-women-shortlists,” in the words of Diane Abbott, the first Black female MP.²⁹ Similarly, in 2007, Asian MP Keith Vaz expressed frustration that “whenever there’s a chance of getting another ethnic minority candidate in, an all-women shortlist is imposed ... no black or Asian person has ever been selected from an all-woman shortlist.”³⁰ Until 2005, the empirical evidence shows this to be true: between 1997 and 2005, not a single BAME woman was nominated or elected via an AWS. Yet the picture began to change in 2010, when BAME women comprised 14.3% of candidates selected and 12.7% of those elected via AWS, roughly equivalent to the BAME share of the population.

A second mode of criticism, however, is by far the more common. Setting up an opposition between the representation of white women and black men, some BAME activists and politicians have suggested that the use of AWS comes at the cost of black men being represented. For example, after a white woman was selected in West Ham, a seat with a 60% BAME population, on an AWS in 2005, Simon Woolley of Operation Black Vote stated that “black Britain will be asking what must we do to get selected for a Labour Party seat.”³¹ Similar arguments have also been voiced where AWS have not been applied and BAME women have been selected. Frustrated at not being chosen in Edmonton in 2015, a local Labour councilor resigned from the party, claiming that it had “actively undermined possibilities for African Caribbean men to have the opportunity to stand for parliament by virtue of the way that it has implemented its policy on all-women shortlists.”³² Taken together, party policies and such statements point to the

ongoing prevalence of single-axis thinking in British party politics.

Candidate selection in the UK Labour party

The final report of the Speaker’s Conference concluded that parties should publish diversity data on their candidate selections. Details on female, BAME, disabled, and lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) candidates were posted on both the Labour and Liberal Democrat websites,³³ while the Conservatives simply listed the names and constituencies of their candidates. In addition to this publicly available data, the Labour Party tracked the sex, race, disability, and sexual identity and orientation of individuals participating in the selection process. The data set that we obtained in May 2015 includes all 414 seats that Labour contested, with complete data on all four stages—applicants, longlists, shortlists, and winners—for 130 open seats and 35 AWS seats.

Consistent with a single-axis mentality, the data report the total number of women and BAME candidates at each stage, but not whether any of these women were non-white or if any of the minority applicants were female. As such, it is not possible to know exactly how many BAME men versus women participated in the open selections. Yet, because the data for AWS constituencies only includes women by definition, it is possible to compare the fates of white versus BAME women. Figure 1 shows the share of BAME aspirants at each stage, tracking the percentage of BAME candidates across open and AWS seats. This mapping reveals that more BAME individuals apply to be candidates in open districts. Slightly more BAME aspirants reach the longlisting and shortlisting stages in AWS

districts. At the final stage, however, these numbers diverge sharply: BAME women constituted 17.6% of those selected via AWS, while BAME aspirants—male and female *together*—comprised only 5.4% of open selections. This pattern similarly holds when examining data from all 414 selections: 8.7% of all constituencies chose a BAME candidate, but this share increases to 11.5% in AWS districts.

These patterns contradict the expectations, already dispelled for the 2010 elections, that AWS block the selection of BAME candidates. Instead, evidence from the 2015 elections indicates that BAME women fare much better in these selections than in the open seats. There is also a close correspondence between their proportion on final shortlists and among the candidates ultimately selected. Using figures from the last census, we explored whether these differing fates were the result of the demographics of the constituencies in question, but find that AWS seats have a lower proportion of BAME voters than open seats. The greater success rate of minority women in AWS districts thus is not due to the presence of a high BAME population.

We argue that the distinct selection rules governing female and minority candidates offers clues to explain these trends. The party's official procedures mandate that BAME candidates be longlisted where BAME aspirants submit applications and urge "due consideration" to BAME candidates over the course of the selection process. However, there is no requirement to select BAME aspirants at the final stage, the moment at which there is a dramatic decline in the BAME share. Interviews with female MPs and activists from the three major parties,³⁴ all of which have compulsory shortlisting rules for women, provide some insight into why this drop-off occurs. Interviewees noted that, while compulsory shortlisting may expand access to members of underrepresented groups, it may be potentially counterproductive. This is because, while selection panels must consider female and minority aspirants, they are not obliged to pick them, thus allowing officials to "tick a box" before going on to choose white men. Evidence to this effect can be seen in the results of the 2001 elections, when the Labour Party only applied gender-balanced shortlists and fewer women were nominated or elected (Krook, 2009).

In combination with the policy of AWS, however, the compulsory shortlisting rule for BAME aspirants appears to benefit BAME women, along the lines of a "tandem quota." Two sets of dynamics might set in motion "multiple-axis" thinking. The first has to do with what types of districts volunteer for AWS. The process by which Labour decides which seats will employ AWS is opaque at best.³⁵ It does, however, involve the chance for constituencies to volunteer and for regional bodies to consider which seats would be best suited to an AWS (Cutts et al., 2008). According to a party insider, it is vital to know "where people were positive" as well as "where the resistance was."³⁶ Reasons for volunteering are not always clear, but

it may be that those seats that are more open to women may also be more open to selecting a non-white candidate, given that this choice reflects an awareness—and a desire to mitigate—the underrepresentation of a politically excluded group.

A second possibility relates to the candidate selection process itself. Once districts for AWS are assigned, constituencies with open contests may feel that the task of diversifying the party's candidates has already been taken care of in other seats. Evidence on policy representation lends some support to this intuition: redistricting in the United States to ensure the presence of blacks and Latinos in Congress has been shown to reduce support for minority-sponsored legislation on the part of legislators from now majority white districts, who no longer feel obliged to respond to minority community concerns (Cameron et al., 1996). At the same time, gaining an AWS may instill a greater sense of responsibility among selectors to pick candidates who do not look like the vast majority of the party—what one interviewee described as "developing a genuine commitment" to select more diverse candidates.³⁷

Black MPs and pressure groups may have contributed to this trend through their vocal concerns that AWS come at the cost of BAME representation: while there were no non-white AWS candidates through 2005, the selection of minority women increased for the 2010 and 2015 elections—suggesting awareness-rising or learning among selectors to more seriously consider BAME women. Calls for AWS and ABS, in other words, may mutually reinforce one another akin to a tandem quota. These dynamics can be seen in a selection that took place in early 2015 in Edmonton, a relatively safe Labour seat that is also one of the most ethnically diverse, with 67% of constituents having a BAME background. The local party had been "divided on the issue" of AWS, and ultimately, the NEC designated the district as "open" because many female candidates had been selected elsewhere.³⁸ Attracting more than 100 applicants, the longlist of 12 included both men and women and BAME and non-BAME aspirants. As the shortlist was being decided, BAME Labour wrote a letter to the local party chair, urging him to apply an ABS. Possibly influenced by calls for AWS and ABS, the committee selected a shortlist of three BAME women.

Although minority women typically lose out in efforts to promote the election of women and/or ethnic minorities, dynamics such as these point to evolving practices and norms regarding the political recruitment of minority women, facilitated by the existence of rules—while disparate—for women and ethnic minorities in candidate selection processes. Despite the small sample size, the stronger outcomes for BAME women in 2015, moreover, appear to be linked to the more robust guarantees inherent in the AWS policy. More specifically, one-fifth (20%) of the BAME women elected to parliament were selected in open seats, compared to nearly one-half (43%) of the white

women. Six of the eight new BAME MPs elected by Labour were female—four of these in AWS districts. AWS thus appear to be crucial in helping to close gaps in representation for minority women, albeit in conjunction with calls for greater BAME representation overall.

Implications and conclusions

Women and ethnic minorities face challenges to being elected to national parliaments around the world. In the British case, both groups have been recognized as requiring specific measures to help level the political playing field, with all three major parties taking some steps to recruit and select more female and BAME candidates. These debates have been by far the most extensive in the Labour Party, which has also elected the most female and ethnic minority members in both relative and absolute terms. Yet, the party has introduced distinct policies regarding these groups in its candidate selection procedures. Through the policy of AWS, the party guarantees that female candidates will be selected in at least some of the districts that the party is likely to win. BAME applicants, in contrast, must be included in the longlisting and shortlisting stages, but there is no requirement to choose a minority candidate. The result has been weaker results in terms of selecting and electing BAME candidates.

The relative success of AWS in achieving greater levels of female representation is rooted in greater clarity regarding the legality of positive action in candidate selection as it concerns women. While they remain controversial, AWS have delivered for Labour in terms of reducing barriers for well-prepared women to stand as candidates, maintaining or attracting party vote shares, and producing diligent and active MPs (Nugent and Krook, 2015). Similar policies for BAME candidates stand on more ambiguous legal grounds. Many observers believe that reforming the RRA would be necessary before ABS could be introduced—restricting the field to BAME candidates from the start, rather than de facto after non-BAME candidates have been considered but then eliminated. Frustration at the lack of BAME candidates has led some to blame the policy of AWS as a factor blocking BAME representation. Yet, the data examined in this article indicates that minority women have greater chances to be selected in AWS as compared to open seats.

The evidence examined in this article—derived from interviews, court cases, and quantitative selection data—together generate three conclusions for the future. First, disparate outcomes suggest the need for stronger measures on the part of Labour to encourage the selection of BAME candidates, especially in districts with large minority populations. In addition to ABS, these might include stronger targets for selecting BAME candidates in particular regions of the country. Second, single-axis thinking is both inaccurate and exclusionary, as it overlooks the experiences—and indeed, existence—of minority women. Tandem quotas, in

contrast, appear to enhance the electoral prospects of BAME women, in the United Kingdom as elsewhere. Third, shifting away from a zero-sum mentality is vitally important for moving debates ahead in a productive way. Framing the issue as women gaining at the expense of ethnic minorities, or vice versa, misses the mark in terms of tackling their shared target of white male dominance—thereby allowing it to persist while marginalized groups struggle among each other for a small share of seats. As Bjarnegård (2013) points out, asking not why some groups are underrepresented, but why other groups are overrepresented, can open up for examination the dynamics preserving existing relations of power.

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Notes

1. <http://www.ipu.org/wmn-e/classif.htm> and <http://www.ons.gov.uk/ons/rel/census/2011-census/index.html>
2. The share of minority men is largely proportional, at 10.8% of national legislators versus 11.3% of society.
3. We would like to thank the Labour Party for making this data available to us.
4. <http://parliamentarycandidates.org/uncategorized/uk-elects-most-diverse-parliament/>
5. In the British context, other politically marginalized groups that have been the focus of debate in recent years include those based on class, sexual orientation, and disability.
6. The Speaker's Conference worked during 2009 to consider why women, ethnic minorities, disabled people, and gays and lesbians were underrepresented in UK politics—and to propose solutions to correct this imbalance (for a summary and critical analysis, see Lovenduski, 2010).
7. <http://www.publications.parliament.uk/pa/spconf/167/167we41.htm>
8. <http://www.publications.parliament.uk/pa/spconf/167/167we43.htm>
9. The book also discusses class dynamics but does not address how class might interact with gender or race.

10. Phillips (1995) is similarly “protointersectional,” addressing gender and race but in separate chapters.
11. Several all-black shortlists have emerged from aspirant pools that originally included white candidates; these would not be illegal, as they were not restricted to BAME citizens from the outset.
12. Bringing the case to the industrial tribunal was also a strategic choice, because if a person brings a case to the court and loses, they are not responsible for paying the defense’s legal costs (Interview, May 2012).
13. The decision and jurisdiction of the court hinged upon MPs being “employees,” yet British tax authorities treat MPs separately because they are not employees (Interviews, May and July 2012, January 2013).
14. Legal ambiguities shaped strategies to increase women’s representation in the new Scottish Parliament and National Assembly for Wales—which took the form of “twinning” and “zipping” rather than AWS (Krook, 2009).
15. Interviews, May and July 2012.
16. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2009/oct/20/cameron-all-women-shortlists>
17. Interviews, May 2012. The party subsequently adopted AWS at their 2016 party conference.
18. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2005/dec/16/conservatives.liberaldemocrats>
19. Interviews, May and July 2012.
20. Interviews, May and July 2012.
21. <http://www.women2win.com/>
22. Although there was no communication among the men bringing these cases, the choice to file the case in the industrial tribunal versus another court again related to the costs involved (Interview, May 2012).
23. <http://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/politics/labour-considers-allblack-shortlists-for-next-election-9159073.html>
24. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2007/sep/25/labour-conference.labour12>
25. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2008/feb/10/harrietharman.labour>
26. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2007/sep/03/uk.race>; <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2008/feb/10/harrietharman.labour>
27. <http://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/politics/labour-shuns-black-and-asian-candidates-in-winnable-seats-9950913.html>
28. Interviews, July 2012.
29. <http://www.telegraph.co.uk/news/uknews/5195686/Sketch-the-all-white-women-shortlists.html>
30. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2007/sep/03/uk.race>
31. <http://www.theguardian.com/politics/2005/feb/23/labour.uk>
32. <http://www.voice-online.co.uk/article/labour-reveals-all-woman-bme-shortlist-edmonton>
33. <http://www.labour.org.uk/pages/promoting-diversity> and http://www.libdems.org.uk/candidate_diversity
34. Interviews, May and July 2012, January 2013.
35. <http://labourlist.org/2013/03/labour-should-choose-which-seats-are-aws-by-lottery/>
36. Interview, January 2013.
37. Interview, July 2012.
38. Interview, February 2015.

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Feminist allies and strategic partners: Exploring the relationship between the women's movement and political parties

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Abstract

Western political parties have been in decline in recent decades and they continue to be viewed as male institutions. Despite this, electoral politics is important to the women's movement as a means by which to advance feminist interests. This article builds upon feminist critiques of political parties by analyzing original qualitative data undertaken with feminists in the United States and United Kingdom in order to explore how activists view political parties. The research finds that although many hold negative views, in line with broader debates concerning disengagement, they also recognize the importance of electoral politics and the need to work with individual politicians. Party and feminist ideology shapes those views, whereby politicians on the left are viewed as feminist allies and those on the right are framed as strategic partners.

Keywords

feminism, US and UK Parties, women's movement

Introduction

Good relationships between the women's movement and political parties are (largely) to the benefit of both: the latter profit from greater representative legitimacy, while the former can influence policies and campaigns (Lovenduski, 2005). The women's movement is currently in resurgence across the Western world, with grassroots activism occurring beyond the legislative sphere (Maddison and Sawyer, 2013; Weldon, 2012). Conversely, political parties are widely considered to be in decline; with disengagement fuelled by ideological centralization and professionalization (Mair, 2005; Whiteley, 2011). The male-dominated nature of political parties and the relative lack of attention paid to women's issues are additional reasons for feminist critiques (Young, 2000). Received wisdom concerning the close relationship between feminists and parties of the left (Lovenduski and Randall, 1993) has been called into question by studies that have explored the extent to which parties on the right can and do represent women's interests (Celis and Childs, 2012; Cott, 1984), making it less clear which parties (if any) feminists might choose to align themselves to. This research considers feminist attitudes to political parties in the United States and United Kingdom, in doing so it speaks to wider debates concerning the decline of political parties and feminist

critiques of parties as male institutions. This article has four central findings: (1) that feminist activists, particularly in the United Kingdom, are largely disengaged with party politics; (2) that despite high levels of disengagement, there is continued support for the association of the women's movement with leftist parties; (3) feminists are much more willing to identify individual politicians, particularly those on the left, as feminist and (4) individual politicians on the right are also identified as having a role to play in the representation of women's interests.

Political scientists have observed a growing disengagement with parties in the west: in part this can be explained by increasing ideological centralization and a tendency towards professionalization that has left them unresponsive to the views of voters, members and activists (Hajnal and Lee, 2011; Mair, 2005; van Biezen et al., 2012). These debates are nothing new, indeed 'scathing denunciations' of political parties are a leitmotif of modern political

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history (Scarrow, 2002: 1). While, scholars have acknowledged the claims that parties are too far removed from the citizenry, they have also countered claims that political parties no longer have a role to play in modern politics. Research illustrates that parties continue to resonate with popular opinion (Hetherington, 2001) and that they are sustained by their adaptability to changing social and economic environments (Enyedi, 2014; Webb, 1995). For some on the left, political parties constitute hollowed out institutions that no longer adequately fulfil their representative function, particularly in the wake of economic and democratic crises (Castells, 2012; Harvey, 2005). This article illustrates that feminist activists, widely considered to be on the political left, also articulate this sense of disengagement. Of course, their views of political parties are also shaped by the extent to which parties are considered to be 'institutionally sexist' (Lovenduski, 2005: 57–58).

Feminist analyses of political parties have tended to focus on their failure to adequately represent women: either descriptively, in terms of the number of elected women present, or substantively, the extent to which they pursue policy goals that advance women's interests (Young, 2000). Feminizing a political party is complicated: there is no 'one size fits all' approach to include, promote and advance women and women's interests (Kittilson, 2006: 2). Furthermore, whether that descriptive and/or substantive representation articulated by parties is *feminist*, is central to understanding how responsive parties are to the women's movement (Childs, 2008). Of course, structural opportunities and constraints of the party system shape the responsiveness of parties to feminist interests (Kittilson, 2006). For instance, creating competition among parties, in terms of capturing women's votes and claim-making vis-à-vis women's policies, could in theory encourage parties to be innovators with regards women's policies (Kantola and Squires, 2012). However, the organization of political parties, policies pursued and candidate selection are all underpinned by masculine norms (Kenny, 2013), which reinforces female exclusion and male dominance (Lovenduski, 2005). This article argues that these critiques resonate with feminist activists.

Party ideology, the ideas and policies espoused by the party organization and politicians, also help influence individual level attitudes: indeed, previous research has highlighted how party ideology and feminist ideology shape feminist attitudes (Lovenduski, 2005). Despite well-observed ties between US and UK women's organizations and parties of the left (Lovenduski and Randall, 1993; Young, 2000), the women's movement has at times distanced itself from political parties (Gelb, 1986), emphasizing its non-partisan character (Sapiro, 1986).¹ Moreover, the received wisdom that feminists are natural allies of leftist parties has not always been borne out by historical analysis (Cott, 1984). Women have long been active within conservative movement politics (Schreiber, 2014), whilst

party ideology on women's rights can change: for instance, the Republicans used to be more pro-choice and more supportive of campaigns for the Equal Rights Amendment than the Democrats (Williams, 2011; Wolbrecht, 2000: 3).² However, during periods of partisan polarization leftist parties are traditionally more sympathetic to women's concerns, for instance during the Reagan and Thatcher administrations (Bashevkin, 1994). The parallel with today's partisan context, particularly in the United States, is striking. Indeed, the Republican's 'War on Women', largely constituting of attacks on reproductive rights, does not make it an obvious site within which to pursue feminist goals. Meanwhile, the UK's Conservative party have been attacked by women's organizations for failing to account for gender in their budgets; although the party has, at least rhetorically, sought to address women's concerns (Childs and Webb, 2011).³ As such, analysis has explored how parties of the right articulate a conservative form of feminism (Celis and Childs, 2012). Thus, we can see the potential for party ideology to shape the interaction between which *types* of parties the women's movement may choose to work with, especially in the United States. However, party ideology is not fixed and does not preclude pragmatic partnerships. This research finds that traditional partisan patterns shape contemporary feminist attitudes towards political parties, although some feminists recognize the importance of forming strategic alliances with those on the right.

If party ideology can have a significant impact on attitudes towards political parties then so too must feminist ideology. Research has shown the continued importance of radical and socialist feminism for United Kingdom activists; in the United States, the influence of black feminism is notable, as is the lack of any feminist ideological identification (Evans, 2015). There are some assumptions we might make regarding the influence of feminist ideology: we might expect those who identify as radical feminists to view parties as traditional sites of male dominance (Millett, 1970); Black feminists to be critical of parties that have not sought to address issues of inclusion (Leighley, 2005); socialist feminists to be more likely to engage with parties that either explicitly articulate a socialist position or broader leftist agenda (Gelb, 1986); liberal feminists to be most likely to seek to work within existing institutions in order to bring about reform (Young, 2000); while those who lack a clear feminist ideology may also be less willing to identify as partisan. At the same time, it is also the case that certain types of feminism are more 'easily accommodated' by political parties than others (Lovenduski and Randall, 1993: 134). Lisa Young has argued that a 'defining characteristic' of the US women's movement is its emphasis on electoral and party politics (2000: 27). While this may be true for large women's organizations, it is not clear whether or not this also reflects the views of grassroots activists, or whether such an interpretation works in a UK context.

Methods

The research adopts a paired comparative method in order to provide a rich and detailed analysis of qualitative data that goes beyond the exploration of a single case study (Tarrow, 2010). Undertaking comparative analysis of feminist attitudes towards political parties is interesting largely because of the differences in systems, parties and political opportunities in the United States and United Kingdom. In gauging levels of partisan identification, voters in the United States can identify as independent rather than with one of the two main parties,⁴ whereas in the UK voters are typically invited to select from a list of parties or to select none at all. Money plays a significant role in US elections, something that has arguably entrenched an elite bias in party organization (Stratmann, 2005), whereas UK parties (although far from being models of mass participation) do at least still rely on local party activists. While US federalism, in theory, allows for more windows of opportunity to influence state-level parties (Robertson, 2012), the more centralized UK system means much party business is directed from Westminster (Davidson and Elstub, 2014) providing a focus for feminist lobbying. Exploring the views of feminists towards political parties in two such different contexts allows us to also reflect upon the impact that systems have on attitudes towards political parties.

Traditionally, attitudinal studies of political parties are quantitative: this article takes a different methodological approach by utilizing qualitative interviews in order to provide a rich illustrative account of feminist attitudes. Such an approach is helpful in this particular area as it allows for a more fulsome exploration of the kinds of ideas and issues that emerge when discussing parties with activists. Furthermore, it also affords an opportunity to consider how party and feminist ideology interact with individual political attitudes in order to shape the participant's views. The data explored in this article comprises of a set of original qualitative interviews undertaken with feminist activists and those involved with campaigning for women's representation.⁵ Interviews were conducted with 73 feminist activists who worked for or were a part of large or local feminist networks in the United States and United Kingdom. Ensuring interviews were undertaken with feminists working in both grassroots and national organizations was important; not least because whether or not the activists worked closely with politicians could influence their views of political parties. Interviews were undertaken across six cities: London, Bristol and Glasgow; and New York, Portland (Oregon) and Washington D.C. These cities were selected in order to cover areas where the majority of formal political activity occurs but also to ensure the inclusion of voices from smaller cities; Bristol and Portland were selected as well-known 'hubs' of feminist activity and to provide a contrast with the metropolitan populations of London and New York.

The interviews were conducted between January 2012 and March 2014, lasted between 45 min and 2 h and were fully transcribed. Interviewees were recruited via initial email contact with local feminist groups and national organizations. The interviewees' activism manifested itself in a number of ways: the majority regularly participated in local feminist groups; others focused on specific themes, such as reproductive justice or sexual objectification; while some attended events but were more active in online feminist forums and campaigning. In some instances, a 'snowballing technique' was adopted, whereby interviewees suggested contacting named individuals. The interviewees came from a wide variety of backgrounds and every effort was made to ensure diversity in terms of sex, gender, age, race, class and sexuality; this is where snowballing was of particular use in helping to identify individuals from under-represented groups (Noy, 2008).⁶ Interviewees were asked whether they identified with a political party with follow up questions probing their views on political parties.⁷ Full anonymity was guaranteed to those participating in the research.

Given that this article explores the influence of feminist ideology on attitudes towards political parties, participants were also asked how they defined their own feminism and their answers were coded according to whether or not they had *explicitly* identified with a specific strand; for instance one interviewee might define her feminism as radical, whereas another might choose to focus on issues rather than on ideologies. This meant those who did identify with a specific ideology had done so freely and consciously, rather than selecting from a pre-determined list; however this also meant that there were some who did not identify with a specific ideology at all or with more than one strand (see Online Appendix 1 Table A1 for a full breakdown).

Attitudes towards political parties

The British Social Attitudes survey reports an ongoing decline in the percentage of the population who identify with a political party (currently 76% of the population); a recent estimate put Labour on 36%, Conservative on 27% and the Liberal Democrats on 6%.⁸ In the United States, where registered independents are on the rise, one recent Gallup poll indicated that 42% of voters identified as independent, 31% as Democrat and 25% as Republican.⁹ Such results reflect broader patterns in partisan de-alignment in both the United Kingdom (Curtice, 2010) and the United States (Dalton, 2011). During the interviews, participants were asked if they identified with a political party.

As Table 1 indicates, none of the US participants identified as Republican; likewise, none of the UK interviewees identified as Conservative. The remaining two thirds either said that they had voted for different parties at different times or that they did not feel strongly enough about any of the political parties to identify with one.

Table 1. Interviewees party identification.

Country	Party	Number of interviewees
United States	Democrat	15
	Independent	18
	Freedom Socialist Party	1
United Kingdom	Labour	8
	Liberal Democrat	2
	Green	2
	Left Unity	1
	None	26

For those who identified with a political party, it was clear that party ideology, and to a lesser extent feminist ideology, was important, although the interaction played out differently in the United States and United Kingdom. The historic and contemporary role played by Labour in advancing women's interests was highlighted by several UK interviewees. UK interviewees who identified as liberal or socialist were more likely to identify with a political party than UK interviewees who identified with no ideology or as radical or queer. Interviewees who identified with a political party argued that parties constitute a critical site within which feminists can bring about change:

I'm a member of the Labour party. I'm not very active at the moment but I have been to women's conferences and I think they're a really important place to push forward a feminist agenda. (London)

I vote Labour. If you look at the party, for all its faults, they do at least seem to take women's issues seriously. They introduced quotas so they have more women in the party, which is important. (Glasgow)

As the aforementioned quotations indicate, UK interviewees who identified with a particular party perceived them to provide an important means by which to advance women's issues. Moreover, other interviewees who expressed similar views argued that engaging with electoral politics was important to pursuing a feminist policy agenda.

For the US interviewees, identification with the Democrats was largely driven by a rejection of the Republicans. In short, they identified as Democrat more as a rejection of the Republicans rather than as a positive embracement of the Democrats, as summed up by one interviewee from Portland: 'Well, I definitely call myself a Democrat because who else is going to oppose the GOP and their regressive views on women'. So for her, identifying with the Democrats is a means by which to help oppose Republican policy. Such an approach underscores the impact that differing party systems have on attitudes in the United States and United Kingdom; when one party in a two party system is espousing anti-feminist views then identification

with the other party would seem logical. Conversely, in the United Kingdom, where there are more viable parties to choose between, some interviewees opted for smaller parties that they felt paid more attention to women's issues: 'I joined the Green Party awhile ago [...] the mainstream parties just don't seem to be very women-friendly spaces' (Bristol). Hence, a multi-party system provides greater choice and opportunity for smaller parties to take a lead in areas not necessarily considered 'core' policy issues; this finding supports feminist research, which has identified the positive impact that wider electoral competition can have on the responsiveness of political parties to women's interests (Kantola and Squires, 2012).

From an initial reading of the numbers of those identifying with political parties, it would be tempting to argue that party ideology has the most important impact on determining levels of support among feminists. It is, for instance telling that none of the interviewees identified with the parties on the right in either the United States or United Kingdom; although this is hardly surprising given the GOP's War on Women and the impact that the Conservative-led coalition's (2010–2015) cuts have had on women. Beyond the fact that the interviews were undertaken in cities that could broadly be identified as being on the left politically, it is perhaps also the case that conservative women are less likely to be either working for women's organizations or involved with grassroots campaigns. Rather the push for conservative feminism appears to come largely from high profile businesswomen, right-wing journalists or politicians.¹⁰ To some extent then this research provides contemporary support for past studies which have found feminists and the women's movement to have closer ties to the left (Lovenduski and Randall, 1993; Young, 2000). That said, what is perhaps most striking is the 18 US interviewees who identified as Independent and the 26 British who did not identify with any party.

The reasons given by those who did not identify with a political party appeared to be most clearly shaped by both feminist ideology and the wider disengagement with political parties expressed by those on the left. Indeed, the two factors were closely intertwined in the responses of radical feminists, Black feminists and US socialist feminists. For instance, those who identified as radical feminist were not only more likely to critique parties as bastions of male dominance but they also argued that parties, as opposed to grassroots activism, did not constitute an adequate site for radical change:

I couldn't really compromise my politics by signing up to a party agenda. Feminism and women are always side-lined within them. Anyway, I'd rather focus on grassroots activism which is where the real politics happens. (New York)

It's never really occurred to me to join a party. I'm not really sure what I'd get out of it and my energy goes into

my feminist activism, I'm focused on helping the most vulnerable women not sitting around talking about what goes on in Westminster. Anyway, as far as I can tell all the parties seem to be dominated by men. (Bristol)

I'm a registered independent; I'm interested in the issue and the candidate not which team I support (New York, US)

Oh, I can't be doing with political parties. They say one thing and then do another when they get some power. As far as I can tell none of them seem very interested in feminist issues. (Glasgow)

So for these interviewees, there was not only a feminist critique of parties as institutions run by, for and in the interests of men, but there was also a sense that *real* politics affecting women's lives took place outside of electoral and legislative spheres. This chimes with research, which has highlighted the importance for the women's movement to pursue change in sites beyond the legislative sphere (Weldon, 2012). Parties were viewed as 'hollowed out' institutions, a view reflected in some critical analyses of political parties (Crouch, 2014). By way of contrast, volunteering for a refuge or a running a local campaign were considered to be more effective ways of undertaking political activism. The type of feminist activism that interviewees were engaged with interacted with feminist ideology; specifically, those who identified as radical or queer feminists were the least likely to be those working for large national organizations who regularly work with political parties.

Some interviewees spoke explicitly about the extent to which political parties only seek to represent mainstream concerns, for instance one interviewee from Portland argued that parties were explicitly driven by 'patriarchal capitalist interests'. There was little sense among these interviewees that parties could be sites for substantive feminist change because the parties themselves were too invested in maintaining current power dynamics. Furthermore, some interviewees argued that parties were driven by electoral demands rather than any real ideological interest in feminism. When asked why they were not members or registered supporters of political parties, a common response was that they would rather channel their energies into their feminism:

I don't want to be involved with a party, you know just go to fundraisers? I mean I do that already for feminist groups that are really struggling for money (Portland)

I vote because it's important and women fought for us to have the right to vote but I only have limited time and I choose to focus on women not on party politics (London).

As the aforementioned quotations indicate, for these feminists involvement with a political party would require additional resources; the US interviewees raised the importance of party fundraising as being particularly

off-putting in terms of getting involved. The amount of individual and collective resources that sustains feminist activism was considered to be such that many interviewees argued that 'it was not possible' to devote time to other forms of political activism. Therefore, limited resources had led many to focus their activism in sites other than party politics. Beyond resource-side issues, interviewees were also reluctant to participate in political party campaigning because, for them, it symbolized unnecessary ideological compromise:

I couldn't really be that involved with a party; you have to make compromises, you have to be pragmatic, you have to toe the party line. There are certain issues that I couldn't compromise on (New York)

I think the problem with our politicians and political parties is that they're all the same – they're in it for themselves. I think I can do more good for women outside of Westminster (London).

The emphasis on party discipline and loyalty was problematic for interviewees in both the United States and United Kingdom. Parties were viewed as pragmatic institutions in contrast to feminism, which was presented as more ideologically 'pure', as one interviewee noted: 'parties have to be something to everyone and therefore nothing to people like me who actually care about things'. Some interviewees expressed outright hostility towards political parties and in particular to the idea that they use women's issues to score political points.

We should not necessarily be surprised that many of the interviewees did not identify with a political party, nor that those who worked for large national organizations were less likely to be critical of politicians and parties. Feminist critiques of political parties and formal political institutions continue to have purchase with activists who sometimes perceive parties to be male institutions run by men and in the interests of men (Evans, 2015; Kittilson, 2006). Interviewees on both sides of the Atlantic also articulated a sense of distance and disengagement with political parties; something considered to be a challenge for parties (Mair, 2005). Although being able to identify as independent offered an opportunity for feminists in the United States to register their rejection of the two main parties without necessarily rejecting electoral politics.

For those UK interviewees who identified with a political party, party ideology played a central role: in particular, the historic contribution that the Labour party had made in advancing women's rights, this was not so obvious in discussions concerning the Democrats. Party systems and ideology also had a role to play in shaping the views of the activists with some in the United States, identifying as Democrat simply as a means by which to resist the Republicans. In other words, those who identified as Democrat

did so because they were the least worst option. In the United Kingdom, despite the presence of more successful minor parties, there was still a perception that the parties were all fairly similar. With regards feminist ideology, radical feminists in the United States and United Kingdom were most likely to be critical of parties, while the socialist feminists in the United Kingdom were more likely to identify with Labour than socialist feminists in the United States who tended to identify as independent.

Of course, party identification alone cannot provide us with a full account of the attitudes of feminist activists towards political parties. For instance, it was clear during discussions with the interviewees that many who had expressed hostility towards political parties also recognized the role that politicians play in helping to advance their agenda. As such, the article now explores the ways in which feminists view working with political parties, even when they have seemingly little ideological common ground.

Working with political parties

All mainstream parties in the United States and United Kingdom have women's groups or caucuses, variously committed to: helping target women voters; promoting women's candidacy for electoral office; advocating 'women-friendly' policies; and providing networking, support and leadership opportunities for women in the party (Childs, 2008; Childs and Kittilson in this issue; Wolbrecht, 2000). For sure, these groups sometimes have long-standing links to external women's groups and to the wider women's movement; however, there is also scope for activists to work bilaterally with politicians, party factions and the party leadership. Despite the opposition to political parties that some participants had expressed, it was clear from the interviews and from wider analysis of the feminist movement that activists are willing to work with political parties, where necessary; this was not restricted just to those who had identified with a political party. These relationships took one of two forms: (1) there were those individual politicians, typically Labour and the Democrats who were viewed as feminist allies and who broadly espoused a progressive agenda for women, such as being pro-choice and in favour of equal opportunities; and (2) there were also those who could be viewed as strategic partners, typically those on the right who did not usually advocate or seek to claim to represent women's interests, but who nonetheless advocated for specific policies which (some) feminists had long campaigned for.

Feminist allies

During the interviews there were some who named individual politicians, those 'critical actors' who were identified as having acted on behalf of women in order to bring about

women-friendly change (Childs and Krook, 2006). Those parties who were perceived to espouse women-friendly policies were (mainly) the Democrat or Labour parties; this was also true for individual politicians who were explicitly identified as feminist:

I have a lot of time for Harriet Harman and Stella Creasy [*both Labour MPs*]; they have been willing to take a stand on feminist issues and helped raise the profile of issues that affect women. (London)

Well there are the big names who are well known for campaigning on women's and feminist issues that we work with closely, people like Nancy Pelosi [*D, California 12th and House Minority Leader*] and Rosa DeLauro [*D, Connecticut 3rd*]. We also worked closely with Carolyn Maloney [*D, NY 4th*] on sexual violence on campus.¹¹ (Washington DC)

Some of those interviewees who had been critical of political parties were able to identify a specific feminist politician, which suggests that reframing the relationship as being one between the women's movement and individual politicians is another way of understanding feminist attitudes. For instance, Wendy Davis, the Democrat Texan State Senator for the 10th district, undertook an 11 h filibuster to block proposals to ban abortions after 20 weeks; such an act of representation meant she was cited by several interviewees as a feminist politician who had acted on behalf of women, as one interviewee from Portland articulated: 'When I think of Wendy Davis it just makes me want to cry, knowing that she was there standing in for all those women who couldn't be there and we were all cheering her on'. That Wendy Davis, a politician elected to the state rather than national legislature, should be cited by feminists in Portland and New York is testament to the impact that her act of representation had around the United States; indeed, the actions of Davis went viral.¹² We might also think about those women politicians who have sought to advance feminist campaigns and issues. For instance, Green MP Caroline Lucas wore a No More Page 3 t-shirt in the House of Commons chamber in order to support the campaign, which is trying to get *The Sun* daily newspaper to remove its topless picture of a woman on page 3.¹³

The interviewees were more positive when discussing feminist politicians, rather than political parties (none of the interviews argued that any party was a feminist party). Such a response was explained both by the under representation of women in all political parties (although many recognized that some parties have a better record when it comes to numbers of women) and by a perception that women's issues are not taken seriously by political parties, except for when they are chasing the votes of women. This approach fits with critiques of political parties as male institutions where both women and women's issues are largely absent (Kittilson, 2006; Lovenduski, 2005). When talking about feminist agendas then it was clear that

participants of all feminist and partisan ideological persuasions were engaged with a more individual appraisal of politicians and did not appear to view them as representative of their wider party. The negative comments that many had expressed regarding political parties were largely absent during the discussions of feminist politicians; this was equally true in the United States and United Kingdom. Yet there was still some scepticism on the part of grassroots activists regarding the role of feminist politicians, who were viewed as both remote from the wider movement and with conflicting loyalties, which compromised their ability to fully represent feminist interests. Such an interpretation positions the politicians as *feminist allies*, rather than as say feminist politicians or indeed feminist critical actors, thus reflecting the detachment and antipathy that some activists expressed vis-à-vis formal politics.

Strategic partners

Despite frequent overlaps between the approaches of leftist parties and national women's organizations to women's issues, the latter tend not to affiliate to political parties. For instance the two most prominent US and UK women's civil society organizations, the National Organization for Women (NOW) and the Fawcett Society are, at least notionally non-partisan. However, the reality is that the Democratic party has traditionally proven to be a more receptive home for lobbying by women's organizations, such as NOW (Freeman, 1987), while in the United Kingdom, the Fawcett Society has come under fire from Conservative women for its suspected links to leftist parties and its high profile attacks on the Government.¹⁴ Indeed, as this article has argued, feminist activists are more likely to identify with leftist parties. Interviews with those feminists who worked for national women's organizations reiterated the importance of being non- or bi-partisan:

It's really important to us to maintain our non-partisan status but we also have to focus on the issues and sometimes it's easy to present us as being an adjunct to the Democrats. (Washington DC)

We have to be careful about what we can and can't say in order to maintain our neutrality and that can mean stepping back a bit [...] we want to see more women elected across the political spectrum and so work with all parties on that. (London)

Maintaining a non-partisan status allows women's organizations the opportunity, at least in theory, to be able to influence all parties. This is self-evident when we consider the need for a permanent profile for women's groups, regardless of which party is in office. Such a position also means that the potential for working with politicians and parties who are traditionally less well disposed to a feminist agenda is kept alive. Indeed, some interviewees claimed

that certain anti-feminist politicians and party factions might be of more strategic use vis-à-vis specific policy issues, particularly those controversial issues that tend to divide feminist opinion.

Contentious issues, such as pornography or prostitution divide the women's movement; with radical feminists on both sides of the Atlantic more likely to advance abolitionist approaches. On these kinds of issues, less traditional alliances are sometimes made between radical feminists and politicians on the conservative right, who seek the same policy ends, but are motivated by very different beliefs and attitudes. A willingness on the part of radical feminists to work with conservative politicians may appear surprising; however, it is instructive in so far as it reveals that the radicalism driving their feminism is focused more on the ends than the means. In other words, while radical feminists were those most likely to be critical of political parties per se and for the most part refuse to be involved in party politics; this is trumped by a desire to abolish prostitution or pornography. That it is these specific issues on which radical feminists are willing to work with conservatives is important because these tend to be the issues largely ignored or viewed as too controversial for large national women's organizations to campaign on:

Well, I may not like an individual politician or party but I'll work with whoever I have to in order to make things better for women, especially when it comes to issues like prostitution or violence against women. (Portland)

It's naïve to think that in order to get real change through you won't have to work with people that on every other issue you fundamentally disagree. (London)

For these feminists, the issue trumped any disquiet with regards who they may have to ally themselves with. For instance, social conservatives on both sides of the Atlantic have argued in favour of greater censorship regulation in order to address the issue of pornography. While conservative opposition to pornography is based upon the argument that it is not only morally corrupting but also threatens family values; feminist critiques are located within a critique of pornography as a manifestation of oppression and exploitation of women. For the radical feminists I interviewed, this tension was clearly problematic; however, the desire to see progress in the issue was of the upmost importance:

It's true, I feel a little uncomfortable sometimes when you see the swivel-eyed right wingers who are also opposed to prostitution but I think it's important to keep your eye on the larger prize (Bristol)

I guess politics, at least electoral politics, is about compromise and for me the compromise comes in terms of who I'll work with. I may disagree with every other policy issue that

some Republicans advocate and I sure as hell wouldn't vote for them [...] but I can also see that if that's the way to make things happen to get things done then so be it (Portland).

The space between conservative and radical feminist critiques can often provide a site within which conservative women can operate. For instance, the Conservative MP Claire Perry was at the forefront of campaigns to introduce internet porn filters, something supported by the End Violence Against Women coalition.¹⁵ In the United States, where there are only 23 Republican Congresswomen (out of 279 Republican representatives), such campaigns tend to be fronted by men on the right. For instance, the Democrats favour a free and largely unregulated Internet, whilst Mitt Romney, during his 2012 Presidential campaign argued in favour of a filter to block all online pornography.¹⁶

The interviewees, mainly those who identified as radical feminists stressed the importance of pragmatism in advancing women's rights. While some reflected that it may be 'uncomfortable' working with those who are simultaneously seeking to attack women's reproductive rights, this was particularly true in the United States, there was also a recognition that leftist/liberal parties all too often tended to shy away from more contentious issues. Hence, party ideology and feminist ideology interact here but only really among those radical feminists and conservative politicians. Large national women's organizations tend to adopt more centrist positions and also tend to focus on less controversial issues. As such, strategic partnerships between radical feminists and conservatives are both possible and necessary.

Conclusion

This article has explored the contemporary relationship between the women's movement and political parties in the United States and United Kingdom. The research has found that feminist activists echo critiques made by feminist scholars that political parties remain male dominated institutions (Lovenduski, 2005). Moreover, despite recognizing the importance of working with individual politicians, the majority of the interviewees (particularly in the United Kingdom) felt detached from political parties. Party and feminist ideology help explain both positive and negative attitudes towards political parties and the extent to which the latter are viewed as both feminist allies and strategic partners. It is clear that leftist partners were more readily identified as being more receptive and committed to advancing women's interests and yet conservative politicians also had a role to play in pursuing issues that tended to divide the women's movement. The analysis has revealed that although there are numerous negative perceptions of parties, and the opportunities they offer feminist activists, this does not extend to individual politicians. Such a view is not necessarily contradictory if the critique is of the parties as institutions rather than of the need for legislative change to pursue feminist goals. However, the

emphasis on individual politicians or critical actors is problematic for UK political parties who focus less on the idea of individual representation than is the case in the United States.

This comparative analysis has revealed differences in attitudes towards political parties, with those in the United Kingdom expressing greater disengagement from the formal process. The critiques made of parties were broadly similar across the two countries, as was the identification of feminist allies and the need for strategic partners. The role for conservative parties and politicians in advancing the interests (if not underlying ethos) of those most closely associated with radical feminism presents an interesting dimension to the debates concerning the representation of women's and feminist interests. The disengagement and alienation from parties as institutions in and of themselves is perhaps not surprising; however despite these views, the women's movement have not rejected the formal political process and recognize the importance of working with politicians and parties in multiple ways across a range of issues.

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Notes

1. Leftist parties is the term used in this article to refer to the UK Labour party (but also includes the Greens and the centrist Liberal Democrats) and the US Democrats a liberal-left party.
2. The Equal Rights Amendment was written in 1923 in order to guarantee the equal application of the constitution to all people, regardless of their sex. It was passed by Congress in 1972, but has failed to gain the support of the required number of states necessary (38), in order to ratify the change to the constitution.
3. The Fawcett Society (unsuccessfully) sought a judicial review of the government's budget for failing to take gender into account.
4. The use of the label independent refers to those who wish to register themselves as independent not as members of the Independent Party.
5. The data used in this article was gathered as part of a broader project exploring feminist activism in the United States and Britain – see Evans, 2015 forthcoming.
6. While the focus of this article is on feminist ideology, socialization also influences attitudes towards political parties. All of the interviewees were very active in feminist politics although had come to it from different backgrounds. Some

had been introduced to feminism at college or University, while others had become active following personal experiences of gender inequality or sexual violence. Given that all interviewees were guaranteed anonymity, biographical details of the participants are not made available. However, a more sociological approach to exploring feminist attitudes to political parties is an important area for development and indicates a possible future research agenda.

7. In order to make a more fruitful comparison, the focus is on levels of party identification rather than numbers of party members or supporters.
8. The British Social Attitudes (BSA) report is available at: <http://bsa-30.natcen.ac.uk/read-the-report/politics/introduction.aspx> (accessed 20 October 2014).
9. See the Gallup poll, available at: <http://www.gallup.com/poll/166763/record-high-americans-identify-independents.aspx> (accessed 20 October 2014).
10. See Leonora O'Neill 'Conservative Feminists Find their Voices' 25th July 2014, available at: <http://www.usatoday.com/story/news/nation/2014/07/24/ozy-conservative-feminists/13087747/> (accessed 20 October 2014). Amber Rudd and Andrea Leadsom 'You're Wrong Harriet Harman – Conservatives Make Better Feminists' 24th July 2012, available at: <http://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2012/jul/24/harriet-harman-wrong-conservatives-feminists> (accessed 20 October 2014).
11. In 2011 Carolyn Maloney sponsored the Campus Sexual Violence Elimination Act which eventually became part of the Violence Against Women Act passed in 2013. Among other measures the Act strengthened the requirements on the part of schools and colleges to provide counselling, guidance and legal assistance to victims of sexual assault. See Campus SaVE Act FAQs, available at: <http://thecampussaveact.com/faq/> (accessed 28 October 2014).
12. See for instance Salon, 'Wendy Davis, Feminist Superhero', available at: http://www.salon.com/2013/06/26/wendy_davis_feminist_super_hero/ (accessed 28 April 2015).
13. See No More Page 3, available at: <http://nomorepage3.org/> (accessed 29 October 2014).
14. See Christopher Hope 'Women Tory MPs Plot Revolution at 150 Year Old Fawcett Society' 13th October 2012, available at: <http://www.telegraph.co.uk/women/womens-politics/9605196/Women-Tory-MPs-plot-revolution-at-150-year-old-Fawcett-Society.html> (accessed 20 October 2014).
15. See BBC 'Online pornography to be blocked by default, PM announces' 22nd July 2013, available at: <http://www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-23401076> (accessed 30 October 2014).
16. See various Mitt Romney speeches, available at: <http://mittromneycentral.com/?s=Pornography> (accessed 7 November 2014).

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Gendering transnational party politics: The case of European Union

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Abstract

In this article, we analyze transnational party politics in the European Union from a gender perspective. This is a subject that has been neglected both by mainstream European studies on party politics and by gender scholars who work on political parties. Drawing on the insights of these two research traditions, we build toward an analytical framework to study gender and transnational party politics. Our empirical analysis focuses on two policy issues, the economic crisis and the sexual and reproductive health and rights, analyzing European Parliament reports, debates and voting on the issues from 2009 to 2014. By focusing on gender equality constructions and the way in which consensus and contestation are built around them within and between party groups, we argue that shared constructions about gender equality are issue specific and change over time. Consensus breaks down along the left right axis and, at the same time, internal divisions within party groups affect policy output.

Keywords

economic crisis, European Union, gender, party groups, sexual and reproductive health and rights

Introduction

The study of gender and political parties most often focuses on national parties in specific countries or undertakes comparative case studies across different countries. The unique contribution of this article is to study gender and political parties in the transnational context, namely, in the European Union (EU) and to evaluate what this form of governance and institutions offer for gender politics. Mainstream EU studies have neglected gender analysis as pertinent to theories about European party politics. Similarly, gender and politics scholarship has shown little interest in transnational party politics. At the same time, the political and legislative importance of the European Parliament (EP) has increased in the past 20 years and feminist EU studies have shown that it is a crucial actor for gender equality in the EU.

In this article, we begin to map the unexplored field of gender and European party politics by studying the EP party groups during the 7th legislature 2009–2014. Our key research questions are as follows: How is gender equality constructed by the European party groups and with what effects? How and why does gender equality create lines of

contestation and consensus between and within EP's party groups? What impact does this have for gender equality policy making? We focus on two debates, namely, the economic crisis and sexual and reproductive health and rights (SRHRs). The former addresses gender inequalities in the field of finance and economics and the latter in relation to bodily rights. Despite their obvious differences as policy issues, both have generated heated debates at the European level in relation to gender. The combination of the two policy fields allows us to analyze the diverse dynamics of parliamentary activity as well as the potential for contestation or consensus across two very different policy fields.

Our research questions are underpinned by an understanding of gender equality as an essentially contested

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concept. Political actors, such as MEPs and political groups, are central in constructing meanings given to “gender equality.” Feminist scholars explore how some of these meanings can become dominant or fixed (e.g. different numerical definitions of gender quotas as equal). Alternatively, other meanings remain highly contested and divisive (e.g. prostitution and sex work). They have consequences for policy making and for achieving gender equality in the society (Lombardo et al., 2009).

We suggest that such a constructivist or poststructuralist feminist approach can be usefully combined with EU studies literature on the political dynamics of the EP generating insights about when and how inter- and intraparty group divisions emerge. Research on the processes whereby political contestation over European integration leads to EU politicization focuses, on the one hand, on “strategic competition among political parties” (on the domestic level), that is, between mainstream and radical, populist parties (Hooghe and Marks, 2009). On the other hand, discursive contestation between a broad range of political actors exists over the content of the integration project:

the *polarization* between political actors resulting from their contestation does not occur on a simple axis of ‘for versus against’ integration (positions), but is also constructed within a field of legitimating ideas where actors also distinguish their stances from one another (frames) (Statham and Trenz, 2013: 978).

Our analysis provides new insights about the political negotiations, ideological divisions and gender constructions behind the scenes of the party group politics in the EP. Our findings illustrate the existence of contestations and consensus about gender equality not only between but also within party groups as expressed in parliamentary debates and voting. Consensus about gender equality and the ways to best achieve it at the European level breaks down as electoral competition increases. Overall, the analysis in the article provides a more nuanced and differentiated view about the presumably gender equal EP than is usually the case in feminist EU studies.

Studying gender and European party groups

European studies literature shows how transnational party politics in the EU can be studied on many levels: the Council, the Commission, the EP, and the European party federations (see, e.g. Hix, 2008; Timuş and Lightfoot, 2014). In this article, we tackle one aspect of the larger picture and focus on the EP’s *party groups* in order to analyze consensus and contestation around gender equality and gender constructions transnationally. Individual MEPs and their national political parties organize in party groups of the EP. The party groups lead the selection process of

committee members and decide on leadership positions, they appoint the party group coordinators of committees,¹ and influence the choice of rapporteurs for legislative and own initiative reports of the committees. The party groups’ policy positions form the blueprint to their legislative activity in the Parliament and new group members usually must agree officially to follow party policy (McElroy and Benoit, 2010: 3). Studies on European party group politics note the increasing levels of internal party group cohesion: over time, party groups have become increasingly cohesive (Hix, 2008) and a heightened emphasis has been placed on maintaining voting cohesion with the two largest political groups operating a whipping system (McElroy and Benoit, 2010: 3). Political group discipline and cohesion is promoted by allocating rapporteurship of legislative reports to MEPs as a reward for loyalty (Yordanova, 2013). Previous research has established that MEPs vote along party group lines over 90% of the time (McElroy and Benoit, 2010: 4). At the same time, building and maintaining cohesion within party groups is a constant struggle and party groups and MEPs negotiate between European and national party positions (McElroy and Benoit, 2010: 4).

Feminist research into party politics, in turn, explores how gender is represented both descriptively (in terms of numbers of women and men in political parties and parliaments and executives) and substantively (in terms of issues and interests) (Childs, 2008; Childs and Webb, 2012; Evans, 2011). This research has identified a range of relevant factors that affect gender and representation ranging from formal to informal party institutions. For example, looking at women’s *descriptive representation* in the EP and its party groups, the composition of the EP after the 2009 elections showed an average female representation of 35%. The Greens/European Free Alliance (Greens/EFA) had more women than men elected in the 2009 elections (54.6%), whereas the Alliance of Liberals and Democrats (ALDE) reached 45.2% female representation. In the middle, with figures between 28% and 40%, we find the Progressive Alliance of Socialists and Democrats (S&D, 40.2%), the European People’s Party (EPP, 33.6%), and the European United Left/Nordic Green Left (GUE/NGL, 28.6%). The groups of the Non-Inscrits (NI, 18.5%), Europe of Freedom and Democracy (EFD, 15.6%), and the European Conservatives and Reformists (ECR, 13.0%) are performing the worst (EP, 2014). While the representation of women in the EP has increased over time, women are better represented in the left-green party groups than in the conservative right ones.

Some indication of *substantive representation* of women can be found on the political groups’ official websites and policy papers on gender and women. For example, the S&D, Greens/EFA, and GUE/NGL address gender equality and women’s rights both as a specific issue in its own right and mainstreamed to many or some other parts of political work. On the web pages, such a strong position of

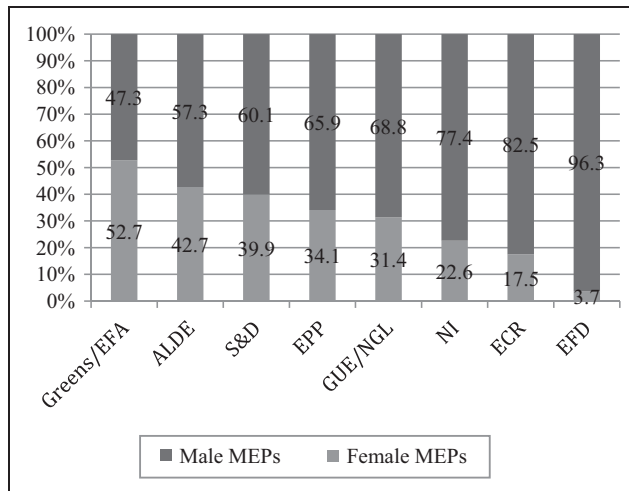


Figure 1. Gender composition of political groups in the EP, 7th legislature.

gender equality is evidenced in the frequent appearance of gender-related news, statements, reports, and position papers that these groups issue. Their policy priorities reflect the centrality of the labor market and the economy (gender pay gap, the crisis) in EU gender policy making (Abels and Mushaben, 2013; Jacquot, 2015; Kantola, 2010: 20) although labor market issues are now balanced with the rise and notable legitimacy of gender-based violence in the documents (Rolandsen Agustín, 2013). Other party groups are more moderate in terms of the importance given to gender equality issues. ALDE mentions gender only a few times in key documents and EPP omits gender equality altogether in general documents and only addresses it in particular programmes on gender equality. The latter also applies to the ECR group that links gender equality to their EU critical agenda, arguing that the EU should not interfere. The EFD holds a marginal position on gender equality since the issue is hardly addressed and, if so, in pejorative terms or only in relation to a limited number of aspects such as Muslim culture. Again a left/right divide in the stances on gender equality, and the substantive representation of women, thus become visible. In sum, gender equality questions are polarized and the green/left groups promote highly feminist definitions and solutions, whereas the radical and conservative right strongly opposes these.

Instead of focusing on descriptive and substantive representation of women, poststructural feminist approaches to party politics analyze how gender and gender equality get constructed in the political struggles surrounding political parties (e.g. Kantola and Saari, 2014; Lombardo et al., 2009; Rolandsen Agustín, 2013). The meaning of gender or gender equality is not taken as given or a priori, as something that can be merely represented in the political debates conducted by political parties. Rather analytical interest is placed in the active constructions of gender and gender equality in the processes of representation (see also Celis

et al., 2014). For example, political parties construct women and men and their rights and duties as citizens in particular ways in the election manifestos as well as shaping perceptions about the most relevant gender equality policies. Traditionally, parties on the left have taken actively part in debates about gender equality drawing on societal and structural explanations about the causes of gender inequalities. Now parties on the right have entered the debate and this has an impact on the constructions of gender equality (Celis and Childs, 2014). For example, notions about equality have become more individualist, liberal, numerical, or market oriented, emphasizing equality of opportunity as opposed to equality of outcome (Kantola and Saari, 2014).

While explorations of gender and party politics remain limited in relation to the EU, the EP committees have been well studied with some important insights to our article. EP committees are indeed a key location for party group politics. However, as opposed to many member state parliaments, EP committee work is consensus-oriented and the political groups seek majorities in committee votes. The roles of the committee chair, the rapporteur and potential shadow rapporteur, and the coordinators appointed by the political groups are central in this consensus building. Patterns of consensus and dissonance are influenced by the type of the committee in question and the type of the report with legislative reports being more contested than nonlegislative ones (Collins et al., 1998; McElroy, 2006; Neuhold, 2001; Settembri and Neuhold, 2009). In the past policy making in the EP was dominated by grand coalitions between the two largest party groups, EPP and S&D; however, coalition formation has become increasingly ideology-driven and formed around the left/right divide, resulting in centre-left or center-right coalitions (Yordanova, 2013).

The EP Committee dedicated to gender equality issues (Committee on Women's Rights and Gender Equality, FEMM) is mainly in charge of nonbinding or nonlegislative reports, making the power and position of the Committee within the EP limited. Even though the FEMM Committee has been considered to be consensus-oriented research shows tendencies towards strong intracommittee networking and alliances across political groups, giving impetus to policy areas such as violence against women and keeping gender equality issues on the EU agenda (Ahrens, 2016; European Parliament, 2014; Kantola, 2010; Montoya, 2013; Pristed Nielsen and Rolandsen Agustín, 2013; Rolandsen Agustín, 2012; Van der Vleuten, 2007, 2012; Woodward and Hubert, 2007). There have been developments toward increased levels of dispute and disagreement between the party groups on certain policy issues, partly related to the enlargement and the shift in power balance between the political forces of the EP in the 2000s which challenged the previously strong feminist character of the Committee (Ahrens, 2014; Montoya, 2013; Rolandsen

Agustín, 2012; Woodward and Hubert, 2007). In other words, consensus, as a trait of the Committee, has been called into question.

Methodological and theoretical approach of the article

Building on these different literatures on gender and party politics, on the one hand, and EU studies on political groups of the EP, on the other, we seek to provide insights into the dynamics that questions about gender create for the political groups. On the basis of the previous research discussed earlier, we hypothesize that there is a high level of consensus in the EP and especially in the FEMM committee about what gender equality is and how it is best achieved. However, certain gender equality issues play a central role in party politics and are highly contested. To study these trends we ask (i) how is gender equality constructed by the party groups and with what effects? (ii) How and why does gender equality create lines of contestation and consensus between and within EP's party groups? (iii) What impact does this have for gender equality policy making?

We have selected two policy debates as our case studies: (i) gender and the economic crisis and (ii) SRHRs. SRHR is explicitly gendered and always debated in relation to gender. It is also considered controversial as political parties relate it to issues of morality and ideology. The economic crisis, in contrast, is most often debated in a gender blind manner, omitting its gendered consequences and linkages to gender equality and gender equality policy. Our search for 'gender and the financial/economic crisis' in the EP documents returned only the three FEMM committee reports and the debates surrounding them that we analyze in more detail later. In other words, gender equality was not considered relevant in relation to most debates about the economic crisis in the EP and its committees. Despite the differences between the two issues, the combination of the two policy fields will allow us to analyze the diverse dynamics of parliamentary activity and political constructions around gender equality as well as the potential for consensus and contestation.

Methodologically, we analyze the *output* as well as the *processes* of policy making on these issues. We highlight the need to focus not only on the output in a form of a parliamentary report, but on the political processes and negotiations behind the report. FEMM initiated reports and parliamentary debates are a popular source of data for gender scholars for analyzing the EP discourses on, for example, gender violence (Kantola, 2006; Rolandsen Agustín, 2013). Their obvious limitation is the strict time limit to 2–3 min of the EP speeches, which does not lend itself to, for example, detailed discourse or frame analysis. We also find that they capture only a small part of the bigger picture

of consensus and contestation and hence supplement them with voting patterns and press releases.

Using the timeframe of the 2009–2014 parliamentary term, we find four committee reports on these two topics that have been debated and voted upon in the parliament. Three of the reports deal with gender and the economic crisis (FEMM, 2010, 2013a, 2014) and one with SRHR (FEMM, 2013b). We divide the analysis in three parts. First, we address expressions of consensus and contestation in the underlying gender constructions as these are articulated and framed² in *parliamentary debates* at Committee and, second, plenary levels as well as intergroup consensus and intragroup cohesion as reflected in *voting patterns* (collected and accessed through VoteWatch). Third, we analyze the political groups' *press releases* in the aftermath of the parliamentary votes that turned down two of the reports, one on the economic crisis (FEMM, 2014) and one on SRHR (FEMM, 2013b). The press releases show the interpretations made of the political process and allow for the political groups to position themselves in relation to each other as a part of the political process. Gender constructions, cohesion, and positioning are all ways of identifying patterns of consensus and/or contestation in the transnational party political dynamics.

Party groups' gendered constructions of the economic crisis

Since its outset in 2008, the economic crisis has come to dominate the European gender policies too. With the key actors, such as the Council, the Commission, and the European Central Bank having opted for tight austerity politics, different gender equality actors have sought to draw attention to the gendered consequences of these policies (Bettio et al., 2012; Karamessini and Rubery, 2014). Our analysis shows how the gendered economic crisis has incrementally changed from a consensual political issue and a shared concern among the majority of the EP's political groups to a highly politicized one where the differences between the political groups have increased. This trajectory can be traced from the debates of the EP that have taken place on the basis of three FEMM-initiated reports (2010, 2013a, 2014). As follows, we focus on consensus and contestation by exploring the constructions about gender equality and the economic crisis in the committee reports and parliamentary debates as well as by analyzing EP voting patterns on these reports.

The contents of the three reports are notably similar in their constructions about gender, gender equality, and the economic crisis. Centrally, the three reports construct the two genders as being differentially impacted by the crisis. The first report draws attention to the gendered waves of the economic crisis: at the initial stages, the crisis hit male dominated industrial and construction sectors. The second wave hit public services, retailing, and tourism, and hence

women's employment (FEMM, 2010: 5). During the four years' time span between the reports, the arguments about the gendered effects become more specific: women have lost jobs and services in the public sector, their salaries have been reduced or frozen, family allowances have been cut, part-time employment and discrimination against pregnant women have increased (FEMM, 2013a; FEMM, 2014: 12). Overall, the reports see the crisis not only as financial or economic but also as 'a crisis for democracy, for equality, for social welfare, and for gender equality' (FEMM, 2013a: 5; FEMM, 2014: 25). Each of these crises is pointed out to have gendered effects.

Another central construction about gender equality relates to its unachieved state across the society that has both brought the crisis about and is exacerbated by it. For example, the FEMM reports suggest that the male dominance in economic decision-making – especially in banking – and its failures led to the crisis. The reports also express concerns about gender equality policies, machineries, and the cutbacks that these face. They criticize the failure of Commission to undertake gender mainstreaming in its own policies (FEMM, 2013a: 21; FEMM, 2014: 13). Gender equality is constructed in relation to economic gain: 'gender equality has a major positive impact on economic productivity and growth' (FEMM, 2010: 6; FEMM, 2014: 13). At the same time, gender equality is related to bodily rights with the reports pointing out that violence against women has increased because of the crisis (FEMM, 2010: 10; FEMM, 2013a). Noteworthy too is that intersectionality is taken into account in the constructions of gender and the reports note that 'the crisis will have the worst effect on vulnerable groups of women' (FEMM, 2010: 9) and call for example for the inclusion of Roma women (FEMM, 2013a).

The first two reports were adopted by the Parliament, while the third one was rejected. This shows how contradictions about the seemingly shared constructions about the gendered consequences of the crisis and appropriate policy solutions increased over time. What differentiates the rejected third report from the first two ones is the fact that it is more broadly about gender equality in the EU although it stresses the consequences of the economic crisis for women. A further difference is that the rapporteur of the third report came from the smaller left-wing group GUE/NGL, while for the former two reports the rapporteurs had been from the Green/EFA group (FEMM, 2010) and from the biggest group EPP (FEMM, 2013a). The political groups' different approaches to handling the crisis where made more evident as the 2014 EP elections came closer. The differences between the political groups come to the fore in the explanatory note of the third report and they explain the polarized outcome (FEMM, 2014). Preempting the political debate between the groups that ensued when the third report was debated in the EP, the explanatory note states: "The rapporteur stresses that it is not possible to

pursue these policies while attempting to 'avoid' or 'minimize' their gender impact, as is often suggested. Gender equality cannot exist alongside these policies" (FEMM, 2014: 26). This reflects the critical stance that the left wing GUE/NGL took toward the way that the troika (International Monetary Fund, Commission, and the Central Bank) was handling the crisis as being in fundamental opposition to gender equality and women's rights. Hence, to the GUE/NGL group, it was not possible to continue on the austerity path and try to mainstream gender in these policies. The EPP opposed this line of argument most clearly.

Parliamentary debates

The parliamentary debates on the three reports, by contrast, were fairly consensual. The biggest differences are reflected in the voting patterns, and not in what was actually said. We suggest that the implication of this finding is that in order to understand contestation around gender equality and its significance in European party politics, one needs to process trace the complete policy debate. As an example of the consensus and shared constructions in the parliamentary debate Livia Járóka (on behalf of the EPP group) stated:

Although ... it is still difficult to assess the financial crisis, it is absolutely clear to all of us that this period has had particularly serious consequences for women. It is therefore very much the case, and should be highlighted endlessly, that inadequate investment in economic and social opportunities for women completely limits economic growth and slows down the reduction of poverty and social disparities in our Europe (June 15, 2010).

Here we thus have a representative of the conservative party group stressing the gendered consequences of the crisis that have been exacerbated by failures to make economic and social investments in women. S&D and ALDE made supportive group speeches too. More overarching critique coming from the left was present in the debate too. Charalampos Angourakis, on behalf of the GUE/NGL group, placed more emphasis on the capitalist system and contested the whole EU 2020 growth strategy: "Fight by women, through the fight by all the workers against the consequences of the crisis, through the fight to overturn capitalism." The MEP rebelled and voted against the report like his Greek colleague. The speech reflected the uneasiness of the left group with the austerity politics as a whole and the primacy of criticizing these over gender equality (June 15, 2010).

The main opposition, however, came from the political groups on the far conservative and right end of the political spectrum. For example, Marina Yannakoudakis (on behalf of the ECR group) emphasized choice and empowerment, and member state competences as solutions:

The reports we have been voting on cover some important issues relating to women's rights. However, as in many cases, we find Parliament crosses the red line into areas which are Member State competencies. In addition the reports have a vision of what a woman should be, and they come up with tools such as quotas to enforce this vision. In the process they undermine the ability of women to achieve, implying they need a helping hand up the ladder to succeed (March 11, 2013).

The quotation shows how she framed attempts to promote gender equality as increased bureaucracy from aforementioned. She constructed women as individual achievers who did not need such harmful legal protection or other interventionist actions. Within the EPP too, there were some more conservative voices with Anna Záborská (EPP) arguing:

Now social engineering is generating an unusual paradox in the Union. We are privatizing state economics on the pretext of free competition but we are nationalizing relations between men and women. The Union is copying the bad experiences we lived through in Central and Eastern Europe (March 11, 2013).

Nationalization in her quotation again signifies too much state intervention and a strong preference for a public/private distinction in matters relating to gender equality defining the appropriate roles and relations of the state, society, and families. In general, however, there was a lot of consensus on economic crisis within EPP speeches.

Voting patterns

A focus on the voting patterns on these reports draws attention not only to the party politics between the political groups of the EP but also the splits that gender equality questions result in within the groups. What we see here is party politics in the sense that the EPP prioritizes the importance of austerity politics over gender equality, but suffers from internal splits as a group since its progender equality MEPs vote against its official line.

When comparing the voting patterns, the first two reports were adopted with clear majorities. For the 2010 report, 57% voted for (S&D, Green/EFA, ALDE, and GUE/NGL) and 14% against (EFD and ECR). The EPP abstained (29%). While all the other groups had very high group cohesions, the EPP – which is normally predicted to have high group cohesion – had only a moderate cohesion (63%), with 35 of its MEPs voting for the report and 19 against it. The second report was adopted with a larger majority as its rapporteur came from the biggest party group, the EPP. The biggest groups (EPP, S&D, ALDE, and the Green/EFA) all voted for the report. The ECR voted against it while the GUE/NGL abstained. Again the group cohesion was very high for most groups and lower than

predicted on the basis of the mainstream literature for EPP with 13 MEPs voting against and 19 abstaining against the group line (cohesion 80%). ALDE was for the report but was more split on this report than the previous one with group cohesion only at 64%. The EFD remained divided and did not have a political line on the report.

Unlike the first two reports, the third report was rejected in the parliament: the final vote was very tight with 44% against (EPP, ECR, and EFD), 43% for (S&D, GUE/NGL, ALDE), and 13% abstaining (Greens/EFA). Group cohesion remained high only for S&D and the ECR with the EPP and GUE/NGL being fairly cohesive with their respective lines. The Greens/EFA were unusually divided on the issue as the official line was to abstain, but 25 MEPs voted for the report and 2 against it. The EFD continued to display low cohesion levels with 10 MEPs abstaining against the group line.

Press releases

In press releases after the debate and vote, EPP and S&D competed over interpretations of the results. For example, the EPP press release (**March 11, 2014**) was titled “The Left is hijacking gender equality for ideological goals.” In the press release, Anne Delvaux states:

From the beginning, the Left has focused its Report on the negative effects of austerity measures and their consequences on employment and public services, continuously diverting from this fundamental issue which was addressed in the Report: the equality between men and women on our continent! On several occasions, our wish has been to refocus the debate and make it more unbiased.

The press release from the S&D, by contrast, was titled: “‘Conservatives refuse to face up to the critical problem of gender inequality’ accuse S&D Euro MPs,” (**March 11, 2014**). In the press release, Zita Gurmai says, “Again the conservatives in this Parliament have taken an ideological stance against women. This is unacceptable.” S&D group negotiator Mojca Kieva Kekuč continues:

I regret that the right wing in the EP rejected the in-depth report which addressed the core problems that women face on a daily basis. It is clear that the crisis and the ill-thought-out austerity measures have worsened the situation for women in the EU.

Thus, the press releases employ a very traditional left-right division to interpret the results with the conservative right constructing the left as “ideological” and the left suggesting that the right is pretentious in its attempts to advance gender equality. This adds to the level of contestation over the issue of gender and the economic crisis.

Our analysis illustrates how transnational party politics breaks down the apparent consensus on the level of the

committee reports and the parliamentary debate about the gendered impact of the crisis and solutions to it. On the one hand, we analyzed how the three FEMM reports whose rapporteurs came from the right (EPP), the Greens (Greens/EFA), and the left (GUE/NGL) had notably similar constructions about gender equality and the crisis. This shows the existence of consensus at the FEMM committee level. On the other hand, the EPP and GUE/NGL's opposing constructions about the economic crisis and its handling increased the tensions in the committee, but were especially apparent in the parliamentary votes and explain the different outcomes. Our analysis pointed to the existence of progender equality groups of MEPs within the EPP who voted against the official party group line. Their numbers, however, were not sufficiently big to change the outcome for gender equality. The Green/EFA were also not supporting the most far reaching analyses of the gendered consequences of the crisis but the group was not cohesive on the issue. Overall, the analysis illustrates the need to study the different stages of the EP policy-making process to reveal not only constructions and consensus but also the contestations that inform the debates.

Party groups' gendered constructions of sexual and reproductive health and rights

The EP has been considered a progressive actor in SRHR issues, among other things due to the adoption of the 2002 resolution on SRHR with a human rights perspective, based on an own-initiative report of the FEMM Committee. However, this status has become contested with the enlargement to the Eastern member states and the rise of the populist right in Europe, making the issue of SRHR controversial and contested in the political debates of the EP not least due to the pro/anti stances on abortion rights, attitudes toward sexuality issues, and differences in member state legislation (Rolandsen Agustín, 2012). In 2013, a report on SRHR (FEMM, 2013b) was once again referred to the Committee and Edite Estrela (S&D) was appointed rapporteur. The policy process around this second report was particularly interesting because the report went back and forth from Committee to plenary several times: it was surrounded by strong disagreements in the debates, which was also reflected by several minority opinions and alternative motions for resolution being proposed. The debates on the Estrela report and the fact that it was not accepted in the parliament illustrate more broadly the new contestation on the issue of SRHR in the EP.

The 2013 report constructed SRHR as an issue of *human rights and bodily integrity*; it addressed "women's and girls' rights to equality, nondiscrimination, dignity, and health," thereby depicting the gendered problem as resulting from structural discrimination as opposed to individual problems. The draft report emphasized the need for sexuality education and youth-friendly services and advocated

freedom of choice in matters of SRHR, favoring legal, safe, and accessible *abortion* and mentioning in particular the abortion ban in Ireland, Malta, and Poland. The report further constructed the EP as a defender of SRHR against the tides, characterized by the rise of conservative forces in Europe ("the antichoice opposition is becoming stronger and more vocal").

Significantly, a Minority Opinion, drafted by former Committee chairperson, Anna Zaboraska (EPP), was added to the report. The Minority Opinion put forward opposing constructions of SRHR, by focusing on the antiabortion stances related to protection of children and human embryo as well as the "human right of conscientious objection," instead of gender equality, structural discrimination or free choice in matters of SRHR. In the policy process, MEPs from EPP, ECR, and EFD made additional proposals for amendments which were not admitted into the report; these related to antiabortion stances, at times replacing SRHR with a focus on prenatal and maternal health as well as defense of member state competences in the area.

Parliamentary debates

The parliamentary debate on the SRHR report reflected the contestation on the issues and the main dividing lines, articulated around the notion of rights. The S&D and GUE/NGL constructed the issue of SRHR as a matter of defending women's rights to decide over their own body whereas the EPP and ECR argued for the right to conscientious objection, the right of the child as a human being, and the right of member states to decide on morality issues.³ The gender constructions thus related to women's bodily rights and empowerment as opposed to ignoring gender inequality as part of the problem. In the written explanations to the votes, the EPP and EFD groups also related the issue to subsidiarity (arguing that the EU had no competence in the area of SRHR) and parents' rights to educate their children (thus rejecting the idea of sexual education in school).

In relation to the issue of sexuality education, some differences within the EPP group became visible: whereas Gabriel and Morin-Chartier (both EPP) in their proposal for amendments to the report argued for sexuality education in order to enable respectful relationships, to counteract the harmful effects of pornography and, to encourage safe sexual behavior and access to means of protection, the general amendments made by EPP/ECR/EFD MEPs collectively stressed the liberty held by parents to ensure education in conformity with their (religious) convictions, thus not permitting SRHR and abortion related education against their wishes. In other words, the issue was constructed as one of unequal gender relations as opposed to the rights of families and the relations between parents and children. Matera, also of the EPP group, proposed several individual amendments, among other things to call on member states to make

sex education classes compulsory, and to include an emphasis on gender equality. Whereas the amendments proposed by the general group were not admitted, the ones made by Gabriel/Morin-Chartier and Matera were accepted and included in the final report. Amendments made by S&D, ALDE, Greens/EFA, and GUE/NGL together strengthened the construction of gender equality as a matter of human rights and highlighted issues such as health, prevention of HIV and sexually transmitted infections, sexuality education, unwanted pregnancies, abortion, and access to contraception.

Voting patterns

The report passed the first vote in the Committee (17 in favor, 7 against, and 7 abstaining), but in the plenary, it was referred back to Committee with 51% favoring the referral and 46% rejecting it (3% abstention).⁴ There was a significant level of cohesion in the S&D, Greens/EFA, and GUE/NGL groups, all rejecting the referral as well as in the EPP, ECR, and EFD groups, who favored sending the report back to the FEMM committee. The ALDE group was quite divided, with 26% voting for referral and 43% against.

The report on SRHR was then redrafted in the FEMM Committee, still with Estrela as rapporteur. It was only slightly modified and the second vote in Committee resulted in 19 votes in favor and 15 opposing. Importantly, and contrary to the case of the economic crisis analyzed earlier, the SRHR issue was highly contested already at the Committee level. The second version of the SRHR report was not accepted in plenary either. Instead, an alternative motion for resolution⁵ by the EPP and ECR groups jointly was adopted in a very tight vote (48% for, 47% against, and 5% abstentions) and thus formed the definite resolution of the EP on SRHR. It was a very short resolution with only three paragraphs, emphasizing that the formulation of health, SRHR, and sexual education policies was a competence of the member states. As official party position, S&D, ALDE, Greens/EFA, and GUE/NGL were against the resolution, and EPP, ECR, and EFD in favor. Most party groups (EPP, S&D, Greens/EFA, ECR, and GUE/NGL) voted in line with the party position (more than 90% cohesion), whereas the ALDE group was slightly more split on the issue with cohesion level of 80%.

Press releases

Similar to the debate on economic crisis, the political groups used press releases after the voting results. The S&D and Greens/EFA denounced the parliamentary process, which led to the final rejection of the SRHR report. Estrela was quoted in an S&D press release following the first vote, saying that the conservatives and the extreme right “used all the procedural tricks possible to avoid a new vote” accusing them of blocking the democratic process.

She was referring to the fact that the ECR group had called for the report to be referred back to Committee, as there was no majority position to be upheld in plenary. At the time both Estrela herself and Gustafsson (GUE/NGL, chairperson of the FEMM Committee) emphasized that the report had already been approved in committee and that the majority there would not change.

The parliamentary process was controversial in another sense as well as the climate of debate became very heated. A clash between right-wing MEPs, shouting and protesting loudly,⁶ and Estrela, accusing her right-wing colleagues of being intolerant to the opinion of others, ensued. Estrela argued that: “hypocrisy and obscurantism have been superimposed on the legitimate rights of women. You can shout but I will not be silent, do not intimidate me, do not intimidate me, I’m not afraid and I’m right.” These events show that the issue of the second report was personalized by the opponents to Estrela and the left wing of the Parliament clearly interpreted this in gendered terms, with Murphy (GUE/NGL) referring to the response to Estrela as a “macho shouting down.”

Furthermore, the left wing denounced lobbying which had been carried out in parallel with the parliamentary process:

MEPs have been bombarded with lobbying from an array of backward, anti-choice groups [...] This morning I got a letter which included a baby soother and a condom, implying that the report had something to do with forcing toddlers to use contraceptives (Murphy, GUE/NGL).⁷

These tensions were reflected in press releases as well: the lobbying campaign was criticized by the left wing for being “fallacious, misleading, and populist” (PES Women, 10/12/2013) and interpreted as being orchestrated by right wing parliamentary actors as well as conservative, Catholic movements together, thus emphasizing the opposition between left and right (Greens/EFA, December 11, 2013). It was perceived as part of electoralist strategies (EP elections were held five months later) as the campaign insisted on a “false fear of crossing the subsidiarity principle” (Mynár, S&D), partly recognized by Ulmer (EPP) when stating that “subsidiarity was the only chance to avoid the Estrela report.” The critique also took on a gendered dimension as oral and written explanations of votes by the S&D, GUE/NGL, Greens/EFA, and ALDE groups insisted on the “retrograde” and “reactionary” character of the process and its outcome. In this way, the parliamentary and extra-parliamentary processes together enhanced the level of contestation and the tensions between party groups.

The contestation over the issue of SRHR in the EP has increased over time and cuts across committee and plenary levels. The analysis of the debate shows that the notion of rights and whose rights to defend is the most questioned one. The issue is constructed in gendered terms in various ways as the health of the mothers is, at times, used as a way

to substitute the framing of the issue as the defense of gender equality and antidiscrimination. Furthermore, the right wing argues for member state competences in the area, invoking the principle of subsidiarity as a way to close the debate. Internal divisions within party groups came out in the Committee debate, especially, where an internal minority of the EPP group voiced arguments against the official line. This did not result in a significant lack of cohesion, however, in the voting. On the contrary, the ALDE group turned out to be more divided and less liberal on the issue than predicted, showing a lack of internal cohesion in the group. The entire process was controversial with strongly opposed groups, a very polarized and heated debate as well as visible and intense lobbying efforts by extra-parliamentary actors.

Conclusions

In this article, we have started to analyze an unexplored area namely gender and party politics at the EU level. Feminist EU studies have firmly established that the EP is the most gender equal actor of the EU institutions and plays a crucial role in advancing gender equality at the EU level. Our analysis renders these findings more nuanced and reveals the party group competition that underpins the presumed progressive gender equality discourse of the EP. We mapped out the consensus and contestation that gender equality constructions result in by focusing on two controversial policy debates in the EP, namely, gender and the economic crisis and the SRHR debates during the 2009–2014 legislature. Our explicit aim was to trace the complete policy process as opposed to merely analyzing either committee reports or parliamentary debates. Our analysis showed how such tracing of the EP debates revealed the party politics both between political groups and within them.

On the basis of previous research, we hypothesized that there is a high level of consensus in the EP and especially in the FEMM committee about what gender equality is and how it is best achieved. Our findings show that there are shared constructions about gender equality in the FEMM committee and across the party groups in the committee but these are highly issue specific and can change over time. For example, in the case of the economic crisis, there were initially high levels of consensus that resulted in in-depth analyses about the gendered impact of the crisis. Analyzing just the FEMM reports would illustrate this consensus as well as the shared constructions about gender equality. However, contestation between party groups increased over time when the economic crisis exacerbated and the overall political debate about the means to tackle it (austerity politics) intensified. Consensus about the importance of gender equality broke down along the left right axis. The debate on SRHR was split along the same axis but considerably more polarized and with a longer history of increased contestation over time.

Our analysis illustrated that the center-right and right parties were more conservative in their constructions of gender equality both in relation to economic crisis and SRHR, and the green-left was more progressive. However, there were internal splits between and within these groups as well. For example, in relation to the economic crisis the Green/EFA party group abstained on the third report indicating that it did not sign the more radical critique of the handling of the economic crisis and its gendered consequences. Importantly, each group that was split (Green/EFA and the EPP) had a small group of MEPs that vote for gender equality against the official party line. For example, in the case of the rejected report on gender equality and the economic crisis a significant minority of MEPs from the EPP group voted in favor of the report. A similar split in the case of SRHR points to the strong differences within the groups regarding SRHR and the way it should be handled at the European level. In the case of the EPP group, the split related to a few strong minority voices at Committee level, prioritizing individual gender equality positions against the official party line, whereas the ALDE group's internal division was less articulated at the level of debate and more so in the overall lack of cohesion in votings, favoring a less liberal approach to the SRHR issue than the official party line suggested. These splits and their size can be important for explaining the outcomes of EP reports on gender equality. We suggest that feminist EU studies scholars should pay attention to this as it raises questions about successful lobbying; who needs to be lobbied to raise the stakes for progressive gender equality politics. The higher degree of consensus in the FEMM committee than in plenary is interesting too, pointing to the existence of slightly stronger gender equality community at the Committee level.

In both cases, we find that contestation was exacerbated toward the end of the parliamentary term as electoral strategies came into play. In particular, gender equality was used instrumentally to argue for member state competences in an overall effort to eliminate or reduce EU intervention. Furthermore, in the case of the economic crisis, the stakes rose as the economic crisis increasingly dominated the political and public agenda, thereby also spilling over into strengthened contestation over gendered perspectives on the crisis. In the case of SRHR, it was particularly actors of the civil society who contributed to agenda setting and polarization over the issue in the wider public sphere. These findings show that the potential for advancing in gender equality policies is at stake in areas where gender constructions are disputed and, at the same time, it is necessary to situate and understand these disputes and contestations in a wider parliamentary and extra-parliamentary or public context.

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Notes

1. The political groups of the European Parliament appoint their own MEP coordinator for each parliamentary committee. The coordinator prepares the work of the political group within the committee in relation to positions in debates and voting and acts as spokesperson for the group.
2. Critical frame analysis is a method used to interpret how meaning is ascribed in policy-making processes, in this case, and how policy issues are problematized. The method identifies diagnostic and prognostic dimensions of policy frames, understood as an “organizing principle that transforms fragmentary or incidental information into a structured and meaningful problem, in which a solution is implicitly or explicitly included” (Verloo, 2005: 20).
3. Largely there is coherence in the argumentation of the political groups but we also find a few divergent opinions, such as for instance Swedish MEPs from EPP abstaining from voting and agreeing on the subsidiarity critique but not the prolife attitudes or individual MEPs from S&D on the prolife side as well as a few GUE/NGL and ALDE MEPs arguing for competence issue.
4. In the process, an alternative motion for resolution was presented by the EFD group. It focused on children’s rights, parents’ right and responsibility to educate, right to conscientious objection, the risk of postabortion trauma syndrome, the need to ensure prenatal and maternal health, promotion of family planning, and respect for member state competence. The motion for resolution was clearly rejected with 73% of the MEPs voting against it, 20% for and 7% abstaining. The EPP group was divided on the issue, with 80 MEPs voting in favor and a cohesion level within the group of only 42%.
5. Likewise, the EFD group presented an alternative motion, identical to the one presented and rejected in the first plenary vote. It was rejected again, this time with 79% of the votes against and 14% for (7% abstentions). A minority of the EPP MEPs (29) voted in favor of the motion.
6. Oral and written explanations of the votes from the EPP group especially also strongly criticizes Estrela’s attitude during the vote. She is called undemocratic and intolerant and accused of not respecting others’ opinions by insulting those who disagree. Lulling (EPP) notes that Estrela has a “rare talent of making reports which are adopted by a tight majority or rejected.”
7. Several MEPs brought the letter with soother and condom to the plenary to illustrate the lobbying efforts.

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Book reviews

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Kate Hudson, *The New European Left: A Socialism for the Twenty-First Century?* London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012; viii + 211 pp.; ISBN 9-780-230-248-762, £63.00 (hbk)

Reviewed by: Dan Keith, *University of York, UK*

This book builds on the author's earlier (Hudson, 2000) work, *European Communism Since 1989*. It sets out to analyse the emergence of what Hudson calls 'The New European Left' since the apparent demise of the Communist movement. Hudson traces how new European Left parties emerged out of the 'wreckage' of the communist movement in both Western and Eastern Europe and their electoral fortunes. The book claims that radical left-wing politics remains relevant in the 21st century and that left parties have become a 'resilient and effective force' (p. 98).

Hudson takes a generally positive view of the way in which radical left parties have changed their tactics and policies rather than embracing dissolution or defeatism. Given that the author has sought to establish a new left party in Britain called 'Left Unity', readers will not be surprised by the book's optimistic appraisal of the future of ideologically pluralistic radical left parties. However, the book is also prescient as it was published before the dramatic electoral success of several radical left parties in Europe. The book makes an important contribution in demonstrating how the left has changed by embracing a politics that is more open-minded towards feminism and ecology. *Die Linke* in Germany is assessed in terms of providing a potential model of programmatic adaptation and electoral success for other European Left parties.

Hudson also makes an important contribution to the growing but as yet underdeveloped literature on radical left parties. The author writes in an engaging and clear way and the book will appeal to readers with an interest in left-wing politics. The book will also be welcomed by scholars of the radical left including historians and political scientists for the rich description it provides on a number of left parties.

The New European Left includes chapters on the electoral fortunes of the radical left, its historic attempts to build a European movement and the emergence of the Party of the European Left (PEL). Chapters also focus on left parties in Germany, France, the Czech Republic, Italy and

Scandinavia. These chapters add to the limited literature on the historical development of these parties in English. The book is impressive in terms of studying a broad range of left parties. It identifies a number of similarities and differences that exist in the approaches that contemporary radical left parties take in promoting socialism.

Hudson's analysis provides insights as to how left parties have responded to developments in their national political systems, cuts by social democratic governments as well as globalization and European integration. Chapter 2 charts the regroupment of the European Left and Chapter 3 makes important advances in our knowledge of the development of the PEL. This explains the key programmatic positions and social policies of the PEL. A major strength of the book is its attempt to look beyond Western Europe to provide a pan-European account of the radical left.

The recent electoral success of Syriza in Greece adds support to the book's claim that ideologically pluralistic left parties offer potential for electoral success. The book presents a conceptualization of the "New European Left". In doing so, it presents a number of challenges for those studying the radical left. In particular, the book raises questions as to how we should best classify the ideological positions of contemporary radical left parties. Further research is needed to question whether Hudson's approach provides a better understanding of the radical left than attempts to identify different subgroups of the radical left developed by Luke March's (2012) *Radical Left Parties in Europe*.

This book is a great resource for those seeking to learn about the policy positions of left parties. Studies of the programmatic adaptation of radical left parties in Europe have generally struggled to identify whether 'internal' party organizational or 'external' party system factors have shaped programmatic adaptation. Hudson's explanations tend to emphasize external factors like changes made by social democracy and globalization. However, some political scientists will desire a more theorized explanation of the factors that have driven programmatic change in left parties. There is also a need for studies that identify the philosophical sources of left party thinking and the theories that they seek to put into practice.

The book concludes with a discussion of the global left, the World Social Forum and antiglobalization movement.

Hudson takes important steps in breaking down divisions between two research areas as she sheds light on the relations between left parties and social movements. Critics may argue that Hudson could go further in questioning why radical left parties still generally play a limited role in most European countries, despite their recent successes in Southern Europe. *The New European Left* makes significant inroads into enhancing our understanding of the politics and performance of several leading left parties.

It is an essential read for those studying and researching radical left politics.

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Theda Skocpol and Vanessa Williamson, *The Tea Party and the Remaking of Republican Conservatism*, New York, NY: Oxford University Press, 2012; 272 pp.: ISBN 9780199832637, US\$24.95 (hbk), 9780199975549, US\$18.95 (pbk)

Reviewed by: Robin Kolodny, *Temple University, USA*

Theda Skocpol and Vanessa Williamson's book on the Tea Party does a remarkably good job placing the Tea Party phenomenon in American politics despite its publication before the 2012 elections. Indeed, as I write this in the wake of the 2014 congressional primaries, I am struck by how their findings still hold true.

The study was carefully and thoughtfully researched at the beginning of the Tea Party emergence. Both authors were working on related projects (Skocpol about the Obama presidency, Williamson about grassroots activism around healthcare reform) and decided to join forces in the summer of 2010. The book is an intellectual history, so its organization is thematic instead of linear. Chapter topics include a profile of Tea Party adherents, their philosophical beliefs, the variety of organizations that emerged in 2009–2010, the media's role (specifically that of conservative Fox News) in fanning the flames of Tea Party sentiments and the Tea Party's influence on the Republican party. The result is a thoughtful examination of the contemporary landscape.

The authors make highly effective use of elite interviews and participant observation, creating a hysteria-free narrative about this segment of the US polity. At the start, the authors compare the current movement to that of 1964 presidential candidate Barry Goldwater supporters and to other "America First" movements that have emerged from time to time in US history. While today's Tea Party supporters may be farther right than supporters of these other groups, Skocpol and Williamson are clear to make the comparison context specific. Earlier right-wing movements were extreme for their times.

They find the Tea Partiers to be personally kind, even welcoming, fairly well-educated, and uncomfortable with, even threatened by, younger citizens. It does not take them

long to discover that the elite rhetoric does not match grass-roots sentiments all that well. This is especially clear in the realm of old-age benefits: Social Security and Medicare (national health insurance for those 65 and older). Grass-roots supporters see no problem in advocating fierce protection of these programs, which they feel they have "earned," while promoting the elimination of programs that they believe benefit "others."

Skocpol and Williamson are careful to contrast their interactions with grass-roots members with that of the nationally oriented groups such as the Tea Party Express and FreedomWorks. They show how the national groups are backed by wealthy conservatives who had previously been unable to influence the Republicans, specifically the Koch brothers who established FreedomWorks in 2004 (p. 103–104)! The presence of former House Republican Majority Leader Dick Armey as the "new face of the movement" invited journalists to project a national cast with "leaders" onto a disconnected set of local protests.

Fox News receives special mention for not only giving the Tea Party movement biased coverage, but also for drumming up stories about the Tea Party's success when none was in evidence. The authors find throughout their research that Tea Party members are not bothered to verify the facts on which they base their opinions. Some of the "facts" cited by Tea Party activists can be traced to specific shows on Fox News.

I am disappointed, however, by how far the authors steer around the question of race. They portray the Tea Party followers as reacting against racial and ethnic diversity broadly defined and a general feeling that Obama is more liberal than previous Presidents. While no one wants to answer a survey question saying that yes, they hate the President because he is Black, that does not mean it is not the truth. It is hard to take the "liberal" label at face value especially when we compare Obama to Bill Clinton. Clinton admitted to smoking marijuana, answered questions about his choice of underwear, first lied about and later admitted to extramarital affairs, and had a life story right out of reality TV. Obama, while also admitting to have smoked marijuana, converted to Christianity as an adult, had a loving and respectful relationship with his grandparents who partly raised him, and has no hint of scandal

surrounding his marriage. In terms of platform ideas, it is hard to see much, if any, difference between the two. If race does not explain the sudden appearance and intense venom of the Tea Party movement, I really can't see what else does.

Race can also explain why Clinton had the potential to woo conservative blue-collar voters while Obama cannot. Clinton was certainly a threat to Republican electoral prospects because these voters both agreed with Clinton's policy stances and related to him personally. Clinton's charm and relatability forced Republican majorities in the 1990s to work with him and create compromise legislation. In the

current climate, there is virtually no chance that conservative blue collar voters would abandon the Republican party—no matter how extreme—for an African American man who was a product of an interracial marriage (one member a foreigner), spent a good part of his youth living overseas, and has a middle name giving fuel to the rumor that he is a “Muslim.” In this sense, Obama is literally the right catalyst at the right time for this movement.

Skocpol and Williamson's book is an excellent start for any scholar looking to understand the contemporary Tea Party dynamics in the United States. Readers at any level will find the text engaging and thoughtful.

Benjamin von dem Berge, Thomas Poguntke, Peter Obert and Diana Tipei, *Measuring Intra-Party Democracy: A Guide for the Content Analysis of Party Statutes with Examples from Hungary, Slovakia and Romania*, Heidelberg: Springer, 2013; ix + 65 pp.: ISBN 978-3-642-36033-6, £35.99 (ebook), 978-3-642-36032-9, £44.99 (9pbk)

Reviewed by: Robin T Pettitt, *Kingston University, UK*

This is an excellent little book with great practical potential. The book presents a scheme for quantitatively measuring the level of internal democracy in a political party using party rules and content analysis.

Traditionally, when using quantitative content analysis the focus is very heavily on the text. The coding will often be by sentences (however defined), that is, each sentence in the document being analysed will be assigned a specific code. This book uses a slightly different approach. Instead of assigning each sentence a code, the analysis is centred around a series of coding questions, for example, ‘are the principles of intra-party democracy explicitly mentioned in the statute?’. Each question can be coded as YES; NO; or in some cases NS (not specified). Depending on the impact that the answer has on intra-party democracy, the answer will result in either 1 or –1 (in the case of NS a 0). 1 is indicative of intra-party democracy and –1 indicative of the lack thereof. Usually YES will result in a 1 and a NO in –1. The results of the 90 odd questions are then combined to provide an overall score ranging from 1 (most democratic) to –1 (least democratic).

The book also contains very detailed coding instructions for each question; a guide to identifying different bodies in party organizations and coded examples from Hungary, Slovakia and Romania. All of this together provides a ready-made tool that can be applied by researchers to their particular cases. This is not the first time this kind of thing has been tried (e.g. see the work of Pedersen (2010)). It is, however, the first time such a detailed and extensive scheme has been made available to researchers. For those

interested in intra-party democracy and sympathetic to this particular method of investigating it, this book is a real asset. Making this scheme for analysing party organizations available to researchers constitutes a real service to the academic community.

However, there are obviously also problems, two of which stand out in particular. The first is the issue of using party rules to measure the level of democracy in a political party. Party rules only show the formal side of an organization. These rules can be ignored, interpreted in different ways or have consequences that are not clear from the wording. It is a well-known argument that a seeming increase in democratic practices can in fact leave the leadership with greater control if the effect is to include a greater proportion of inactive, and often more pliant members, and thus watering down the influence of middle-level committed activists.

The book does address this issue at some length. The authors argue that despite the problem of a potential distance between formal rules and actual practice, such rules still tell us something important about how a party operates. In many ways, this argument is a rerun of that used by Katz and Mair to justify their focus on formal rules in the 1992 data handbook of party organizations. The book being reviewed here does not add substantially to that argument, although it is able to draw on several authors who have worked with party rules since the publication of the Katz and Mair work. So the problem remains but has at least been addressed. The extent to which this issue is sufficiently problematic to make a researcher reject the approach comes down to whether or not one buys the ‘yes, rules do not tell the whole story, but they are still important’ argument. The authors also, rightly, point out that examining the practice of internal party life is extremely resource intensive and at least using party rule books allows for quite extensive comparative analysis in a way a more in-depth approach would not be able to due to resource requirements.

The second issue is with the whole idea of quantifying democracy. There are significant methodological problems

with the notion that one can quantify something as amorphous and contested as 'democracy'. It is true that this is not the first project to quantify contested ideas. Freedom House's quantitative measure of freedom is equally problematic. That however does not make it any less of an issue. In addition, unlike the use of rule books, this is not a problem the authors address. Again, as with the use of party rules to measure democracy, the notion of quantifying democracy will not be a problem for a lot of people, but it will be a significant issue for many.

In short, this is an excellent contribution to the study of political parties. Its detailed description of the scheme for quantifying intra-party democracy makes it a very useful 'off the shelf' tool for researchers to deploy in their own research. There are serious problems with the approach chosen to analyse intra-party democracy. However, these

Alberto Simpser, *Why Governments and Parties Manipulate Elections*, New York: Cambridge University Press, 2013; xix + 282 pp.: ISBN 9781107030541, US\$90.00 (hbk)

Reviewed by: Miguel Angel Lara Otaola, *University of Sussex, UK*

In a speech for the 1995 election in Zimbabwe, Robert Mugabe asked the people to give his party 'a massive 99.9% vote to frighten away the fringe opposition'. Mugabe not only wanted to win, he wanted to intimidate the opposition and any other person or organization who might challenge the Zimbabwe African National Union-Patriotic Front or its predominant role in the country. This was not about gaining electoral victory (for which 50.1% of the vote would have sufficed) but total victory. In line with this, Alberto Simpser's *Why Governments and Parties Manipulate Elections* is a valuable study that shows us that electoral manipulation is about more than winning the election at hand.

As pointed out by the author, conventional wisdom, along with the existing literature, holds that the main objective of electoral manipulation is to win elections. As a result, this view states that manipulation is more likely to happen in close races (where electoral fraud can make the difference between winning and losing) and leads to small margins of victory. It must also be a clandestine activity kept in secret from the public to avoid punishment. However, as this book demonstrates, these ideas do not account for what really happens in many countries. Manipulation is often excessive and blatant. In addition, it frequently takes place in elections with large margins of victory: of all executive elections substantially manipulated in the last two decades, more than two in five were won by the manipulating party by a margin of victory exceeding 40% of the

problems are based on underlying methodological debates and are not problems with the book taken on its own merits. The problems are driven by the overall approach chosen and will only bother those who would not use such an approach in the first place. If you are sceptical about using party rule books to analyse party processes and with quantifying democracy you are unlikely to be convinced by this book. By contrast, if you are happy with using content analysis in this way, then this will be a superb tool with much to recommend itself.

Reference

Helene Hedboe P (2010) Differences and changes in Danish Party Organisations: Central Party Organisations versus Parliamentary Party Group Power. *The Journal of Legislative Studies*, 16: 233–250.

vote (p. 8). Manipulation is often used even when it is not needed to win. Why would parties heavily manipulate elections if victory is virtually secure? The answer is because manipulation can yield more benefits than simply winning an election. This is the main argument of this book.

The book is divided into eight chapters, in which Simpser explores issues of definition and measurement and presents an original and very complete data set with information about electoral manipulation for nearly 800 country-level elections between 1990 and 2007. Empirical analysis identifies the different patterns and correlates of electoral manipulation around the world and shows that the data do not fit existing notions on electoral manipulation. Simpser develops a theory of manipulation, highlighting its informational role and direct and indirect effects. This theory is then illustrated through a number of case studies, including Mugabe's Zimbabwe and Russia under Yeltsin and Putin. In addition, quantitative evidence is provided on the indirect effects of manipulation on the duration in office, on voter turnout and for the case of Mexico before the far-reaching electoral reforms of the 1990s. The conclusion highlights the practical implications of the theory for areas such as election monitoring and electoral reform.

Returning to the central thesis of the book, Simpser argues that electoral manipulation has direct and indirect effects. The former, as expected, are related to winning the election at hand. Indirect effects, however, concern the longer term consequences that can help consolidate the power of the manipulator. This is as electoral manipulation has certain informational properties that signify the 'attributes and capacities' of the manipulator. Therefore, manipulating excessively and blatantly can portray an image of power and strength, while minimal manipulation can do the opposite. This information, in turn, shapes the expectations and actions of key social and political players in favour of the manipulator. Some of these indirect effects include

influencing the future behaviour of voters, the electoral strategies of opposition parties (e.g. to quit and join the ruling party), and the political and electoral behaviour of elites and power brokers.

This makes me think of Mexico before its transition to democracy. During the PRI's (Institutional Revolutionary Party) heyday, this political party sought not only to win and manipulate elections but to cultivate an image of overwhelming power (in which gaining stunning electoral victories played a key role). The goal was to show that the PRI could not be beaten electorally – or politically. In fact, this led not only to its control of the executive but also of the judiciary, the legislature, state governorships, federal and local public administration, worker unions and even private companies. It has been said that Mexican presidents at this time had both constitutional and 'meta-constitutional' powers (Carpizo, 1979). All this happened while regular elections occurred in the country at local, state and national levels every 3 years.

Alexander Smith, *Devolution and the Scottish Conservatives*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2011; xi + 152 pp.: ISBN 978-0-7190-9556-6, paperback, £13.99.

Reviewed by: Lindsay Paterson, *University of Edinburgh, UK*

After the Scottish Conservative Party lost all its members of the UK Parliament at the 1997 general election, it struggled with what Alexander Smith calls in this book 'the politics of irrelevance'. Its declining, elderly and only intermittently active membership retreated – metaphorically or (in the affluent districts of south-west Scotland studied here) literally – to its bastions in 'the big hooses', seeming to confirm the caricatures painted by its main opponents in the Labour Party and the Scottish National Party (SNP) that the Tories were staffed by landed elites who could engage in local politics only by hiding their ideological colours.

One significant aftermath of that 1997 result was the final stages of the very long process which led to the setting up of a Scottish Parliament in 1999, endorsed in the referendum in September of that year. Although later coming to accept such autonomy within the United Kingdom, the Conservatives opposed it in the referendum, reinforcing the sense of being marginalized. Even in the south-west – an area not at all unsympathetic to the party – the vote in favour of a parliament was fairly clear, though (at 61%) far short of the 74% across Scotland as a whole, and this was one of only two (of 32) local council areas that voted by a small majority against giving the parliament taxation powers.

Dr Smith spent the period leading up to the second elections to that new parliament – in May 2003 – 'embedded'

This book successfully challenges conventional wisdom about electoral manipulation and fosters reflection on the role of elections, especially in authoritarian regimes. Readers will first understand there is much more to win from electoral manipulation than elections themselves. After all, ruling parties are not only interested in simply holding office but also in increasing their grip on power. Second, readers will realize that this book provides another reason to challenge the legitimacy of electoral authoritarian regimes. In countries such as Angola, Iran, Syria or Turkmenistan, overwhelming electoral results are not the reflection of a high degree of popular support (as incumbents claim they are). Now, we know that these supermajorities not only hide some degree of manipulation but the desire of total control (or of 99.9% control in the case of Mugabe).

Reference

Carpizo J (1979) *El presidencialismo mexicano*. Mexico: Siglo XXI.

(as he puts it, p. 56) with the local Conservative Party in Dumfries, working with them as an activist and even, towards the end of the campaigning, becoming an informal press officer (p. 75). Since the election coincided with election to the local council, much of the activity which he anthropologically observed was of that intensely local kind which electoral politics the world over is obsessed by. He thus had a unique opportunity to observe first-hand the relationship between ideology and community, through the eyes of a social group that believed it had lost legitimacy in a society where it had once commanded deep loyalty.

As a story, this works lucidly. Dr Smith explains what he appositely calls 'banal activism', the escape into leafleting and canvassing as a substitute for political thought, in which there is a concentration on 'questions of form, method and organisation rather than ... policy issues that might have been viewed as controversial' (p. 80). Much of his text is then spent on matters that are rarely brought to the fore in discussion of politics. A self-deprecatory human warmth comes across from the camaraderie which he describes, the sort of sentiment which explains why politics appeals to that minority who make up the cadre of persistent activists – despite the bickering over tactics, the meetings in cramped rooms, the sense of being against the world. There is even (and perhaps especially in an area of small towns and long distances) a strange sense of commonality with activists in other parties.

There is also a sense of mistaken self-doubt. There is absolutely no trace in the Conservatives with whom Dr Smith worked of that messianic belief by activists who think that they have history on their side. In fact here the very opposite is the case, a kind of self-pitying insistence on their perceived irrelevance, buoyed up only by the

contact with the outside world of normal politics that flowed from the local party's three elected legislators – David Mundell and Alex Fergusson in the Scottish Parliament and Peter Duncan in the UK Parliament (the Scottish Conservatives' sole regained seat there in the election which followed the 1997 debacle). Especially through Mr Mundell and Mr Fergusson, we get a glimpse of, in fact, growing relevance, something which strengthened subsequently, and thus confirming these men's astute understanding of what a minority party can achieve in a new structure of multilevel governance. As Dr Smith notes, but does not really integrate into his account, Mr Fergusson became Presiding Officer of the Scottish Parliament from 2007 to 2011, and Mr Mundell became a minister in the post-2010 UK coalition government (having won a seat at Westminster in the 2005 election) and then in the post-2015 UK Conservative government. But perhaps all that gradual success is much more readily seen in retrospect, now that the Scottish Conservatives have clawed their way back to relevance by coming second to the SNP (and thus ahead of Labour) in the 2016 Scottish Parliament elections.

Even the outcomes of the electoral contests that are the focus of the activities described in the book hardly showed a party as marginal as its members purported to believe. Mr

Fergusson defeated a strong SNP challenge in his seat in the west of the region, and Mr Mundell was only quite narrowly beaten by Labour in the town of Dumfries: vote shares of 38% and 37% are not those of a minor party. Mr Mundell was re-elected to the Scottish Parliament through the regional list element of the additional member system.

So if there is a criticism of this insightful and thoughtful book, it is that it takes too much on trust its subjects' self-definitions. It would have been interesting to have had Dr Smith's understanding of why the activists whom he befriended could be so bewildered: perhaps his anthropological embedding was just not distanced enough. Despite his conclusion that the party sought renovation after its disasters by burying itself in the 'everyday and mundane', the striking thing might have been how oblivious this was to what was happening around them. Perhaps, indeed, that is the main conclusion of Dr Smith's work – that there is a self-delusion of failure which can be just as strong as the more familiar self-deception of the ideologue. If the Scottish Conservatives are finally reviving – buoyed up by taking the lead of the unionist majority that was expressed through the referendum on Scottish independence in 2014 – then the story that has taken them there may well be about their superseding the almost artificial sense of irrelevance which Dr Smith presents.

